

GARDEN REFERENCE

# West of Ireland Planting Guide

Soil, sun, and species notes for gardening on the  
Atlantic coast

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AVAILABLE MATERIALS

Clay soil · Multipurpose compost · Ericaceous compost · Horticultural bark · Horticultural  
grit · Small pebbles · Vermiculite · Perlite

## DRAINAGE: YOUR MOST IMPORTANT RULE

West of Ireland clay soil is typically heavy, poorly draining, and mildly acidic to neutral (pH ~6.0–7.0). The Atlantic climate brings very high rainfall year-round. **The single most important thing you can do for the majority of these plants is improve drainage before planting.**

**General clay soil recipe for most non-ericaceous plants:**

- Dig each planting hole at least twice the width and depth of the rootball
- Mix the excavated clay 50/50 with multipurpose compost
- Add 20–30% horticultural grit by volume to that mix
- After planting, mulch with horticultural bark (5–7cm), keeping mulch away from stems/crowns
- Test your soil pH before planting — west of Ireland soils vary considerably

## HOW TO USE YOUR MATERIALS

| Material             | Best Use                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                              |
|----------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Clay soil            | Base for all in-ground plantings                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                      |
| Multipurpose compost | Soil amendment for most plants (50/50 with clay)                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                      |
| Ericaceous compost   | Blueberry · Heather · Lingonberry · Cranberry · Japanese Maple (partial) · Star Magnolia (partial) · Deer Fern · Hydrangea macrophylla (for blue flowers) · Japanese Skimmia · Dicksonia antarctica (partial) · Japanese Camellia · Prickly Heath                                                     |
| Horticultural bark   | Surface mulch for all in-ground plants (5–7cm), keep away from stems                                                                                                                                                                                                                                  |
| Horticultural grit   | Drainage improver mixed into clay (20–30%); vital for rosemary, lavender, roses, peonies, pasqueflower, fritillaria, creeping juniper, dianthus, phlox subulata, bearded iris, dwarf iris, alliums, freesia, ixia, sempervivum, saxifrage, campanula saxifraga, edelweiss, auricula, siberian statice |
| Small pebbles        | Base drainage layer in pots; decorative surface mulch for Mediterranean herbs and rock plants                                                                                                                                                                                                         |
| Vermiculite          | Seed-starting; mix into potting compost for moisture retention                                                                                                                                                                                                                                        |
| Perlite              | Drainage improver in pots (10–20%); especially for rosemary, lavender, blueberry, acidanthera, herbs                                                                                                                                                                                                  |

## THE PLANTS

Groups: A = Annual Flowers | B = Bulbs | C = Climbers & Wall Plants | F = Fruit Trees & Shrubs | G = Groundcover & Creeping Plants | H = Kitchen Herbs & Vegetables | P = Ornamental Perennials | S = Shade & Woodland Plants | T = Ornamental Trees & Shrubs | W = Pond & Water Plants

### GROUP A: ANNUAL FLOWERS

#### A2. Cornflower (*Centaurea cyanus*)

 Reference photo: [Cornflower — view source](#)

**Light:** ☀ Full sun.

**Soil needs:** Well-drained soil; pH 6.0–7.5. Tolerant of poor soil.

**Soil prep:** Improve clay with compost and grit; avoid over-rich ground, which produces weak, floppy stems.

**Planting depth:** Sow seed 1–2cm deep, spring (or autumn for earlier flowers).

**Spacing:** 20–30cm between plants; annual, self-seeds

**Fertiliser:** Little required.

**Companions:** Poppies, love-in-a-mist, briza maxima — classic hardy-annual cutting garden mix, and good for pollinators.

**West of Ireland:** Easy, reliable, and long-flowering through summer if deadheaded regularly. Self-seeds freely; the classic bright blue form is most traditional, though pink and white forms are also available.

### A3. Greater Quaking Grass (*Briza maxima*)

 **Reference photo:** [Briza Maxima — view source](#)

**Light:** ☀ Full sun.

**Soil needs:** Well-drained soil; pH 6.0–7.5. Tolerant of poor soil.

**Soil prep:** Improve clay with compost and grit.

**Planting depth:** Sow seed 5mm deep in spring, direct or in trays.

**Spacing:** 15–20cm between plants; annual, self-seeds

**Fertiliser:** Little required; over-feeding produces floppy growth.

**Companions:** Cornflower, poppies, love-in-a-mist — classic annual cutting-garden/cottage border mix; the papery seed heads are excellent for dried arrangements.

**West of Ireland:** An easy hardy annual ornamental grass with distinctive nodding, oat-like seed heads that rustle in the breeze — self-seeds readily, so allow some heads to drop if you want it to return next year, or deadhead if not.

### A4. Lacy Phacelia (*Phacelia tanacetifolia*)

 **Reference photo:** [Phacelia — view source](#)

**Light:** ☀ Full sun.

**Soil needs:** Most well-drained soils including clay; pH 6.0–7.5. Very unfussy.

**Soil prep:** Minimal — often used as a green manure/cover crop precisely because it grows so easily on poor or heavy ground.

**Planting depth:** Sow seed 1cm deep, spring through summer for successional flowering.

**Spacing:** 20–30cm between plants; annual, sow successionaly

**Fertiliser:** None required.

**Companions:** Excellent sown alongside or near vegetable beds and fruit — one of the very best plants for attracting bees and other pollinators, and can be dug in as a green manure to improve soil structure.

**West of Ireland:** Fast, easy, and highly valuable for pollinators, with fuzzy purple-blue flower heads. Sow a patch near the vegetable garden or fruit trees to boost pollination, or use as a soil-improving green manure between crops.

### A5. Love-in-a-Mist (*Nigella damascena*)

 **Reference photo:** [Love-in-a-Mist — view source](#)

**Light:** ☀ Full sun to 🌞 partial shade.

**Soil needs:** Well-drained soil; pH 6.0–7.5.

**Soil prep:** Improve clay with compost and grit.

**Planting depth:** Sow seed 1cm deep, spring or autumn, direct where it is to flower (dislikes root disturbance from transplanting).

**Spacing:** 20cm between plants; annual, self-seeds freely

**Fertiliser:** Light balanced feed if soil is poor; otherwise little required.

**Companions:** Cornflower, poppies, briza maxima — classic hardy annual cutting garden mix; the inflated seed pods are attractive dried.

**West of Ireland:** Airy, feathery foliage surrounds delicate blue, white or pink flowers in summer, followed by ornamental seed pods. Self-seeds very readily — thin seedlings if too dense, or deadhead before seed pods form if self-seeding isn't wanted.

### A6. Poppies (*Papaver* spp., e.g. *P. rhoeas*, Shirley poppies)

 **Reference photo:** [Poppies — view source](#)

**Light:** ☀ Full sun.

**Soil needs:** Well-drained soil; pH 6.0–7.5. Tolerant of poor soil.

**Soil prep:** Improve clay with compost and grit; avoid over-rich ground.

**Planting depth:** Sow seed on the surface or just barely covered (needs light to germinate), spring or autumn, direct where it is to flower.

**Spacing:** 15–20cm between plants; annual, self-seeds freely

**Fertiliser:** Little required.

**Companions:** Cornflower, love-in-a-mist, briza maxima — classic hardy annual meadow/cutting garden mix.

**West of Ireland:** The classic annual field/Shirley poppy self-seeds very freely and is one of the easiest hardy annuals to naturalise in a sunny border or wildflower patch. (Note: perennial Oriental poppies, *Papaver orientale*, are a different, longer-lived border plant with similar sun/drainage needs if a non-annual poppy is wanted instead.)

## A7. Sweet Peas (*Lathyrus odoratus*)

 **Reference photo:** [Sweet Peas — view source](#)

**Light:** ☀ Full sun.

**Soil needs:** Moist but well-drained, fertile soil; pH 6.0–7.5.

**Soil prep:** Dig in plenty of compost — sweet peas are hungrier and thirstier than most annuals. Improve drainage with grit if the site is very wet.

**Planting depth:** Sow seed 2cm deep, spring (or autumn under cover for earlier, stronger plants).

**Spacing:** 15–20cm between plants against support

**Fertiliser:** Balanced liquid feed weekly once flowering begins; a high-potash feed (tomato feed) encourages more blooms.

**Companions:** Climbing roses, clematis — grow up the same wall/trellis for a long season of colour; also a classic vegetable-garden companion, attracting pollinators.

**West of Ireland:** Fragrant, prolific climbing annual for a sunny wall, trellis or wigwam of canes — regular picking (rather than letting pods form) is the key to a long flowering season. Needs support to climb by tendrils and consistent moisture at the roots.

## GROUP B: BULBS

### B1. Acidanthera (*Gladiolus murielae*)

 **Reference photo:** [Acidanthera — view on Wikipedia](#)

**Light:** ☀ Full sun — essential. Plant in the warmest, sunniest spot available.

**Soil needs:** Fertile, well-drained, pH 6.0–7.0. Plant on sharp sand base.

**Planting depth:** 10–16cm deep on a bed of sharp sand. Plant April–May. Lift after first frosts; dry and store frost-free.

**Spacing:** 15–20cm between corms

**Fertiliser:** Balanced bulb fertiliser or tomato feed fortnightly from when shoots appear until flowering in August–September. Feed until foliage begins to die down.

**Companions:** Salvias, dahlias, gladioli, ornamental grasses, white agapanthus. Elegant near deep purple salvias or against dark evergreen hedging.

### B2. Anemone (spring: *A. blanda*, *A. nemorosa*; Japanese/autumn: *A. × hybrida*)

 **Reference photo:** [Anemone — view on Wikipedia](#)

**Spring anemones:** **Light:** 🌤 Partial shade (woodland conditions). *A. nemorosa* is native Irish.

**Spacing:** Spring Anemone: 10cm between corms. Japanese/Autumn Anemone: 45–60cm between plants; can spread. **Planting depth:** 5–8cm deep, in autumn (September–October). Soak de Caen corms 24 hours before planting. Fully hardy — never needs lifting. **Fertiliser:** Not heavy feeders. Light balanced fertiliser in spring. Allow foliage to die back naturally. **Companions:** Snowdrops, bluebells, foxgloves in woodland-edge bed.

**Japanese/Autumn anemones:** **Light:** 🌤 Partial shade to full sun. Excellent in semi-shaded spots. **Planting depth:** At pot level; plant potted rhizomes in spring. Fully hardy — never needs lifting. **Fertiliser:** Balanced fertiliser in spring and compost mulch. Low-maintenance.

**Companions:** Hostas, astilbe, hellebores (all share moisture and partial-shade requirements). Can spread — be aware in small borders.

### B3. Fritillaria (Fritillaria spp.)

 Reference photos: [Checkered Lily](#) · [Crown Imperial](#) · [Fox's Grape Fritillary](#) · [F. michailovskyi](#) · [Persian Fritillary](#)

| Species                                  | Latin name              | Height    | Flowering | Planting depth            | Notes                                                                                                              |
|------------------------------------------|-------------------------|-----------|-----------|---------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Checkered Lily (Snake's Head Fritillary) | <i>F. meleagris</i>     | 20–30cm   | April–May | 10cm deep                 | Checkered purple-and-white nodding bells; tolerates damp clay far better than the rest — the easiest to naturalise |
| Crown Imperial                           | <i>F. imperialis</i>    | 80cm–1.2m | April–May | 20–30cm deep, on its side | Tall crown-topped spike of orange, red or yellow bells; needs alkaline, sharply drained soil                       |
| Fox's Grape Fritillary                   | <i>F. uva-vulpis</i>    | 15–30cm   | April     | 10cm deep                 | Small plum-brown bells with a grey bloom; needs a dry winter position                                              |
| <i>F. michailovskyi</i>                  | <i>F. michailovskyi</i> | 10–20cm   | April–May | 8–10cm deep               | Small maroon bells tipped bright yellow; the most demanding of the group for drainage                              |
| Persian Fritillary                       | <i>F. persica</i>       | 60cm+     | May       | 15–20cm deep, on its side | Tall spike of small plum-purple bells; needs alkaline, sharply drained soil like Crown Imperial                    |

**Light:** ☀ Full sun for all — *F. meleagris* also tolerates partial shade.

**Soil needs:** pH 6.0–8.0 depending on species. *F. meleagris*: moist but reasonably drained, tolerates damp clay. All others (*imperialis*, *uva-vulpis*, *michailovskyi*, *persica*): free-draining soil essential, and *imperialis/persica* need it neutral to alkaline; none tolerate waterlogging.

**Soil prep:** *F. meleagris*: improve clay with compost; heavy grit is less critical given its preference for damper ground. The rest: improve clay generously with 25–40% horticultural grit (30% for *imperialis* and *persica*, worked in over a 35–40cm depth with grit at the base of the hole); a raised bed, trough or pot gives the most reliable results for *uva-vulpis* and *michailovskyi* on heavy west of Ireland clay.

**Planting depth:** Plant all in autumn. *F. meleagris*: 10cm deep. *F. uva-vulpis*: 10cm deep. *F. michailovskyi*: 8–10cm deep. *F. imperialis*: 20–30cm deep, on its side. *F. persica*: 15–20cm deep, on its side. All pointed end up except where planted on their side to stop water pooling in the hollow crown top. Fully hardy — none need lifting in the west of Ireland climate, though small bulbs of *meleagris*, *uva-vulpis* and *michailovskyi* dry out quickly out of the ground, so plant promptly after purchase, and *imperialis/persica* resent disturbance once settled.

**Spacing:** 8–10cm between bulbs for the smaller species; 20–25cm for Persian Fritillary; 25cm for Crown Imperial.

**Fertiliser:** Light bonemeal at planting for all. Crown Imperial and Persian Fritillary are hungrier: balanced bulb fertiliser as shoots emerge, plus a high-potash liquid feed once or twice before flowering. The rest need very little beyond the initial bonemeal.

**Companions:** *F. meleagris*: snowdrops, daffodils, damp border or pond-margin planting. *F. uva-vulpis*, *F. michailovskyi*: other species fritillarias, dwarf iris, crocus in a sharply drained rockery. *F. imperialis*, *F. persica*: tulips, alliums, euphorbia, wallflowers.

**West of Ireland:** *F. meleagris* is one of the easiest bulbs to naturalise here, thriving in the moist climate. The rest are trickier: *F. imperialis* and *F. persica* are ⚠ challenging on wet clay and are most reliable in a raised bed or large gritty container, while *F. uva-vulpis* and *F. michailovskyi* need a raised bed, trough or pot rather than open clay ground to survive winter wet.

### B4. Corn Lily (Ixia spp.)

 Reference photo: [Ixia — view source](#)

**Light:** ☀ Full sun.

**Soil needs:** Light, very free-draining soil; pH 6.0–7.0. Corms rot in wet, heavy clay.

**Soil prep:** Improve clay heavily with grit, or grow in containers of free-draining compost for best results.

**Planting depth:** 8–10cm deep, pointed end up, in spring (March–April) once frost risk has passed.

**Spacing:** 5–8cm between corms

**Fertiliser:** Low-nitrogen bulb/liquid feed while in leaf; avoid feeding once foliage dies back.

**Companions:** Freesia and other South African corms with similar sun and drainage needs.

**West of Ireland:** Borderline hardy (RHS H3) — in most of the west of Ireland best grown in pots that can be given a sheltered, dry position over winter, or lifted after the foliage dies down in autumn and stored dry and frost-free like gladioli, replanting the following spring. Wiry stems of star-shaped flowers in early summer.

## B5. Crocus (*Crocus* spp.)

 **Reference photo:** [Crocus — view on Wikipedia](#)

**Light:** ☀ Full sun preferred for most types. *C. speciosus* 'Albus' tolerates light shade under deciduous shrubs. Spring crocuses: sunny border, lawn or pot. Autumn crocuses: as for spring types.

**Soil needs:** Well-drained to gritty, poor to moderately fertile, pH 6.0–7.5. On heavy clay, add a handful of horticultural grit beneath each corm to prevent waterlogging. Spring types tolerate summer moisture if drainage is right; specialist alpine types prefer dry summers and are best grown in pots.

**Soil prep:** Add 20–25% grit to clay planting areas. In lawns, use a bulb auger or trowel to make individual holes; place a little grit beneath each corm.

**Planting depth:** To naturalise *C. tommasinianus* and *C. chrysanthus* plant 7–10cm deep in small groups. In garden lawns, Dutch hybrids have bigger corms and can go deeper at 12cm. Space individually about 9cm apart. Plant with pointed tip facing upward in September–November (autumn-flowering species such as *C. speciosus* are planted a little earlier, in August). A 20cm pot holds 15–20 corms comfortably — layer them 5–8cm deep, almost touching, for a dense display. Use a mix of multipurpose compost and horticultural grit (roughly 3:1) for sharp drainage. Fully hardy — corms are left in the ground permanently and never need lifting.

**Spacing:** 8–9cm between corms

**Fertiliser:** Feed after flowering when leaves are still in active growth. Very little feeding required otherwise. A light balanced bulb fertiliser while foliage is green is sufficient. Allow foliage to yellow before removing — this feeds the corm for the following year.

**Companions:** For a layered spring display in grass, combine crocus with snowdrops (January–February) and daffodils (March–April). The three together give nearly four months of colour before the grass needs cutting. Muscari, squill, and winter aconites are also superb companions. Excellent beneath deciduous shrubs. Do not mow for at least 6 weeks after flowering in lawns. ⚠ Squirrels and mice dig up freshly planted corms — cover with chicken wire for the first season.

**Pot size:** Use pots at least 15cm deep with drainage holes. A 20cm pot holds 15–20 corms comfortably.

**West of Ireland:** Crocuses naturalise magnificently in Irish gardens. *C. tommasinianus* (the 'Tommie' — early February, pale lilac) self-seeds prolifically and forms spreading carpets within a few years. Autumn-flowering types (*C. speciosus*, *C. sativus* — saffron crocus) extend interest into October–November.

## B7. Daffodils (*Narcissus* spp.)

 **Reference photo:** [Daffodils — view on Wikipedia](#)

**Light:** ☀ Full sun to partial shade. Naturalise under deciduous trees.

**Soil needs:** Well-drained, pH 6.0–7.0. Add grit at base of each planting hole.

**Planting depth:** 15cm (3× bulb height). Plant September–October. Fully hardy — never needs lifting.

**Spacing:** 10–15cm between bulbs

**Fertiliser:** Balanced bulb fertiliser after flowering while foliage still green. Allow foliage to yellow for at least 6 weeks before removing. Autumn compost mulch on naturalised drifts.

**Companions:** Snowdrops (succession), tulips (follow on), Pulmonaria and muscari for ground cover. Naturalise magnificently under apple trees.

## B8. Dwarf Iris (*Iris reticulata*)

 **Reference photo:** [Dwarf Iris — view source](#)

**Light:** ☀ Full sun.

**Soil needs:** Free-draining soil essential; pH 6.0–7.5. Bulbs rot in wet, heavy clay over winter.

**Soil prep:** Improve clay generously with 30–40% horticultural grit; excellent drainage is the key requirement. Raised beds, troughs or pots are often more reliable than open clay ground.

**Planting depth:** 8–10cm deep, pointed end up, in autumn. Fully hardy — never needs lifting.

**Spacing:** 5–8cm between bulbs

**Fertiliser:** Bonemeal or bulb fertiliser at planting (autumn). Low-nitrogen liquid feed while in leaf after flowering, to build next year's bulb.

**Companions:** Snowdrops, crocus and dwarf daffodils for a very early, low-growing spring display; also excellent at the front of a border or in rockeries.

**West of Ireland:** One of the earliest bulbs to flower, often in February. Best in a very free-draining spot such as a raised bed, trough or pot given typical clay drainage; can struggle to persist in heavy wet ground.

#### Br1. Freesia (Freesia spp.)

 **Reference photo:** [Freesia — view source](#)

**Light:** ☀ Full sun.

**Soil needs:** Light, free-draining soil; pH 6.0–7.0. Corms are tender/half-hardy and dislike cold, wet clay.

**Soil prep:** Improve clay with grit and compost, or grow entirely in containers of multipurpose/free-draining compost for reliability.

**Planting depth:** 5–8cm deep, pointed end up, in spring (March–April) once frost risk has passed.

**Spacing:** 5–8cm between corms

**Fertiliser:** Balanced liquid feed fortnightly once in growth, until foliage yellows after flowering.

**Companions:** Ixia, other South African corms with similar needs; good in mixed pots with other tender bulbs.

**West of Ireland:** Not reliably frost-hardy (RHS H2–H3) — in most west of Ireland gardens best grown in containers that can be moved under cover, or lifted and stored dry over winter like gladioli. Fragrant, long-lasting cut flowers.

#### Br2. Iron Cross (Oxalis tetraphylla 'Iron Cross')

 **Reference photo:** [Iron Cross — view source](#)

**Light:** ☀ Full sun to 🌤 partial shade.

**Soil needs:** Well-drained soil; pH 6.0–7.0.

**Soil prep:** Improve clay with compost and grit.

**Planting depth:** 5cm deep, growing point up, in spring (April–May) once frost risk has passed.

**Spacing:** 10–15cm between tubers; lift over winter

**Fertiliser:** Balanced liquid feed monthly through the growing season.

**Companions:** Front-of-border and container planting with other low, colourful summer bulbs such as ixia or dwarf dahlias.

**West of Ireland:** Grown for its distinctive four-lobed leaves marked with a dark maroon "iron cross" pattern and pink summer flowers. Tuber is not reliably frost-hardy — lift and store dry over winter like a dahlia, or grow in containers that can be moved under cover.

#### Br3. Lilies (Lilium spp.)

 **Reference photo:** [Lilies — view on Wikipedia](#)

**Light:** 🌤 Partial sun to partial shade. Most prefer heads in sun, roots shaded by low plants.

**Soil needs:** Well-drained, pH 6.0–7.0. Drainage essential.

**Soil prep:** Compost and 20–25% grit. Place 5cm grit at base of each hole.

**Planting depth:** 15cm (3× bulb height) on a bed of grit, in autumn (September–October) or early spring. Fully hardy — never needs lifting.

**Spacing:** 15–30cm between bulbs

**Fertiliser:** Balanced bulb fertiliser as shoots emerge. Tomato feed fortnightly from bud formation until flowering. Continue feeding until foliage yellows. Do not remove foliage until it dies back naturally.

**Companions:** Hostas, geraniums, low salvias (shade the soil around bulbs). Roses (lilies fill the midsummer gap). Alliums in the same border.

#### Br4. Martagon Lily (Lilium martagon)

 **Reference photo:** [Martagon Lily — view source](#)

**Light:** 🌤 Partial shade to sun; happier in dappled woodland-edge light than full baking sun.

**Soil needs:** Well-drained, humus-rich soil, tolerant of neutral to slightly alkaline conditions; pH 6.0–7.5.

**Soil prep:** Compost and 20% grit at planting; unlike many lilies it tolerates heavier soil reasonably well once drainage is adequate.

**Planting depth:** 15cm deep (3× bulb height), on a bed of grit, in autumn (September–October) or early spring. Fully hardy — never needs lifting.

**Spacing:** 20–30cm between bulbs

**Fertiliser:** Balanced bulb fertiliser as shoots emerge; otherwise undemanding once established. Do not remove foliage until it dies back naturally.

**Companions:** Naturalises well among shrubs, in light woodland or a shady border with hostas, ferns and hellebores — unlike many lilies, martagon lily is happy in part shade.

**West of Ireland:** More shade-tolerant and better suited to naturalising under trees/shrubs than most garden lilies, with distinctive nodding, "turk's cap" recurved flowers in early-mid summer. Slow to establish — settle for two to three years before flowering well, but long-lived once happy.

## Bi5. Native Bluebells (*Hyacinthoides non-scripta*)

 **Reference photo:** [Native Bluebells — view on Wikipedia](#)

**Light:**  Partial shade preferred; ideal under deciduous trees where it flowers before the canopy closes. Tolerates full sun to full shade.

**Soil needs:** Moist but well-drained, humus-rich soil; slightly acid, pH 6.0–6.8. Tolerates clay reasonably well if not waterlogged.

**Soil prep:** Improve clay with leaf mould or compost; heavy grit amendment is not essential.

**Planting depth:** 8cm deep, pointed end up, in autumn.

**Spacing:** 8–10cm between bulbs

**Fertiliser:** Little required. Bonemeal at planting is sufficient; leave foliage to die back naturally each year to feed the bulb.

**Companions:** Ferns, hostas, primroses, wood anemones — classic native woodland-floor planting under deciduous trees and shrubs such as hawthorn, rowan or Japanese maple.

**West of Ireland:** Ireland's native bluebell, distinguished from the non-native Spanish bluebell by its narrower, more strongly recurved deep violet-blue flowers borne on one side of a nodding stem, its sweet scent, and creamy-white (not blue) pollen. Naturalises readily in a woodland-style planting and is excellent for pollinators. Spreads by both offsets and self-seeding, forming drifts over time, but is less aggressive and better behaved in a garden setting than Spanish bluebell.

 Harmful if eaten; wear gloves when handling bulbs, as the sap can irritate skin.

## Bi6. Ornamental Onion (*Allium* spp.)

 **Reference photos:** [Allium](#) · [Allium giganteum](#) · [Allium moly](#) · [Allium oreophilum](#) · [Allium neapolitanum \(cowanii\)](#) · [Allium nigrum](#) · [Allium atropurpureum](#)

| Species               | Latin name                                             | Flower colour      | Height   | Flowering                | Planting depth | Notes                                                                                               |
|-----------------------|--------------------------------------------------------|--------------------|----------|--------------------------|----------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Giant Onion           | <i>A. giganteum</i>                                    | Purple             | 1.2–1.5m | Late spring–early summer | 20cm deep      | Huge globes to 15cm across; RHS AGM; the classic tall border allium                                 |
| Golden Garlic         | <i>A. moly</i>                                         | Bright yellow      | 25–30cm  | Late spring              | 8–10cm deep    | Star-shaped flowers in loose clusters; spreads readily, almost naturalising                         |
| Ostrowsky's Onion     | <i>A. oreophilum</i>                                   | Rose-pink          | 15–20cm  | Late spring              | 8–10cm deep    | Loose clusters on short stems; good rockery/front-of-border allium                                  |
| Naples Garlic         | <i>A. cowanii</i> (syn. <i>A. neapolitanum</i> )       | White              | 20–30cm  | Early–mid spring         | 8–10cm deep    | Fragrant star flowers; flowers earlier than the rest; slightly less reliably hardy — see note below |
| Allium 'Nigrum'       | <i>A. multibulbosum</i> 'Nigrum' (= <i>A. nigrum</i> ) | White, dark centre | 60–90cm  | Late spring–early summer | 15cm deep      | Unusual open, spike-like flower head rather than a tight ball                                       |
| Purple-flowered Onion | <i>A. atropurpureum</i>                                | Deep maroon-purple | 80cm–1m  | Late spring–early summer | 20cm deep      | Smaller, darker blooms than Giant Onion; a strong eye-catcher                                       |

**Light:**  Full sun for all.

**Soil needs:** Free-draining soil; pH any, but bulbs rot in waterlogged clay, so drainage is essential. All tolerate loam, sand, clay and stony ground provided it drains.

**Soil prep:** Improve clay with 25–30% horticultural grit before planting; raised beds or mounded planting help on heavy soil.



**Planting depth:** Plant all in autumn (mid to late autumn is ideal). Roughly 2–3× the bulb's own depth, pointed end up (about 20cm for Giant Onion's large bulbs, 8–10cm for the smaller species). Space bulbs about twice the bulb's diameter apart. All are fully hardy and, once planted, are left in the ground permanently — none need lifting in the west of Ireland climate. *A. cowanii* is the one partial exception: as a Mediterranean species it is slightly less robustly hardy than the others, so in colder inland gardens (rather than the milder coastal west) it benefits from a sheltered spot or a winter mulch, though it is not usually necessary to lift it.

**Spacing:** 10–20cm between bulbs for the smaller species; 25–30cm for Giant Onion and *A. 'Nigrum'*/*atropurpureum*.

**Fertiliser:** Bonemeal or bulb fertiliser at planting. Balanced liquid feed as foliage emerges in spring, stopped once flowering finishes.

**Companions:** Roses (alliums are classic rose-border companions and can help deter some pests), peonies, irises, ornamental grasses. The smaller species (moly, oreophilum, cowanii) suit rockeries and gravel gardens; the taller ones (giganteum, 'Nigrum', atropurpureum) suit borders and cut-flower beds.

**West of Ireland:** All flower in late spring—for *A. cowanii* it's notably earlier, into March–April. Excellent in pots for good drainage on wet clay sites; leave foliage to die back naturally to feed next year's bulb.

## B18. Ranunculus (*Ranunculus asiaticus*)

 **Reference photo:** [Ranunculus — view on Wikipedia](#)

**Light:** ☀️ Full sun to partial shade.

**Soil needs:** Well-drained, fertile, pH 6.0–7.0. Tubers rot in wet clay.

**Soil prep:** Compost and 20–30% grit. Plant on a bed of grit.

**Planting depth:** 5–8cm deep, claws pointing downward. Soak tubers 2–4 hours before planting. Plant in spring (February–April). Not reliably hardy — lift after flowering, dry, and store frost-free over winter, or treat as a seasonal pot plant.

**Spacing:** 15–20cm between tubers

**Fertiliser:** Balanced liquid fertiliser every 2 weeks once shoots appear. Liquid tomato feed from bud formation until flowering. Container: monthly balanced liquid feed.

**Companions:** Pansies and violas in cool-season containers. Muscari, fritillaria, spring anemones flower simultaneously.

**West of Ireland:** ⚠️ Treat as seasonal pot plant — lift after flowering, dry, and store frost-free.

## B19. Snowdrops (*Galanthus nivalis*)

 **Reference photo:** [Snowdrops — view on Wikipedia](#)

**Light:** 🌞 to 🌑 Partial to full shade. Under deciduous trees is ideal — winter/spring light before canopy forms.

**Spacing:** 8–10cm between bulbs

**Soil needs:** Humus-rich, moisture-retentive but well-drained, pH 5.5–7.0. Best planted "in the green."

**Planting depth (dry bulbs):** 10cm deep, 8–10cm apart, in autumn (September–October). **Planting depth (in the green):** At same depth as growing; plant in spring, just after flowering, while leaves are still on. Fully hardy either way — never needs lifting.

**Fertiliser:** Light balanced fertiliser in early spring while foliage is still green. Annual leaf mould or compost mulch. Allow foliage to die back completely before removing.

**Companions:** Hellebores (classic January–March winter combination). Aconites, early narcissus, cyclamen coum in February–March. Underplant shrubs (forsythia, lilac) with snowdrops for colour before the shrubs flower.

## B20. Snowflake (*Leucojum aestivum* — Summer Snowflake; *L. vernum* — Spring Snowflake)

 **Reference photo:** [Snowflake — view on Wikipedia](#)

**Note on naming:** Despite its common name, the Summer Snowflake, *Leucojum aestivum*, flowers in mid-spring and goes dormant during summer, not in summer itself. It features nodding, bell-shaped white flowers with green-tipped tepals, and is softly chocolate-scented.

**Light:** ☀️ Full sun to partial shade. They prefer soil that stays cool and damp, making them ideal for borders, woodland edges, or near water.

**Soil needs:** Organically rich, medium moisture, well-drained soils in full sun to part shade. Adapts to clay soils. Plants need consistent moisture during the spring period of growth and bloom. pH 5.5–7.0. They are notably tolerant of wet and clay soils.

**Soil prep:** Add generous compost. Plants will naturalize well by bulb offsets. Bulbs are best left undisturbed once set in the ground. Mulch to retain summer moisture.

**Planting depth:** Plant dry bulbs 8–10cm deep in autumn in moist, humus-rich soil. Plant bulbs in autumn about 10cm deep and 8–10cm apart. Water well after planting and keep the soil evenly moist, especially during dry spells in spring. Allow the foliage to die back completely after flowering to feed the bulbs for next year's growth.

**Spacing:** 8–10cm between bulbs

**Fertiliser:** Light balanced bulb fertiliser in spring while foliage is green, or annual compost top-dressing around the planting area. Low-maintenance once established.

**Companions:** Mixes beautifully with other spring flowering bulbs. Tolerates boggy spots and will do well on the edges of natural ponds. Spectacular in large sweeping drifts. Excellent with daffodils, snowdrops, hellebores, and moisture-loving plants. Plant at pond edges where it will naturalise freely.

**Pot size:** 30–40cm diameter, 25cm+ deep; multipurpose compost.

**West of Ireland:** This attractive bulb is ideal for naturalising in areas of grass or planting in generous clumps throughout the front of borders and rockeries. The moist Irish conditions and winter-spring wet suit it perfectly. An excellent naturalistic bulb for damp areas that can be challenging for other bulbs.

## B2I. Spring Sowbread (*Cyclamen coum*)

 **Reference photo:** [Spring Sowbread — view source](#)

**Light:** 🌞 Partial to full shade; ideal under deciduous trees and shrubs.

**Soil needs:** Well-drained, humus-rich soil; pH 6.0–7.5. Dislikes waterlogging around the tuber.

**Soil prep:** Improve clay with leaf mould/compost and grit.

**Planting depth:** Tuber just below the soil surface (2–3cm), flattest side down, planted in late summer to early autumn (August–September) while dormant. Fully hardy — never needs lifting.

**Spacing:** 10–15cm between tubers

**Fertiliser:** Light balanced feed as leaves emerge in autumn/winter. Top-dress with leaf mould annually.

**Companions:** Snowdrops, winter aconite, hellebores — classic winter/early-spring woodland-floor planting.

**West of Ireland:** Flowers from midwinter into early spring, often alongside snowdrops, with attractively marbled leaves persisting after flowering. Once settled it self-seeds gently to form a carpet under trees and shrubs — avoid disturbing the tubers once established.

## B22. Tulip (*Tulipa* spp.)

 **Reference photos:** [Tulip](#) · [Turkestan Tulip](#) · [Whittall's Tulip](#) · [Wild Tulip](#)

| Species                | Latin name             | Height  | Flowering      | Planting depth             | Notes                                                                                                |
|------------------------|------------------------|---------|----------------|----------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Tulip (garden hybrids) | <i>Tulipa</i> spp.     | 30–60cm | April–May      | 20cm deep (3× bulb height) | The familiar large-flowered garden tulip; rots readily in wet clay                                   |
| Turkestan Tulip        | <i>T. turkestanica</i> | 10–15cm | February–March | 10cm deep                  | Up to a dozen small white, yellow-centred star flowers per bulb; one of the earliest tulips          |
| Whittall's Tulip       | <i>T. orphanidea</i>   | 15–20cm | Mid-spring     | 10–15cm deep               | Copper-orange star flowers, one to four per stem; reliably perennial                                 |
| Wild Tulip             | <i>T. sylvestris</i>   | 20–30cm | Mid-spring     | 10–15cm deep               | Fragrant, nodding, buttercup-yellow; more shade- and damp-tolerant than the rest, spreads by stolons |

**Light:** 🌞 Full sun essential for all — except Wild Tulip, which tolerates partial shade as a woodland-edge species.

**Soil needs:** pH 6.0–7.5. Well-drained soil essential for garden hybrids, Turkestan Tulip and Whittall's Tulip, all of which rot in wet winter clay. Wild Tulip is the exception, tolerating damper, more clay-rich conditions than the others.

**Soil prep:** Improve clay with compost and 20–30% horticultural grit for garden hybrids, Turkestan Tulip and Whittall's Tulip; raised beds or pots give the most reliable results on heavy west of Ireland ground. For Wild Tulip, heavy grit amendment is less critical.

**Planting depth:** Plant all in autumn (November is ideal for garden hybrids, to reduce tulip fire disease risk; the species tulips can go in a little earlier). Garden hybrids: 20cm deep (3× bulb height). Turkestan Tulip: 10cm deep. Whittall's Tulip: 10–15cm deep. Wild Tulip: 10–15cm deep. All pointed end up. The three species tulips are fully hardy and never need lifting. Garden hybrid tulips are also hardy, but in Ireland's cool, wet climate many gardeners lift the bulbs after the foliage dies back in early summer, dry them off and replant in autumn, as this improves the reliability of repeat flowering more than leaving them in permanently damp ground; treating hybrids as annuals and replanting fresh bulbs each year is also common practice here.

**Spacing:** 8–10cm between bulbs for the three species tulips; 10–15cm for garden hybrids.

**Fertiliser:** Light bonemeal at planting for the species tulips; otherwise little required. Garden hybrids benefit from a high-potash bulb fertiliser in early spring as shoots emerge, and a balanced feed after flowering while the foliage is still green if being kept for a second year.

**Companions:** Garden hybrids: forget-me-nots, wallflowers, daffodils, alliums, stocks. Turkestan Tulip: crocus, dwarf iris and other very early bulbs. Whittall's Tulip: crocus, grape hyacinth and other species tulips. Wild Tulip: naturalises well in grass or light woodland with daffodils.

**West of Ireland:** The three species tulips (Turkestan, Whittall's and Wild) naturalise far more reliably here than showier garden hybrids, which are best treated as a shorter-lived display unless lifted and dried each summer.

## B26. Yellow Star-of-Bethlehem (*Gagea lutea*)

 **Reference photo:** [Gagea — view source](#)

**Light:** 🌤️ Partial shade to sun; naturally a woodland-floor plant, flowering before the canopy closes.

**Soil needs:** Moist, humus-rich, base-rich (near-neutral to slightly alkaline) soil; pH 6.5–7.5. Never allow it to dry out during the growing season.

**Soil prep:** Improve clay with compost/leaf mould; avoid heavy grit amendment, since this species prefers more moisture-retentive ground than most bulbs.

**Planting depth:** 5–8cm deep, pointed end up, in autumn. Fully hardy — never needs lifting.

**Spacing:** 5–8cm between bulbs

**Fertiliser:** Light bonemeal at planting. Otherwise little required; allow foliage to die back naturally.

**Companions:** Snowdrops, wood anemones and other early woodland-floor bulbs.

**West of Ireland:** A delicate, early-flowering native British woodland bulb; note that it is genuinely rare across Britain and Ireland and its status as a wild Irish native is uncertain — most sources describe it as a rare/scattered Great Britain species rather than confirmed native to Ireland, so plants sold for gardens are nursery-propagated stock rather than "native Irish" in origin. Grow in a shaded, undisturbed woodland-style corner.

## GROUP C: CLIMBERS & WALL PLANTS

### C1. Blue Passion Flower (*Passiflora caerulea*)

 **Reference photo:** [Passiflora \(Blue Passion Flower\) — view source](#)

**Light:** ☀️ Full sun, sheltered from cold wind — a south- or west-facing wall is ideal.

**Soil needs:** Most well-drained soils including clay; pH 6.0–7.5. Good drainage is essential — this is the hardiest passion flower but still dislikes waterlogged roots in winter.

**Soil prep:** Dig hole twice the rootball width against the wall base. Mix excavated clay 50/50 with compost and 20–30% grit.

**Planting depth:** At nursery soil mark, 30–45cm from the wall, angled towards support.

**Spacing:** 2–3m between plants against wall/fence

**Fertiliser:** Balanced general or high-potash liquid feed monthly through the growing season. Avoid excess nitrogen, which favours leaf growth over flowers.

**Companions:** Climbing roses, clematis and honeysuckle on the same wall/structure for a long season of colour.

**West of Ireland:** RHS hardiness H4 (hardy to about –5 to –10°C) — reliably hardy in most west of Ireland gardens with wall shelter, though may be cut back by hard frost and regrow from the base. Needs a sturdy support (trellis or wires) to climb by tendrils.

### C2. Clematis (*Clematis* spp.)

 **Reference photo:** [Clematis — view on Wikipedia](#)

**Light:** 🌤️ Roots prefer shade (cover with stone or tile), stems flower best in sun or dappled light. Evergreen types prefer sheltered, sunny, south-facing wall.

**Soil needs:** Well-drained, fertile, neutral to slightly alkaline, pH 6.5–7.5.

**Soil prep:** Mix clay 50/50 with compost plus 20% grit. Shade the root zone.

**Planting depth:** Groups 2 & 3 large-flowered: 10–15cm DEEPER than pot; *C. montana* (Group 1): 8–10cm; Evergreen types: at pot level only.

**Spacing:** 60–90cm between; cool roots essential

**Fertiliser:** Balanced slow-release fertiliser in early spring. From April: high-potash liquid feed (tomato feed) fortnightly until August. Feed regularly — clematis are hungry. Do not feed after August.

**Companions:** Climbing roses on the same wall (classic combination). Clematis through other shrubs. Late-flowering Group 3 through roses for second flush of colour.

**Species for the west of Ireland:** All of the following are hardy and well suited to the Atlantic climate; pruning group is noted for each.

| Species               | Latin name            | Height   | Flowering                | Planting depth                    | Notes                                                                                                                                                |
|-----------------------|-----------------------|----------|--------------------------|-----------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <i>C. montana</i>     | <i>C. montana</i>     | 8–10m    | Late spring              | 8–10cm deep (Group 1)             | The most vigorous of the six, covering itself in single, four-petalled white or pink flowers; best given a large wall, tree or shed to scramble over |
| <i>C. alpina</i>      | <i>C. alpina</i>      | 2–3m     | April                    | 8–10cm deep (Group 1)             | Compact, with nodding, lantern-shaped single flowers (four narrow sepals) in blue, purple, pink or white; good for a windy or north-facing spot      |
| <i>C. macropetala</i> | <i>C. macropetala</i> | 2–3m     | Mid-late spring          | 8–10cm deep (Group 1)             | Very similar to <i>C. alpina</i> in size and season, but the flowers look "double": extra narrow petal-like staminodes fill the centre               |
| <i>C. viticella</i>   | <i>C. viticella</i>   | 3–4m     | Midsummer–autumn         | 10–15cm deeper than pot (Group 3) | Small, nodding, open bell-shaped flowers in purple, red or pink; naturally resistant to clematis wilt, a reliable choice on damp Irish sites         |
| <i>C. tangutica</i>   | <i>C. tangutica</i>   | 3.5–4.5m | Late summer–early autumn | 10–15cm deeper than pot (Group 3) | Bright yellow, nodding lantern-shaped flowers followed by large, silvery, fluffy seedheads that persist into winter                                  |
| <i>C. terniflora</i>  | <i>C. terniflora</i>  | 3–6m     | Late summer–autumn       | 10–15cm deeper than pot (Group 3) | The latest to flower, with small, star-shaped, fragrant white flowers in large sprays; extremely vigorous, so give it plenty of room                 |

### C3. Climbing Honeysuckle (*Lonicera periclymenum*)

 **Reference photo:** [Climbing Honeysuckle — view on Wikipedia](#)

**Light:** ☀️ to 🌞 Full sun to partial shade. Woodland-edge habit: roots shaded, stems growing into light.

**Soil needs:** Most soils; prefers moist, humus-rich.

**Soil prep:** Hole the same size as rootball. Mix in compost. Firm in and mulch.

**Planting depth:** At pot level.

**Spacing:** 1.5m between plants

**Fertiliser:** Balanced general fertiliser in spring (Growmore) or manure mulch. Liquid tomato feed fortnightly in summer encourages flowering. Avoid excessive nitrogen.

**Companions:** Climbing roses, clematis (classic combination). Plant near windows or doorways for evening fragrance. Native woodbine is a superb wildlife plant.

### C4. Climbing Hydrangea (*Hydrangea anomala* subsp. *petiolaris*)

 **Reference photo:** [Climbing Hydrangea — view on Wikipedia](#)

**Light:** 🌑 to 🌞 North or east-facing walls are ideal — will grow and flower in shade that defeats most climbers. Full sun tolerated if soil stays consistently moist. Self-clinging via aerial roots; slow to start but ultimately vigorous (can reach 10–15m). RHS hardiness rating: H5 (to -15°C).

**Soil needs:** Fertile, moist but well-drained soil, pH 6.0–7.0. Tolerates clay, loamy and sandy soils. Dislikes waterlogged or excessively dry conditions.

**Soil prep:** Dig hole twice as wide and the same depth as the rootball. Mix in compost. If against a wall or fence, allow a 45cm gap between plant and wall (rain shadow). Mulch well. Space 60cm+ between plants.

**Planting depth:** At pot level. Can tolerate slightly deeper planting as it forms shoot-like roots on buried stem.

**Spacing:** 45cm from wall; 60cm+ between plants

**Fertiliser:** Needs little feeding for the first three years — do not feed during establishment. After year three: balanced slow-release fertiliser in early spring if leaves appear yellow; otherwise a single spring application of balanced granular feed is sufficient. Annual mulch with compost in late summer. Low-maintenance overall.

**Companions:** Grows beautifully with ivy on north-facing walls for year-round coverage. Ferns at its base (same moisture preference). Shade-tolerant hostas and hellebores beneath. Invaluable for dark walls where most climbers fail.

**West of Ireland:** Exceptional plant for the Irish climate. One of the very few climbers that genuinely thrives on cold, north-facing or shaded walls. The moist Atlantic climate suits it perfectly. Slow in the first 2–3 years but can ultimately cover an entire house wall.

### C5. Climbing Roses (*Rosa*, climbing cultivars)

 **Reference photo:** [Climbing Roses — view on Wikipedia](#)

**Light:** ☀ Full sun preferred — at least 6 hours.

**Soil needs:** Fertile, well-drained, pH 6.0–7.0. Never plant where a rose previously grew.

**Soil prep:** Double-dig (50–60cm deep). Mix clay 50/50 with compost and 20% grit. Position at least 45cm from wall.

**Planting depth:** Graft union just below soil level.

**Spacing:** 45cm from wall; 2–3m between plants

**Fertiliser:** Specialist rose fertiliser in late March and again in early June. Liquid high-potash feed fortnightly May–August. Stop feeding by late August. Annual bark or manure mulch.

**Companions:** Clematis (trained together on the same wall). Lavender at base. Alliums, salvia, hardy geraniums as foreground.

### C6. Hardy Grapes (*Vitis vinifera*)

 **Reference photo:** [Hardy Grapes — view on Wikipedia](#)

**Light:** ☀ Full sun — south-facing wall essential. Without maximum sun, fruit will not ripen.

**Soil needs:** Well-drained, pH 6.0–6.5. Neutral to slightly alkaline preferred; mulch to keep soil moist.

**Soil prep:** Clay/compost/grit plus coarse gravel at base. At least 20cm from wall.

**Planting depth:** At pot depth; graft above soil.

**Spacing:** 1.2–1.5m between vines; 20cm from wall

**Fertiliser:** Balanced fertiliser with potassium in early spring. High-potash liquid feed fortnightly through summer. Do not overfeed with nitrogen. Grapevines on somewhat lean soil often fruit better.

**Companions:** Lavender, rosemary, garlic, hyssop at base. Good air circulation is critical in Irish conditions to reduce fungal disease risk.

#### Your varieties:

**'Phoenix'** — A mid-season white dessert and wine grape with large bunches of pale green fruits. Bred in Germany; its most important attribute for west of Ireland growing is its excellent built-in resistance to both powdery mildew and downy mildew, making it one of the most reliable outdoor grapes in the UK and Ireland. Hardy and very productive. Harvest: mid-September. One of the very best choices for Irish conditions (source: RHS outdoor cultivation guide; Pomona Fruits; Roots Plants).

**'Regent'** — A vigorous, disease-resistant red/blue-black dual-purpose grape for wine-making, juice or dessert eating. Originally bred in Germany (Chambourcin × Müller-Thurgau parentage). Bunches of large, dark red grapes mature to blue-black in early autumn; foliage turns red and purple in autumn. Excellent resistance to fungal diseases including downy mildew; slightly less resistant to mildew in unusually humid seasons. Hardy to northern European conditions. Harvest: September–October depending on season. RHS recommends growing in full sun in well-drained, humus-rich, neutral to slightly alkaline soil (RHS plant profile, *Vitis* 'Regent').

**'Boskoop Glory'** (also sold as 'Gloire of Boskoop') — A very popular and reliable outdoor dessert and wine grape developed in the Netherlands in the 1950s; a hybrid between *V. vinifera* and *V. labrusca*. Vigorous, disease-resistant and very cold-tolerant — one of the hardiest outdoor grape varieties available, RHS Award of Garden Merit holder. Large bunches of sweet, blue-black, seedless grapes ripen in early autumn (typically late August–September). Suitable for outdoor cultivation almost anywhere in the UK and Ireland. Leaves turn shades of red and purple in autumn. Can grow to an impressive 10m high and 4m wide. ⚠ Harmful to dogs if eaten. (Source: RHS plant profile *Vitis* 'Boskoop Glory'; Wikipedia; Roots Plants; Marshalls Garden.)

### C7. Hops (*Humulus lupulus*)

 **Reference photo:** [Hops — view on Wikipedia](#)

**Light:** ☀ Full sun to partial shade. Full sun produces more vigorous growth and larger cones.

**Soil needs:** Rich, moist, well-drained, pH 6.0–8.0. Tolerates clay well.

**Soil prep:** Dig and enrich generously with compost. Heavy feeders.

**Planting depth:** Rhizome 5–8cm deep; pot-grown plants at pot level.

**Spacing:** 1–1.5m between plants

**Fertiliser:** High-nitrogen fertiliser in spring, then balanced fertiliser with potassium once flowering begins. Thick compost or manure mulch each spring. Container: balanced liquid feed monthly throughout the growing season.

**Companions:** Climbing roses, clematis, ornamental grasses. Golden hop ('Aureus') looks spectacular against dark-foliaged plants (yew, holly).

#### C8. Ivy (*Hedera helix* / *H. hibernica* — native Irish ivy)

 **Reference photo:** [Ivy — view on Wikipedia](#)

**Light:** 🌑 Full shade to 🌞 full sun. One of the most light-tolerant plants. In deep shade variegated forms lose markings; green forms thrive.

**Soil needs:** Almost any soil including heavy clay, pH 5.0–8.0.

**Soil prep:** Minimal — basic compost addition to planting hole.

**Planting depth:** At pot level.

**Spacing:** 30–50cm between plants

**Fertiliser:** Little required. Balanced slow-release in spring if plant appears weak. Annual bark mulch. Container: balanced liquid fertiliser monthly during the growing season.

**Companions:** Native *H. hibernica* is one of Ireland's most important wildlife plants — nesting habitat, late nectar, winter berries. Grows beautifully under trees alongside ferns, snowdrops, and bluebells. With Virginia creeper on walls for year-round interest.

#### C9. Kiwi (*Actinidia deliciosa* 'Jenny')

 **Reference photo:** [Kiwi — view source](#)

**Light:** 🌞 Full sun to partial shade. Best fruiting in full sun; a south- or west-facing wall gives the most reliable cropping in Ireland.

**Soil needs:** Fertile, moist but well-drained soil, pH 6.0–7.0. Sandy loam is ideal; dislikes waterlogging, so on clay, drainage improvement is essential.

**Soil prep:** Dig a generous hole at least 60cm wide and 45cm deep, 45cm out from the wall or fence. Mix the excavated clay 50/50 with multipurpose compost and 20–25% horticultural grit to guarantee free drainage at the root zone. Install a strong permanent support (trellis, wires or pergola) at planting time — the vine is vigorous and support is far harder to add later. Mulch generously with bark after planting to retain moisture and suppress weeds.

**Planting depth:** At pot level; do not bury the crown. Plant in spring once frost risk has passed (April–May).

**Spacing:** 3–5m between plants, trained against a wall or over a sturdy pergola.

**Fertiliser:** Balanced granular fertiliser (e.g. Growmore) in early spring as buds swell, then a high-potash liquid feed (tomato feed) fortnightly from May to August. Do not feed after August. Mulch annually with well-rotted compost each spring.

**Companions:** Climbing roses, wisteria or clematis on adjacent structures. Lavender and rosemary at the base suit its preference for a warm, sheltered spot; garlic or chives nearby help deter aphids.

**Pruning:** Prune in late winter to establish a framework, then again in summer to control vigorous growth. Fruit forms on the current season's lateral shoots — shorten these to 4–6 leaves beyond the last fruit cluster each summer.

**Hardiness & pot growing:** Hardy to about -10°C to -15°C once established; young plants need frost protection over their first winter. ⚠️ Can be grown in a large container (60–80L minimum) but fruits far less freely than in the ground.

**West of Ireland:** 'Jenny' is self-fertile, removing the need for a second pollinator plant, which makes it the practical choice for most gardens here. Kiwi is at the northern edge of its reliable fruiting range in Ireland, so a sheltered, sun-warmed wall is essential and a modest crop is realistic rather than a heavy one.

#### C10. Tufted Vetch (*Vicia cracca*)

 **Reference photo:** [Vicia — view source](#)

**Light:** 🌞 Full sun to 🌞 partial shade.

**Soil needs:** Most soils including clay; pH 6.0–7.5. Tolerant and unfussy, as a nitrogen-fixing legume.

**Soil prep:** Minimal — very adaptable. Improve heaviest clay with compost if desired.

**Planting depth:** At pot level, or sow seed directly 1–2cm deep in spring.

**Spacing:** 20–30cm between plants; scrambles via tendrils

**Fertiliser:** None required — like other vetches, it fixes its own nitrogen. Avoid rich feeding, which encourages excess soft growth.

**Companions:** Grasses, other wildflower meadow and hedgerow species; scrambles happily through shrubs or a wildlife-friendly fence/trellis via tendrils.

**West of Ireland:** A native climbing/scrambling wildflower with clusters of blue-purple pea flowers, valuable for bees and other pollinators. Best suited to a wildflower area, informal hedge or meadow planting rather than a formal border, as it can spread and scramble vigorously.

## C11. Virginia Creeper (*Parthenocissus quinquefolia*)

 **Reference photo:** [Virginia Creeper — view on Wikipedia](#)

**Light:** ☀ Full sun to partial shade. Autumn colour more vivid in sunnier positions.

**Soil needs:** Wide range including clay, pH 5.5–7.5.

**Soil prep:** Dig twice the rootball, backfill with clay/compost mix.

**Planting depth:** At pot level.

**Spacing:** 1.5–3m between plants

**Fertiliser:** Low-maintenance. Balanced general fertiliser in spring. Annual bark mulch. In poor soils, slow-release granular fertiliser provides sufficient nutrition for the season.

**Companions:** Ivy on same wall for year-round coverage. Late-flowering clematis. Good companion for climbing roses (extends season of interest).

## C12. Wisteria (*Wisteria sinensis* / *W. floribunda*)

 **Reference photo:** [Wisteria — view on Wikipedia](#)

**Light:** ☀ Full sun — south- or west-facing wall essential. Flowers very poorly in shade.

**Soil needs:** Well-drained, fertile, pH 6.0–7.0.

**Soil prep:** 60cm wide, 40cm deep, at least 45cm from wall base. Clay/compost/grit blend over a wide area.

**Planting depth:** At pot level; graft union above soil. Buy grafted plants — seed-grown can take 15–20 years to flower.

**Spacing:** 45cm from wall; 3m between plants

**Fertiliser:** High-potash fertiliser (tomato feed) from spring through early summer — avoid nitrogen (produces leaves, not flowers). Light dressing of bonemeal in spring. Do not feed after midsummer.

**Companions:** Climbing roses on adjacent wall, alliums and irises at its feet, spring bulbs at the base. Do not plant near drains or gutters.

# GROUP F: FRUIT TREES & SHRUBS

## F1. Apple Tree 'Baya Marisa' on P22 Rootstock (*Malus domestica*)

 **Reference photo:** [Apple Tree 'Baya Marisa' on P22 Rootstock — view on Wikipedia](#)

**About P22:** A Polish rootstock (M.9 × Common Antonovka cross). Ultimate height 2–3m; width 100–125cm at maturity; fruits September–October. Requires permanent staking for life. Good resistance to root rots (a key advantage on Irish clay). Harvest September–October (per gardens4you.ie listing).

**Light:** ☀ Full sun essential — at least 6 hours daily.

**Soil needs:** Well-drained, moderately fertile, pH 6.0–7.0. Good root rot resistance on wet clay.

**Soil prep:** Dig wider and deeper than the root system. Break up clay beneath. Mix excavated clay 50/50 with multipurpose compost over a broad area. Keep a 60cm weed-free circle around the base permanently.

**Planting depth:** Graft union (bulge near stem base) at or just above soil level. Plant to the nursery soil mark.

**Spacing:** 1–1.5m between trees; permanent stake

**Fertiliser:** Balanced fruit tree fertiliser (Growmore or specialist fruit feed) each February. Liquid high-potash feed (tomato feed) fortnightly from late spring to midsummer. Do not feed after July. Bonemeal in the planting hole at planting.

**Companions:** Chives and garlic deter aphids (P22 is susceptible to woolly apple aphid). Nasturtiums attract beneficial insects. Plant two or more apple varieties for cross-pollination.

**West of Ireland:** Permanent staking essential against Atlantic winds.

## F2. Blackberries (*Rubus fruticosus* agg.)

 **Reference photo:** [Blackberries — view source](#)

**Light:** ☀ Full sun to 🌤 partial shade for best fruiting.

**Soil needs:** Most moist, well-drained soils including clay; pH 5.5–7.0. One of the most clay-tolerant fruiting plants.

**Soil prep:** Dig hole twice the rootball width. Mix excavated clay 50/50 with compost.

**Planting depth:** At nursery soil mark.

**Spacing:** 2–3m between plants against wires

**Fertiliser:** Balanced general fertiliser (Growmore) in spring. Annual mulch with compost.

**Companions:** Raspberries and other cane fruit with similar needs; avoid planting near wild bramble, which can cross-pollinate and revert vigour.

**West of Ireland:** Extremely easy and productive on Irish clay — thornless cultivars (e.g. 'Loch Ness', 'Oregon Thornless') are more manageable than wild bramble for a garden setting. Provide a sturdy wire support and tie in new canes each summer; cut back fruited canes after harvest.

## F3. Blackcurrant (*Ribes nigrum*)

 **Reference photo:** [Blackcurrant — view on Wikipedia](#)

**Light:** ☀ Full sun to partial shade — tolerates shade better than other currants.

**Soil prep:** Double dig; compost generously; 15–20% grit on heavy clay.

**Planting depth:** 5–7cm deeper than nursery mark. Cut all stems to 10cm after planting.

**Spacing:** 1.2–1.5m between plants

**Fertiliser:** High-nitrogen fertiliser in early spring. Again after harvest. Generous compost or manure mulch each winter. Potassium deficiency (brown leaf edges) common — use balanced feed with potassium.

**Companions:** Alliums, garlic, nasturtiums nearby; redcurrant, gooseberry in the same bed.

## F4. Blueberry (*Vaccinium corymbosum*)

 **Reference photo:** [Blueberry — view on Wikipedia](#)

**Light:** ☀ Full sun to partial shade. More berries in full sun.

**Soil needs:** Ericaceous, pH 4.0–5.5. Use ericaceous compost only. Rainwater preferred for watering.

**Pot size:** Start in 40cm diameter pot; scale up every 2–3 years. Final container: minimum 50 litres (~60cm diameter, 45–60cm deep). One blueberry per pot. Heather and lingonberry compatible at edges of a wide trough (same pH).

**Planting depth:** At pot level.

**Spacing:** 1 plant per pot; 60cm between pots

**Fertiliser:** Use only ericaceous liquid fertiliser fortnightly April–August. Top-dress with fresh ericaceous compost in spring. Sulphur chips to maintain acidity over time.

**Companions:** Heather, lingonberry, cranberry, other *Vaccinium*. Dedicated ericaceous bed with rhododendrons and azaleas if naturally acidic area.



#### F5. Cherry 'Athos' (*Prunus avium* 'Athos')

 **Reference photo:** [Cherry — view on Wikipedia](#)

**About 'Athos':** A patio cherry bush bred over some 60 years of crossbreeding, and unusual in that it grows on its own roots rather than being grafted onto rootstock. Self-pollinating, so a single plant is enough for fruit. Produces many medium-sized, very dark red, sweet cherries, harvested June–July depending on the season. Very winter-hardy and not particularly disease-prone. Bears fruit within two to four years of planting. In a pot it stays compact (roughly 100–150cm); in open ground it reaches around 200–250cm (source: schramas.com).

**Light:** ☀ Full sun essential — at least 6 hours daily.

**Soil needs:** Well-drained, sandy soil with a pH of 5.5–7.5 is ideal for cherries generally; 'Athos' is not fussy but dislikes waterlogging.

**Soil prep:** Dig wider and deeper than the root system. Mix excavated clay 50/50 with multipurpose compost and 20–30% horticultural grit for drainage. In a pot, use a container at least 30–40cm in diameter with good drainage holes, filled with a free-draining multipurpose compost mix.

**Planting depth:** At the same depth as in its nursery pot; plant in spring or autumn once frost risk is low. Since 'Athos' grows on its own roots rather than a graft, there is no graft union to keep above soil level.

**Spacing:** 1–1.5m if planted in the open ground; a single plant is fine in a large pot on a patio.

**Fertiliser:** Balanced fruit tree fertiliser (Growmore or specialist fruit feed) in early spring, with a further feed after harvest. Avoid feeding late in the season, to let the wood ripen before winter.

**Companions:** Chives and garlic nearby help deter aphids. Keep a weed-free, mulched area around the base.

**Pruning:** Prune in summer, ideally straight after harvest, to reduce the risk of silver leaf disease common to *Prunus* species.

**Pot/container:** ✅ Bred specifically as the first cherry bush suited to pot culture as well as open ground — one of the more compact, patio-friendly cherry options in this guide. ⚠️ Protect the ripening fruit from birds with netting.

**West of Ireland:** Self-pollinating and genuinely compact, 'Athos' suits smaller west of Ireland gardens and patios where a full-sized cherry tree would not fit. Its stated winter-hardiness (source: schramas.com) fits comfortably within the general cold-tolerance of sweet cherries (*Prunus avium*), which tolerate the mild, wet west of Ireland winters well provided drainage is adequate; the main local risk, as with other cherries, is losing blossom to a late spring frost, so a sheltered spot away from frost pockets gives the most reliable cropping.

#### F6. Cranberry (*Vaccinium macrocarpon*)

 **Reference photo:** [Cranberry — view on Wikipedia](#)

**Light:** ☀ Full sun to partial shade. Best fruiting in full sun.

**Soil needs:** Highly acidic, pH 4.0–5.0. Bog plant — prefers consistently moist, peaty, acidic conditions. Must be grown in ericaceous compost container or purpose-made acidic bog bed.

**Pot size:** 30–45cm wide, 20–30cm deep container; 100% ericaceous compost. Keep consistently moist. Do not add grit.

**Planting depth:** At pot level; shallow-rooting.

**Spacing:** 30–45cm in acidic bed

**Fertiliser:** Ericaceous liquid fertiliser monthly April–August. Do not use general-purpose fertilisers. Adapted to nutrient-poor conditions — do not overfeed.

**Companions:** Heather, lingonberry, blueberry (all share ericaceous requirements). Low carpet beneath taller blueberry bushes.

**West of Ireland:** The moist, mild Atlantic climate is naturally ideal for cranberry — but only if you provide or replicate acidic bog soil. Container with ericaceous compost is most practical.

#### F7. Garden Plum (*Prunus domestica*)

 **Reference photo:** [Garden Plum — view source](#)

**Light:** ☀ Full sun essential for best fruiting — at least 6 hours daily, sheltered from wind.

**Soil needs:** Well-drained, moderately fertile soil, pH 6.0–7.0. Dislikes waterlogged clay — good drainage is essential.

**Soil prep:** Dig wider and deeper than the root system. Break up clay beneath. Mix excavated clay 50/50 with compost and 20–30% grit over a broad area. Keep a weed-free circle around the base.

**Planting depth:** Graft union (bulge near stem base) at or just above soil level. Plant to the nursery soil mark.

**Spacing:** 3–5m between trees depending on rootstock; permanent stake

**Fertiliser:** Balanced fruit tree fertiliser (Growmore or specialist fruit feed) each February. Do not feed after midsummer, to allow wood to ripen before winter. Potash feed helps fruiting.

**Companions:** Chives and garlic to deter aphids. Comfrey or nasturtiums nearby to attract beneficial insects. Many plums (though not all) need a compatible pollination partner flowering at the same time — check the variety before buying.

**West of Ireland:** Permanent staking recommended against Atlantic winds, especially on dwarfing rootstocks. Choose a sheltered, sunny spot away from frost pockets — plum blossoms early and late frosts can damage the crop.

#### F8. Gooseberry (*Ribes uva-crispa*)

 **Reference photo:** [Gooseberry — view on Wikipedia](#)

**Light:** ☀️ Full sun to partial shade. Tolerates semi-shade better than most fruit.

**Soil prep:** Compost and grit amendment. Bonemeal at planting.

**Planting depth:** At nursery mark; roots covered ~5cm. Cut all stems to 30cm after planting.

**Spacing:** 1.5m between plants

**Fertiliser:** Sulphate of potash in late winter/early spring. Balanced fertiliser after flowering. Annual compost mulch. Avoid excessive nitrogen.

**Companions:** Redcurrants, whitecurrants. Tansy nearby reportedly repels gooseberry sawfly.

#### F9. Honeyberry (*Lonicera caerulea* var. *kamtschatica*)

 **Reference photo:** [Honeyberry — Kamchatka — view on Wikipedia](#)

**Light:** ☀️ Full sun to partial shade. Fruits better in full sun.

**Soil needs:** Very flexible, pH 4.5–7.5, tolerates clay. Plant two different varieties for cross-pollination.

**Soil prep:** Standard clay improvement with compost and grit.

**Planting depth:** At pot level or slightly deeper.

**Spacing:** 1–1.5m between plants

**Fertiliser:** Balanced fertiliser in early spring. Annual compost mulch. Liquid balanced feed monthly during flowering and fruiting can improve yields.

**Companions:** Blueberry, lingonberry in adjacent beds. Pollinator-attracting flowers nearby (important for early February–April flowers). Needs 2+ varieties: e.g. 'Borealis' and 'Tundra'.

#### F10. Lingonberry (*Vaccinium vitis-idaea*)

 **Reference photo:** [Lingonberry — view on Wikipedia](#)

**Light:** 🌤️ Partial shade preferred — woodland edge as recommended by the RHS. Tolerates full sun if soil stays consistently moist.

**Soil needs:** Acidic, moist but well-drained, pH 4.2–5.5. Same requirements as blueberry. Will not tolerate neutral or alkaline soil.

**Pot size:** 30cm diameter, 20cm+ deep container; 100% ericaceous compost. Or a dedicated acidic bed.

**Planting depth:** At pot level. Space 30cm apart.

**Spacing:** 30cm between plants

**Fertiliser:** Ericaceous liquid fertiliser monthly April–August only. Mulch with pine bark to maintain acidity.

**Companions:** Blueberry, heather, cranberry. Low ground cover under taller blueberry bushes. Also combines well with deer fern (same acidic conditions) in a naturalistic ericaceous bed.

**West of Ireland:** Produces berries twice per year (late July and late September). Self-fertile. Excellent for west of Ireland mild, moist climate.

#### F11. Plum Tree 'Aprimira' (*Prunus domestica* 'Aprimira')

 **Reference photo:** [Plum — view on Wikipedia](#)

**Light:** ☀️ Full sun essential — a warm, sheltered spot gives the best fruit set and ripening.

**Soil needs:** Fertile, well-drained soil, pH 6.0–7.0. Dislikes waterlogged clay; good drainage matters more than fertility.

**Soil prep — in the ground:** Dig a hole at least twice the width of the rootball. Break up the base of the hole to help roots establish. Mix excavated clay 50/50 with multipurpose compost and 20–30% horticultural grit over a broad area, since good drainage is the single biggest factor in preventing root problems on wet Irish clay. Firm in well and stake permanently — plums often need support for their whole life on windy sites.

**Soil prep — in a pot (recommended for smaller gardens):** Use a container at least 25cm in diameter with drainage holes, and cover the base with a piece of broken pot or crock so water can always drain freely. Fill with a mix of one-third sharp sand, one-third multipurpose compost and one-third good topsoil or potting soil. Loosen the rootball before planting so roots spread outward rather than circling.

**Planting depth:** Plant so the top of the original rootball sits just below the surrounding soil or compost surface; keep the graft union above soil level.

**Spacing:** Sold as a standard (bush-headed) tree, ideal for a large pot or a small garden bed; allow at least 1–1.5m from other plants or structures.

**Fertiliser:** In pots, feed with cow manure pellets or a balanced granular feed in early spring, then a potash-rich granular feed (e.g. NPK 12-10-18) in May and again in July. In the ground, an annual balanced fruit tree feed each February is sufficient. Stop feeding by midsummer to let the wood ripen before winter.

**Companions:** Chives and garlic at the base help deter aphids. In a container, underplant with low, shallow-rooted plants only, to avoid competing with the tree's roots.

**Pruning:** Prune only in summer, during or just after flowering — never in winter, when open wounds on stone fruit are vulnerable to silver leaf disease. Prune lightly each February to maintain shape while flower buds are visible, working around them where possible.

**Pot/container:**  Bred and sold as a compact standard specifically for patio pots and small gardens; in winter, move container-grown plants to a cool, sheltered spot (a shed or a wall-sheltered corner) and wrap the pot in jute sacking or fleece to protect the roots from hard frost.

**West of Ireland:** 'Aprimira' is a self-fertile mirabelle-apricot hybrid plum, so no second pollinator tree is needed — useful in a smaller west of Ireland garden. It flowers in spring like other plums, so a sheltered, sunny spot away from frost pockets protects the blossom from late frost damage. Harvest is August–September; fruits have sweet, orange-yellow flesh with a stone that separates cleanly.

## F12. Pomegranate (*Punica granatum*)

 **Reference photo:** [Pomegranate — view source](#)

**Light:**  Full sun essential, against a warm, sheltered south- or west-facing wall.

**Soil needs:** Well-drained soil; pH 5.5–7.0. Dislikes waterlogged clay.

**Soil prep:** Dig hole twice the rootball width against the wall base. Mix excavated clay 50/50 with compost and 20–30% grit.

**Planting depth:** At nursery soil mark.

**Spacing:** 2–3m against wall; borderline hardy, best in a container

**Fertiliser:** Balanced fruit tree fertiliser in spring. Liquid high-potash feed through summer to encourage flowering/fruiting.

**Companions:** Other wall-trained sun-lovers such as passiflora or grapevine on the same warm wall.

**West of Ireland:** Borderline hardy (RHS H4, roughly to –5 to –10°C) — reliable fruiting in the west of Ireland's cooler, shorter summers is uncertain, and pomegranate is best treated primarily as an ornamental flowering wall shrub here, grown against a warm wall or in a large container that can be moved under cover in winter, with any fruit a bonus rather than a certainty.

## F13. Raspberry (*Rubus idaeus*)

 **Reference photo:** [Raspberry — view on Wikipedia](#)

**Light:**  Full sun to partial shade. Better fruiting in full sun.

**Soil prep:** Compost and grit essential on clay. Raised bed recommended. Plant in mounded rows or raised beds between parallel support wires.

**Planting depth:** Crown 5–7cm below soil. Cut canes to 25cm after planting.

**Spacing:** 45–60cm between canes; 1.8m between rows

**Fertiliser:** High-potash fertiliser (tomato feed) fortnightly from spring bud break until fruit set. Or balanced granular fertiliser in early spring plus compost mulch. Avoid excessive nitrogen on wet clay.

**Companions:** Garlic, marigolds, tansy deter aphids. Avoid planting near potatoes (shared virus diseases) and wild brambles.

**Your varieties:**

*Summer-fruiting (floricane — fruit on second-year canes; prune fruited canes to the ground in early to mid-autumn):*

**'Glen Ample'** (PBR) — One of the most widely grown summer-fruiting raspberries in the UK; holds the RHS Award of Garden Merit. Bred at the James Hutton Institute (formerly Scottish Crop Research Institute), Scotland. Mid-season; harvest from late June to late July (sometimes into September). Large to very large, deep red, rich-flavoured berries — five large berries can weigh up to 30g. Almost completely thornless (spineless canes and laterals), making harvesting and pruning easy. High yields — over 2kg per plant — and excellent disease resistance. Canes grow to approximately 1.8m; tie to horizontal support wires. Best in well-drained, fertile, moisture-retentive soil; does not do well in waterlogged or very chalky conditions.

*Autumn-fruiting (primocane — fruit on current year's canes; cut ALL canes to the ground in late winter/early spring):*

**'Zefa Herbsternte'** (also sold as 'Zeva Herbsternte') — A primocane (autumn-fruiting) variety bred in Switzerland in 1952; one of the first commercial primocane raspberries and still widely grown. Sometimes spelled *Zefa*, sometimes *Zeva* — both refer to the same cultivar. Late-season: harvest from August to September (or until first frosts). Large, sweet-tasting, dark red berries measuring 2–3cm in length. Vigorous, upright canes to 150cm with thorns. Particularly well suited to cooler northern regions of the UK and Ireland. Good resistance to phytophthora root disease. Primocane cultivar so fruiting is best in its first year (all canes to the ground in late winter). Fruiting is best in cool summers.

**'Autumn Bliss'** — A primocane (autumn-fruiting) variety bred at East Malling Research Station, England. RHS Award of Garden Merit (1993 and 2009). One of the most widely grown autumn raspberries in the UK. Medium-large, firm, dark red berries from late July through to late October. Excellent disease resistance, particularly to aphids. Relatively short, self-supporting canes (to 150cm) that can often stand without support, though tying in is recommended in exposed west of Ireland conditions. Earlier to crop than most autumn varieties.

**'Heritage'** — An American primocane (autumn-fruiting) variety released in 1969 by Cornell University; long considered the standard against which autumn-bearing varieties are measured. Harvest from August into autumn. Medium-sized, firm, conical, deep red berries with a classic sweet-tart raspberry flavour. Excellent cold hardiness. Sturdy, often self-supporting canes. For UK and Irish growing, managed as an autumn raspberry (cut all canes to the ground in late winter). Popular commercially because fruit is firm, travels well, and the variety is reliably productive.

*Patio/dwarf cultivars (suitable for containers; minimum 45–60cm wide, deep container):*

**'Good as Gold'** (Lowberry® Goodasgold®) — A compact, dwarf autumn-fruiting raspberry with a final height under 100cm (usually 80cm), due to early flowering and fruiting which slows further growth. Produces medium-sized, pale yellow/golden fruits from mid-July through to autumn; sweet flavour and aroma. A few thorns present, reducing towards the tips of fruiting shoots. Bred as a patio cultivar, ideal for containers on a sunny patio or balcony. Part of the Lowberry® range of compact raspberry varieties.

**'Lucky Berry'** — A new, self-fertile, dwarf patio raspberry with a vigorous habit despite its compact size. Produces juicy, sweet-tasting red fruits over a remarkably long season of four months, from July to October, fruiting continuously until the first frosts. Part of the Lucky Berry® range of compact, long-season fruit plants selected specifically for pot cultivation. Resistant to diseases and cold. Prune back before winter. Ideal for containers on a terrace, balcony or patio.

#### F14. Redcurrant (*Ribes rubrum*)

 **Reference photo:** [Redcurrant — view on Wikipedia](#)

**Light:** ☀️ Full sun to partial shade. One of the most shade-tolerant fruiting plants — good for north-facing fences trained as a fan.

**Soil prep:** Compost and grit amendment. Good drainage.

**Planting depth:** At nursery mark; roots covered ~5cm.

**Spacing:** 1.5m between plants

**Fertiliser:** Sulphate of potash in late winter. Balanced fertiliser after flowering. Annual bark or compost mulch. Do not overfeed with nitrogen.

**Companions:** Gooseberries, whitecurrants. North-facing fan trained redcurrant is a remarkably productive use of otherwise difficult wall space.

#### F15. Rhubarb (*Rheum × hybridum*)

 **Reference photo:** [Rhubarb — view on Wikipedia](#)

**Light:** ☀️ Full sun to partial shade. Tolerates partial shade better than most vegetables.

**Soil needs:** Fertile, moisture-retentive but well-drained. RHS advises raised beds on heavy clay.

**Soil prep:** Remove weeds, dig in two bucketfuls of compost per sq metre. Raised bed (30cm+) on wet clay.

**Planting depth:** Buds 1–2cm below soil level.

**Spacing:** 90cm between crowns

**Fertiliser:** Balanced granular fertiliser in early spring. Generous well-rotted manure or compost mulch each autumn after leaves die back — this is the most beneficial treatment.

**Companions:** Beans and peas nearby (nitrogen-fixers). Keep away from fennel (inhibits many plants). Do not pick in the first year after planting.

#### F16. Serviceberry (*Amelanchier lamarckii*)

 **Reference photo:** [Serviceberry — view source](#)

**Light:** ☀ Full sun to 🌤 part shade. Best autumn colour in full sun.

**Soil needs:** Most moist, well-drained soils including clay; tolerates acid to neutral, pH 5.5–7.0. Dislikes waterlogging.

**Soil prep:** Dig hole twice the rootball width and as deep as the rootball. Mix excavated clay 50/50 with compost and 20% grit for drainage.

**Planting depth:** At nursery soil mark.

**Spacing:** 2–4m between plants/structures

**Fertiliser:** Balanced general fertiliser in early spring. Annual compost or bark mulch; little further feeding needed once established.

**Companions:** Underplant with hellebores, snowdrops, bluebells and ferns; works well as a woodland-edge specimen with Japanese maple and hydrangea.

**West of Ireland:** Multi-season interest — white spring blossom, edible summer berries (loved by birds), fiery autumn colour. Tolerates coastal wind well once established.

#### F17. Strawberry (*Fragaria × ananassa*)

 **Reference photo:** [Strawberry — view on Wikipedia](#)

**Light:** ☀ Full sun essential for maximum fruiting.

**Soil needs:** pH 5.5–6.8, well-drained. Raised bed on clay strongly recommended.

**Soil prep:** Compost and grit. Raised bed 20–25cm high.

**Planting depth:** Crown exactly at soil level — too deep = crown rot; too shallow = roots dry out.

**Spacing:** 30–45cm between plants (or 45cm × 75cm rows if in open ground)

**Fertiliser:** High-potash fertiliser (tomato feed) fortnightly from first flowers until fruiting ceases. Balanced granular fertiliser in early spring. Do not use high-nitrogen fertiliser.

**Companions:** Borage, garlic, chives, marigolds. Avoid planting near brassicas.

##### Your varieties:

**'Korona'** — An early to mid-season summer-fruiting variety (harvests from mid-June). Heavy cropping with large, glossy, dark red fruits packed with juicy flavour. Very resistant to verticillium wilt, botrytis and grey mould — one of the best disease-resistant varieties available, which is particularly important in the wet west of Ireland climate. Suitable for patio pots, containers, greenhouses and open ground. Height approximately 20cm, spread 30cm. RHS plant profile confirms heavy cropping of large, dark red fruits in early summer. Pomona Fruits describes the flavour as very sweet and juicy with a refreshing flavour, sometimes with a hint of wild strawberry. Popular for pick-your-own and recommended by Sproot for its "combination of flavour, season and disease resistance."

**'Ostara'** — A popular, long-established perpetual (everbearing) variety producing sweet-tasting bright red fruits from early summer (spring crop) and again from mid-July until the first frosts in October or November. Fruits are conical, medium-sized, firm and juicy with a flavour resembling wild strawberries. Plants are strong growing with a wide spreading habit, making them ideal for raised beds, hanging baskets and climbing frames. Produces heavy crops which increase over the season. Recommended for pick-your-own and amateur use. RHS plant profile lists it as an everbearing variety producing sweet bright red fruits from early summer.

**'Summer Breeze'** — A compact, ornamental patio strawberry grown as much for its decorative value as for its fruit. Produces delicious small red berries all through the growing season (everbearing/perpetual). Compact and beautiful, suitable for use as a border plant or in containers on a patio. The double purpose as an eye-catching ornamental makes it a useful choice for potted displays.

#### F18. Sweet Cherry 'Sylvia' (*Prunus avium* 'Sylvia')

 **Reference photo:** [Sweet Cherry 'Sylvia' — view source](#)

**About 'Sylvia':** A compact, self-fertile sweet cherry suitable for patios and smaller gardens. Mature height approximately 125–150cm with a spread of 30–40cm, making it one of the most compact cherries available — well suited to container growing (source: gardens4you.ie).

**Light:** ☀ Full sun to 🌤 partial sun.

**Soil needs:** Well-drained soil.

**Soil prep:** Dig wider and deeper than the root system. Break up clay beneath. Mix excavated clay 50/50 with compost and 20–30% grit for drainage.

**Planting depth:** Approximately 12cm, or to the nursery soil mark/graft union at or just above soil level.

**Spacing:** 1m spacing; self-fertile

**Fertiliser:** Feed from spring until fruit sets, and again after harvest. Balanced fruit tree fertiliser (Growmore or specialist fruit feed).

**Companions:** Chives and garlic to deter aphids. Keep an area of roughly 1.2m around the base weed-free and mulched.

**Pruning:** Best pruned in summer, ideally straight after harvest, to reduce the risk of silver leaf disease common to *Prunus* species.

**West of Ireland:** Self-fertile, so a single tree will produce fruit — ideal for smaller west of Ireland gardens or patios. Harvest June–July. White blossom in spring. Permanent staking recommended given its compact form and Atlantic winds.

### Fig. Woodland Strawberry (*Fragaria vesca*)

 **Reference photo:** [Woodland Strawberry — view on Wikipedia](#)

**Light:** ☀ Full sun to ☁ partial shade. Tolerates full shade but fruits less freely there.

**Soil needs:** Fertile, moist but well-drained soil; pH 5.5–7.0. Tolerates clay and a wide pH range better than most fruit.

**Soil prep:** Mix clay 50/50 with compost. Mulch with leaf mould to mimic its natural woodland-edge habitat.

**Planting depth:** Crown at soil level — do not bury the crown.

**Spacing:** 25–30cm between plants; runners will fill gaps and can be left to spread or removed to keep a tidier clump.

**Fertiliser:** Light balanced feed in spring. Annual compost mulch, kept away from the crown.

**Companions:** Ferns, hostas, primroses — a natural, decorative groundcover under fruit trees and in a woodland-edge bed; also good as informal edging along a path.

**West of Ireland:** Smaller and less showy than garden strawberry, but reliably hardy, shade-tolerant and long-fruited (often June to autumn), with small, intensely flavoured berries. Spreads gently by runners to form an attractive edible groundcover under trees and shrubs — a good choice for a spot too shaded for garden strawberry.

## GROUP G: GROUNDCOVER & CREEPING PLANTS

### G10. Bellflowers (Rockery) (*Campanula* spp.)

 **Reference photos:** [Campanula saxifraga](#) · [Carpathian Bellflower](#) · [Dalmatian Bellflower](#)

| Species                  | Latin name                 | Height                      | Flowering         | Planting depth | Notes                                                                                  |
|--------------------------|----------------------------|-----------------------------|-------------------|----------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Carpathian Bellflower    | <i>C. carpatica</i>        | 15–25cm                     | Early–late summer | At pot level   | Neat, low, non-spreading mound; upward-facing bells; good for edging and troughs       |
| Dalmatian Bellflower     | <i>C. portenschlagiana</i> | 10–15cm, spreading to 50cm+ | Summer            | At pot level   | Vigorous mat-forming evergreen; RHS AGM; excellent in wall crevices and between paving |
| Trailing Rock Bellflower | <i>C. saxifraga</i>        | 10–15cm, trailing           | Summer            | At pot level   | Trailing, semi-evergreen; best in a trough, rockery or wall crevice                    |

**Light:** ☀ Full sun for Trailing Rock Bellflower. Carpathian and Dalmatian Bellflower: full sun to partial shade, especially in the heat of late summer.

**Soil needs:** Trailing Rock Bellflower: free-draining, gritty soil, pH 6.5–7.5 — rots in wet, heavy clay over winter. Carpathian Bellflower: well-drained, moist, fertile soil, neutral to alkaline, pH 6.0–7.0 — dislikes both waterlogging and drying out. Dalmatian Bellflower: average, well-drained soil, pH 6.0–7.5 — very adaptable, though it dislikes constantly wet soil and humid air more than the other two.

**Soil prep:** Trailing Rock Bellflower: improve clay heavily with 30–40% horticultural grit; best in a raised trough, rockery or wall crevice rather than open ground. Carpathian and Dalmatian Bellflower: mix clay 50/50 with multipurpose compost and horticultural grit.

**Planting depth:** At pot level for all three.

**Spacing:** Trailing Rock Bellflower: 15–20cm between plants. Carpathian Bellflower: 25–35cm between plants; low, mounding, non-invasive habit. Dalmatian Bellflower: 30–40cm between plants; spreads by rhizomes to 50cm or more but is not invasive.

**Fertiliser:** Trailing Rock Bellflower: very little required — a light balanced feed in spring if in a container. Carpathian and Dalmatian Bellflower: balanced feed in spring and again in midsummer.

**Companions:** Trailing Rock Bellflower: sempervivum, saxifrage, wall pennywort and other rockery/trough plants with the same sharp-drainage needs. Carpathian and Dalmatian Bellflower: sempervivum, saxifrage, dianthus pinks — front-of-border and rockery companions.

**West of Ireland:** Trailing Rock Bellflower is one of the plants most likely to fail on flat, wet clay — best given the sharp drainage a raised trough or wall crevice provides. Carpathian Bellflower is distinct in habit from the other campanulas in this guide (Clustered, Spreading and Peach-leaved Bellflower) — a neat, low, non-spreading mound ideal for rock gardens, border edging or troughs, with upward-facing blue, purple or white bells from early to late summer if deadheaded. Dalmatian Bellflower is the most vigorous of the three and semi-evergreen — in colder, more exposed spots it may lose its leaves over winter, regrowing freely in spring; excellent cascading over a wall or raised bed, but best kept away from smaller, less competitive rockery plants.

## G2. Creeping Phlox / Moss Phlox (*Phlox subulata*)

 **Reference photo:** [Phlox subulata — view on Wikipedia](#)

**Light:** ☀ Full sun preferred. Creeping Phlox thrives in full sun, but it can tolerate light shade, especially in hotter climates. More sun typically leads to a denser bloom.

**Soil needs:** This plant prefers well-drained soil. While it can tolerate a range of soil types, from sandy to clay, it doesn't like to sit in water. Consider amending your soil with compost or other organic matter to improve drainage, especially if your soil is heavy clay. pH 5.5–7.7.

**Soil prep:** Mix clay 50/50 with compost and 20–25% grit. On heavy clay, a raised bed or slope is ideal.

**Planting depth:** At pot level. Plant Phlox subulata root balls so that the root system is fully submerged in the compost, leaving any young shoots/leaves, buds or stems exposed above the soil surface. Space 30–45cm apart.

**Spacing:** 30–45cm for ground cover

**Fertiliser:** In early spring, feed Creeping Phlox with a slow-release, balanced fertilizer to support healthy growth and abundant flowering. Light feeding only — over-feeding produces lush, floppy growth. Minimal fertiliser once established.

**Companions:** Creeping Phlox makes a gorgeous underplanting for spring bulbs like tulips and daffodils. Excellent on slopes, in rock gardens, or cascading over walls. With thyme, sedum, dianthus, and other well-drained-soil companions in a sunny rockery. Weigela as a taller backdrop.

**Pot size:** 20–30cm diameter, 15cm deep; multipurpose compost with 20–25% grit. Excellent in shallow, wide terracotta bowls on sunny patios.

**West of Ireland:** The mild, moist Irish climate requires excellent drainage for this plant. A sunny south-facing slope, raised bed, or rock garden is ideal. Grows well in walls and between paving stones. May suffer crown rot in continuously wet conditions — drainage is the key.

## G3. Heathers (*Calluna* / *Erica* spp.)

 **Reference photos:** [Calluna vulgaris](#) · [Erica cinerea](#) · [Erica carnea](#) · [Erica erigena](#) · [Erica arborea](#)

| Species               | Latin name                                               | Height                                  | Flowering                 | Planting depth | Notes                                                                                                                    |
|-----------------------|----------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------|---------------------------|----------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Common Heather / Ling | <i>Calluna vulgaris</i><br>(syn. <i>Erica vulgaris</i> ) | 20–50cm                                 | Summer–autumn             | At pot level   | Native to Irish heathland; the classic garden heather; strictly acid soil only                                           |
| Bell Heather          | <i>Erica cinerea</i>                                     | 15–50cm                                 | Early summer–early autumn | At pot level   | Native to Ireland; vivid magenta-purple bell flowers; acid soil only                                                     |
| Winter Heath          | <i>Erica carnea</i>                                      | 10–25cm                                 | Late autumn–mid spring    | At pot level   | The one heather reliably tolerant of neutral to mildly alkaline soil; low mat, valuable winter colour                    |
| Irish Heath           | <i>Erica erigena</i>                                     | 45–75cm (some cultivars to 1.2m)        | Winter–late spring        | At pot level   | Native to Connemara/Mayo; taller and upright; tolerates neutral to mildly alkaline soil, unusually wet-tolerant          |
| Tree Heath            | <i>Erica arborea</i>                                     | 1–2m in cultivation (to 7m in the wild) | Late winter–spring        | At pot level   | Much larger, upright shrub with honey-scented white flowers; needs a sheltered spot, less reliably hardy than the others |

**Light:** ☀ Full sun for all five — flowering and foliage colour suffer in shade, though light shade from high-canopied trees is tolerated.

**Soil needs:** *Calluna vulgaris* and *Erica cinerea* are strict calcifuges — acid soil only, pH 6.5 or below (ideally 5.5) — and will not tolerate lime. *Erica carnea* and *Erica erigena* are the exceptions in this group: both are genuinely lime-tolerant and will grow in neutral to mildly alkaline soil, though they still perform best in humus-rich, well-drained ground. *Erica arborea* prefers well-drained, acid to neutral soil.



**Soil prep:** For acid-loving species (*vulgaris*, *cinerea*, *arborea*) on neutral or alkaline clay: grow in containers of ericaceous compost only — do not add lime near any of them. For lime-tolerant species (*carnea*, *erigena*) in the open ground, add leafmould or composted bark to the clay; heavy grit is less important than for most plants in this guide, since good structure and moisture retention matter more than sharp drainage here.

**Planting depth:** At pot level for all five.

**Spacing:** *Calluna vulgaris*, *E. cinerea*, *E. carnea*: 30–45cm between plants. *E. erigena*: 45–60cm, or closer if grown as a low informal hedge. *E. arborea*: 1–1.5m, since it grows much larger.

**Fertiliser:** An ericaceous fertiliser annually in March/April keeps all five flowering well, or a liquid feed such as Phostrogen between April and September; heather grown in naturally suitable soil generally needs little feeding. Annual mulch with composted pine bark or leafmould benefits all species.

**Companions:** Blueberry, lingonberry, cranberry (all ericaceous, sharing *Calluna*'s and *E. cinerea*'s acid-soil needs). Creeping juniper, deer fern, dwarf bulbs (species crocus, snowdrops) and Japanese maple all combine beautifully with any of the five for year-round interest and contrasting texture.

**Pot/container:**  All five can be grown in containers using peat-free ericaceous compost (for *carnea/erigena*, ordinary peat-free multipurpose compost is also fine given their lime tolerance); minimum 20–25cm diameter, 20cm deep, repotted every 3 years.

**West of Ireland:** *Calluna vulgaris* and *Erica cinerea* are both native to Irish heathland and perfectly adapted to the moist western climate, provided the soil is genuinely acidic — check pH before planting in the ground. *Erica erigena*, the Irish Heath, is a real rarity: genuinely native to a handful of sites in Connemara and Co. Mayo, and one of the very few heathers that tolerates the region's damper, less acidic pockets of ground. *Erica carnea* is the easiest choice for a garden with neutral or slightly alkaline soil. *Erica arborea* is the most tender of the five and appreciates the mild Atlantic winters, but still wants a sheltered spot away from the harshest coastal wind. Note that "*Erica vulgaris*" is simply an old synonym for *Calluna vulgaris*, not a separate species — the two names refer to exactly the same plant.

#### G4. Houseleek (*Sempervivum* spp.)

 **Reference photo:** [Sempervivum — view source](#)

**Light:**  Full sun.

**Soil needs:** Very free-draining, poor to moderately fertile soil; pH 6.0–7.5. Rots quickly in wet clay, especially winter.

**Soil prep:** Improve clay heavily with 40%+ grit, or grow entirely in a shallow pot/trough of gritty, free-draining compost.

**Planting depth:** At pot level; do not bury the rosette.

**Spacing:** 10–15cm between rosettes

**Fertiliser:** None to very little required — rich soil produces soft, less hardy growth.

**Companions:** Saxifrage, wall pennywort, thyme, sedum — classic gritty rockery/roof-garden planting.

**West of Ireland:** Extremely hardy and drought-tolerant once established, but the biggest risk on Irish clay is winter wet, not cold — a raised trough, wall top, or gritty rockery gives much better results than open ground. Spreads by offsets ("chicks") to form a mat over time.

#### G1. Junipers (Creeping) (*Juniperus* spp.)

 **Reference photos:** [Creeping Juniper](#) · [Juniperus communis](#)

| Species           | Latin name                   | Height             | Flowering                            | Planting depth                  | Notes                                                                                      |
|-------------------|------------------------------|--------------------|--------------------------------------|---------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Creeping Juniper  | <i>J. horizontalis</i>       | 10–30cm, spreading | Foliage plant (no ornamental flower) | At pot level or slightly raised | Widest pH tolerance (4.5–8.5); tolerates clay, rocky and poor soils given sharp drainage   |
| Juniper 'Repanda' | <i>J. communis</i> 'Repanda' | 20–40cm, spreading | Foliage plant (no ornamental flower) | At pot level, roughly 15cm deep | Native genus in Ireland; bronze-green winter colour; well suited to exposed, coastal sites |

**Light:**  Full sun essential for both — neither will grow well in shade, and Juniper 'Repanda' needs it for dense growth and best foliage colour.

**Soil needs:** Creeping Juniper: pH 4.5–8.5, tolerates clay, rocky and poor soils, but requires excellent drainage and will rot in constantly wet clay. Juniper 'Repanda': free-draining soil, pH 4.5–7.5 — copes with poor soil but dislikes sitting wet in winter.

**Soil prep:** Creeping Juniper: mix clay with 30–40% horticultural grit; plant on a slight mound or raised bed, essential on very wet clay. Juniper 'Repanda': improve clay with 25–30% horticultural grit worked into the planting area; on the wettest sites, plant on a slightly raised mound or ridge to keep the base clear of standing water.



**Planting depth:** Creeping Juniper: at pot level or slightly raised above it. Juniper 'Repanda': at pot level, roughly 15cm deep, at the same level as it sat in its nursery pot.

**Spacing:** 1–1.5m between plants for both, to form a continuous carpet.

**Fertiliser:** Creeping Juniper: virtually no feeding required — evolved on lean soils; a light slow-release balanced fertiliser in spring only if the plant appears weak, and a grit mulch is more beneficial than fertiliser. Juniper 'Repanda': none needed for the first 6–8 weeks after planting, then an occasional light dressing of Kieserite (magnesium sulphate) or organic conifer feed in February–March.

**Companions:** Creeping Juniper: heather, sedum, ornamental grasses, thyme, rosemary; excellent ground cover beneath Irish yew, holly and conifers, and a good companion for fruit trees. Juniper 'Repanda': heather, sempervivum, saxifrage and other rockery or gravel-garden plants; also works as groundcover beneath the Dwarf Mountain Pine.

**Pruning:** Juniper 'Repanda': prune only to remove dead or damaged growth.

**West of Ireland:** For Creeping Juniper, ⚠ the biggest challenge is the region's high rainfall — raised beds, slopes, or very well-drained gritty ground are essential. Juniper 'Repanda' is a cultivar of common juniper, which is native to Ireland and found on rocky uplands and coastal heath, so it is naturally well suited to exposed, windy or coastal west of Ireland sites and to poor, thin soils where little else will form dense cover.

## G6. Periwinkle (*Vinca minor* and *V. major*)

 **Reference photo:** [Periwinkle — view on Wikipedia](#)

**Light:** 🌑 Full shade to 🌞 full sun. Grow in any but very dry soil, in full sun (for best flowering) to partial shade.

**Soil needs:** Grow in any but very dry soil. Tolerates heavy clay, pH 5.5–8.0. One of the most clay-tolerant ground cover plants. Remarkably adaptable.

**Soil prep:** Basic compost addition to planting hole. Even unamended clay is usually tolerated.

**Planting depth:** At pot level. Space 30–45cm apart for ground cover.

**Spacing:** 30–45cm between plants; can spread

**Fertiliser:** Very low-maintenance. A balanced slow-release fertiliser in spring if the plant appears slow or pale. Annual bark mulch is more useful than feeding. In containers, monthly balanced liquid feed during the growing season.

**Companions:** Hellebores, snowdrops, ivy — classic trio for difficult shaded areas. Excellent under trees and shrubs where grass won't grow. Underplant forsythia, lilac, or shrub roses with periwinkle for year-round ground cover. The blue flowers of *V. minor* are a valuable early source of nectar for bees.

⚠ *Vinca* can spread vigorously — in small or formal gardens, divide and restrict regularly.

**Pot size:** 25–35cm diameter container; multipurpose compost.

**West of Ireland:** Excellent in all Irish conditions. Tolerates coastal exposure, clay, shade, and wet winters. Very low-maintenance once established. Can self-layer (roots where stems touch soil) and spread into extensive ground cover without any effort.

## G7. Prickly Heath (*Gaultheria mucronata*)

 **Reference photo:** [Prickly Heath — view source](#)

**Light:** 🌞 Full sun to 🌂 partial shade.

**Soil needs:** Moist but well-drained, acid soil; pH 4.5–6.0. Dislikes lime.

**Soil prep:** Mix clay with 30–40% ericaceous compost and grit.

**Planting depth:** At nursery soil mark.

**Spacing:** 45–60cm between plants; ♂+♀ for berries

**Fertiliser:** Ericaceous slow-release feed in spring. Annual mulch with ericaceous compost or bark.

**Companions:** Heather, blueberry, lingonberry — classic acid-soil groundcover planting; good with dwarf conifers.

**West of Ireland:** Dioecious — plant a male near females for the females' showy, long-lasting white, pink or magenta berries in autumn/winter. Compact evergreen groundcover, tolerant of coastal exposure once established.

## G8. Reindeer Lichen (*Cladonia rangiferina*)

 **Reference photo:** [Reindeer Lichen — view source](#)

**Light:** 🌞 Full sun to 🌂 partial shade.

**Soil needs:** Very poor, free-draining, acid soil or bare mineral ground/rock; pH 4.0–5.5. Will not survive in rich garden soil or where it is shaded out by faster-growing plants.

**Soil prep:** None — this is a slow-growing lichen, not a rooted vascular plant. Best established on an existing patch of poor, undisturbed acid ground, sand, or a rockery, not planted into amended clay.

**Planting depth:** Laid on the surface, not buried.

**Spacing:** Establishes slowly; avoid disturbance

**Fertiliser:** None — feeding kills lichens, which take all their nutrients from air and rain.

**Companions:** Heather, sempervivum and other poor-soil, sun-loving plants of open heath or rockery.

**West of Ireland:** Genuinely difficult to establish deliberately — reindeer lichen grows extremely slowly (a few mm per year) and needs open, undisturbed, nutrient-poor ground, most realistically an established rockery or heath-style planting rather than a conventional border. Best treated as a feature to preserve if already present, rather than one to plant and expect quick results from.

## G9. Saxifrage (*Saxifraga* spp., alpine/rockery types)

 **Reference photo:** [Saxifrage — view source](#)

**Light:** ☀ Full sun to 🌤 partial shade, depending on species.

**Soil needs:** Free-draining, gritty soil; pH 6.0–7.5. Most alpine saxifrages rot in wet, heavy clay.

**Soil prep:** Improve clay heavily with 30–40% grit; best in a rockery, trough, or raised bed.

**Planting depth:** At pot level.

**Spacing:** 15–20cm between plants

**Fertiliser:** Very little required. Light balanced feed in spring for container-grown plants.

**Companions:** Sempervivum, campanula saxifraga, wall pennywort, dwarf bulbs (species crocus, dwarf iris).

**West of Ireland:** A large genus with many hardy mat- and cushion-forming evergreen species suited to rockeries, troughs and wall crevices; excellent drainage is the single most important factor for success on west of Ireland clay.

## G13. Thyme (Creeping) (*Thymus* spp.)

 **Reference photos:** [Thymus serpyllum](#) · [Thymus polytrichus](#)

| Species                                 | Latin name            | Height              | Flowering | Planting depth | Notes                                                                                                           |
|-----------------------------------------|-----------------------|---------------------|-----------|----------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Mother of Thyme (Creeping Thyme)</b> | <i>T. serpyllum</i>   | 5–10cm, mat-forming | Summer    | At pot level   | Well-drained to dry, poor soil; the more commonly grown culinary/ornamental mat thyme                           |
| <b>Wild Thyme</b>                       | <i>T. polytrichus</i> | 2–5cm, mat-forming  | Summer    | At pot level   | Native Irish wildflower of dry grassland, heaths, dunes and stone walls; needs the sharpest drainage of the two |

**Light:** ☀ Full sun essential for both — requires maximum sunshine and warmth.

**Soil needs:** Mother of Thyme: well-drained to dry, poor soil, pH 6.0–8.0 — dislikes wet clay, a raised bed or pot is essential. Wild Thyme: free-draining, alkaline to neutral soil, tolerant of poor/shallow ground, pH 6.5–7.5 — genuinely native to Ireland on dry grassland, heaths, dunes and stone walls; in the cooler, wetter north and west it also tolerates some acidic soils better than in drier parts of Britain.

**Soil prep:** Mother of Thyme: 40–50% grit mixed with compost, with small pebbles as a surface mulch. Wild Thyme: improve clay generously with 30–40% horticultural grit — this is one of the least clay-tolerant plants in the guide and needs sharp drainage above all else; a raised bed, gravel garden or wall-top setting suits it far better than flat ground.

**Planting depth:** At pot level for both.

**Spacing:** Mother of Thyme: 20–30cm between plants. Wild Thyme: 20–30cm between plants; spreads by runners to form a dense, low mat.

**Fertiliser:** Mother of Thyme: very low nutrient requirements — evolved on lean soil; a very light dressing of balanced fertiliser in spring is the maximum needed, and do not feed in summer or autumn, since a grit mulch is more beneficial than fertiliser. Wild Thyme: none required — a genuine stress-tolerator adapted to poor, lean soil; feeding produces weak, less aromatic growth.

**Companions:** Mother of Thyme: rosemary, oregano, lavender, creeping juniper; grows beautifully between paving stones or on dry walls, and alongside pasqueflower in a raised sunny bed. Wild Thyme: sempervivum, saxifrage, wall pennywort — classic dry rockery/gravel garden companions.

**West of Ireland:** Mother of Thyme needs a raised bed or pot to perform reliably on west of Ireland clay. Wild Thyme is a true native Irish wildflower, common on dry grassland, coastal heath and old stone walls, and the larval food plant of the large blue butterfly in Britain — distinct from Mother of Thyme, it is less commonly used in cooking and better suited to a dry wildflower bank, rockery or scented lawn than a kitchen bed.

## GII. Wall Pennywort (*Umbilicus rupestris*)

 **Reference photo:** [Wall Pennywort — view source](#)

**Light:** 🌞 Partial to full shade; tolerates some sun.

**Soil needs:** Free-draining, near-neutral, gritty soil, often rooting in very little soil at all; pH 6.0–7.5.

**Soil prep:** Minimal — this native succulent naturally colonises old stone walls, rock crevices and dry-stone boundaries. In a border, improve clay with grit; it is otherwise best established directly into a wall crevice or dry-stone gap with a little compost.

**Planting depth:** At pot level, or tucked into a wall crevice.

**Spacing:** 15–20cm between plants

**Fertiliser:** None required.

**Companions:** Ivy, ferns and other wall/shade plants at the base of old walls; sempervivum and saxifrage on drier wall tops.

**West of Ireland:** Common throughout Ireland on damp, shaded stone walls, banks and tree bases — an easy, attractive native succulent for softening an old wall or boundary; young leaves are edible in salads with a mild, slightly salty-cucumber flavour.

## GROUP H: KITCHEN HERBS & VEGETABLES

### HI. Catnip (*Nepeta cataria*)

 **Reference photo:** [Catnip — view source](#)

**Light:** 🌞 Full sun to 🌞 partial shade.

**Soil needs:** Well-drained soil; pH 6.0–7.5. Tolerant of poor soil.

**Soil prep:** Improve clay with compost and grit.

**Planting depth:** At pot level.

**Spacing:** 30–45cm between plants

**Fertiliser:** Little required; over-feeding produces floppy, less aromatic growth.

**Companions:** Brassicas (said to deter flea beetle and cabbage moth), roses (said to deter aphids); popular with cats, which can damage young plants by rolling on them.

**West of Ireland:** Easy and reliable, though may need protection from cats when young (a cloche or wire cage over new plants prevents damage until established). Trim after flowering to keep compact and encourage fresh growth.

### H2. Coriander (*Coriandrum sativum*)

 **Reference photo:** [Coriander — view on Wikipedia](#)

**Light:** 🌞 Full sun to partial shade. Shade reduces bolting — useful in the cool west of Ireland.

**Soil needs:** Light, well-drained, fertile, pH 6.0–7.0. Annual. Do NOT transplant — sow direct.

**Planting depth:** Sow direct 5mm deep. Thin to 15–20cm.

**Spacing:** 15–20cm between plants

**Fertiliser:** Minimal. Light balanced liquid feed once or twice during growing season. Do not overfeed — promotes fast, leafy bolting growth.

**Companions:** Parsley, brassicas (nearby). Do NOT grow adjacent to fennel or dill (cross-pollination ruins flavour of both if they flower together). Attracts beneficial insects.

### H3. Cucumbers (*Cucumis sativus*)

 **Reference photo:** [Cucumbers — view source](#)

**Light:** ☀ Full sun, sheltered from wind.

**Soil needs:** Rich, moisture-retentive but well-drained soil; pH 6.0–7.0.

**Soil prep:** Dig in plenty of well-rotted compost/manure. Raise beds or mound slightly on heavy clay for better drainage and warmth.

**Planting depth:** At pot level, after all risk of frost has passed (outdoor "ridge" types) or under cover for greenhouse types.

**Spacing:** 45–60cm between plants

**Fertiliser:** High-potash liquid feed (tomato feed) weekly once fruits begin to set.

**Companions:** Nasturtiums (trap crop for aphids), dill, sweetcorn as a windbreak.

**West of Ireland:** Outdoor "ridge" cucumbers cope reasonably with the cooler west of Ireland summer, though a sheltered, sunny spot or polytunnel/greenhouse gives more reliable results and a longer season than fully exposed outdoor growing.

### H4. Dill (*Anethum graveolens*)

 **Reference photo:** [Dill — view on Wikipedia](#)

**Light:** ☀ Full sun. Sheltered from wind (tall and floppy).

**Soil needs:** Moist, medium-to-well-drained, pH 5.5–7.0. Annual. Sow direct.

**Planting depth:** Sow direct, cover 3–5mm. Thin to 20–30cm.

**Spacing:** 20–30cm between plants

**Fertiliser:** Minimal. Light balanced fertiliser once during the season. Overfeeding promotes rapid bolting.

**Companions:** Brassicas, lettuce, cucumbers. Do NOT plant near fennel or coriander (cross-pollination). Attracts hoverflies and beneficial insects.

### H5. Green Onions (*Allium fistulosum*)

 **Reference photo:** [Green Onions / Scallions — view source](#)

**Light:** ☀ Full sun to 🌤 partial shade.

**Soil needs:** Fertile, well-drained soil; pH 6.0–7.0.

**Soil prep:** Improve clay with compost; light and free-draining is best.

**Planting depth:** Sow seed 1cm deep, or plant sets at pot level, spring through summer for successional harvests.

**Spacing:** 5–8cm between plants; sow successionally

**Fertiliser:** Balanced liquid feed monthly through the growing season.

**Companions:** Carrots (mutually deters carrot fly and onion fly), rocket, radish — classic salad-bed companions.

**West of Ireland:** Fast, easy, and can be sown successionally every few weeks from spring to late summer for a continuous harvest of mild, slender salad onions.

### H6. Lavender (*Lavandula angustifolia*)

 **Reference photo:** [Lavender — view source](#)

**Light:** ☀ Full sun essential — at least 6 hours daily.

**Soil needs:** Free-draining, poor to moderately fertile, neutral to alkaline soil; pH 6.5–8.0. Excellent drainage is essential — dislikes sitting in wet clay, especially over winter.

**Soil prep:** Mix clay generously with 30%+ horticultural grit, or plant on a raised mound/bed. A layer of grit or pebbles as surface mulch keeps the crown dry.

**Planting depth:** At pot level; do not bury the woody base.

**Spacing:** 30–45cm between plants

**Fertiliser:** Very little required — rich soil produces soft, less aromatic growth prone to winter damage.

**Companions:** Roses (classic underplanting), rosemary, thyme and other Mediterranean herbs with the same sun/drainage needs.

**West of Ireland:** Along with rosemary, one of the herbs most likely to struggle on wet west of Ireland clay in winter — a raised bed, gritty mound, or large terracotta container in a sheltered, sunny spot gives much better results than open ground. Trim lightly after flowering; avoid cutting into old bare wood.

#### H7. Lemon Balm (*Melissa officinalis*)

 **Reference photo:** [Melissa / Lemon Balm — view source](#)

**Light:** ☀ Full sun to ☁ partial shade.

**Soil needs:** Most moist, well-drained soils including clay; pH 6.0–7.5.

**Soil prep:** Mix clay 50/50 with compost.

**Planting depth:** At pot level.

**Spacing:** 30–45cm between plants; spreads readily

**Fertiliser:** Little required; over-feeding produces excess soft growth.

**Companions:** Brassicas, tomatoes; attractive to bees when in flower.

**West of Ireland:** Easy, vigorous, and self-seeds/spreads readily — best in a container or a bed where its spread can be controlled, similar to mint. Fresh lemon-scented leaves are excellent for tea.

#### H8. Mint (*Mentha* spp.)

 **Reference photo:** [Mint — view on Wikipedia](#)

**Light:** ☀ Full sun to ☁ partial shade. More aromatic in sun; more leaves in shade.

**Soil needs:** Moist, fertile, pH 6.0–7.0. ⚠ **Always grow in a container or with a deep root barrier — invasive spreader.**

**Planting depth:** At pot level. Root barrier in ground should be 30cm deep. Container minimum 30cm diameter and depth.

**Spacing:** 60cm if in ground with root barrier

**Fertiliser:** Balanced liquid feed monthly during the growing season. Cut back after flowering and feed to encourage fresh growth. Repot yearly into fresh compost.

**Companions:** Use pots of mint near brassicas, tomatoes, and beans as a pest deterrent (volatile oils without the invasive roots). Peppermint near roses reportedly deters aphids.

#### H9. Nasturtiums (*Tropaeolum majus*)

 **Reference photo:** [Nasturtiums — view source](#)

**Light:** ☀ Full sun to ☁ partial shade.

**Soil needs:** Poor to moderately fertile, well-drained soil; pH 6.0–7.5. Rich soil produces excess leaves at the expense of flowers.

**Soil prep:** Minimal — nasturtiums thrive on poor soil; avoid heavy feeding or over-improving the ground.

**Planting depth:** Sow seed 1–2cm deep, direct after frost risk has passed.

**Spacing:** 20–30cm between plants; annual, self-seeds

**Fertiliser:** None to very little required.

**Companions:** Already used throughout this guide as a companion plant for apples, brassicas and cucumbers — nasturtiums act as a "trap crop" drawing aphids and cabbage white butterflies away from vegetables, and the peppery leaves and flowers are edible in salads.

**West of Ireland:** One of the easiest, most useful companion flowers for the vegetable garden — self-seeds readily and tolerates poor, dry corners well, though it can be checked by heavy Atlantic rain in a very wet summer.

#### H11. Oregano / Wild Marjoram (*Origanum vulgare*)

 **Reference photo:** [Oregano / Wild Marjoram — view on Wikipedia](#)

**Light:** ☀ Full sun — open, sunny position for best aroma and flavour.

**Soil needs:** Well-drained, slightly alkaline preferred, pH 6.5–8.0.

**Soil prep:** 30–40% grit to clay/compost mix. Raised beds ideal.

**Planting depth:** At pot level.

**Spacing:** 30–45cm between plants

**Fertiliser:** Low nutrient requirements. Light balanced fertiliser in spring only. Avoid nitrogen-heavy feeds (reduces aromatic oil content).  
**Container:** monthly balanced liquid at half-strength during growing season.

**Companions:** Thyme, rosemary, sage. Oregano flowers attract pollinators very effectively — excellent companion for fruit trees, raspberries, and other fruiting plants.

## H12. Radish (*Raphanus sativus*)

 **Reference photo:** [Radish — view source](#)

**Light:** ☀ Full sun to 🌤 partial shade.

**Soil needs:** Light, fertile, well-drained soil, free of stones; pH 6.0–7.0.

**Soil prep:** Improve clay with compost and grit for a looser, freer-draining bed — stony or heavy clay produces misshapen roots.

**Planting depth:** Sow seed 1cm deep, direct, from spring through late summer for successional harvests.

**Spacing:** 2–3cm between plants; sow successionally

**Fertiliser:** Little required; rich soil produces excess leaf at the expense of the root.

**Companions:** Carrots, lettuce, green onions — classic salad-bed companions; also used as a fast "marker crop" sown alongside slower vegetables.

**West of Ireland:** One of the fastest vegetables to harvest (as little as 3–4 weeks), making it ideal for succession sowing every couple of weeks through the growing season.

## H13. Rocket (*Eruca sativa*)

 **Reference photo:** [Rocket — view source](#)

**Light:** ☀ Full sun to 🌤 partial shade (some shade helps prevent premature bolting in summer heat).

**Soil needs:** Fertile, moisture-retentive but well-drained soil; pH 6.0–7.0.

**Soil prep:** Improve clay with compost.

**Planting depth:** Sow seed 1cm deep, direct, spring through autumn for successional harvests.

**Spacing:** 15–20cm between plants; sow successionally

**Fertiliser:** Balanced liquid feed occasionally through the growing season.

**Companions:** Radish, green onions, lettuce — classic salad-bed companions.

**West of Ireland:** Fast-growing and easy; keep well watered and pick young leaves regularly to delay bolting (running to flower), which happens quickly in dry or hot spells. Sow successionally every few weeks for a continuous supply.

## H14. Rosemary (*Salvia rosmarinus*, syn. *Rosmarinus officinalis*)

 **Reference photo:** [Rosemary — view source](#)

**Light:** ☀ Full sun essential — at least 6 hours daily. Poor, leggy growth and reduced flavour in shade.

**Soil needs:** Free-draining, poor to moderately fertile soil; pH 6.0–7.5. Excellent drainage is essential — rosemary is Mediterranean in origin and will not tolerate sitting in wet clay, especially over winter.

**Soil prep:** Mix clay generously with 30%+ horticultural grit, or plant on a raised mound/bed. Add a layer of grit or pebbles as surface mulch to keep the crown dry.

**Planting depth:** At pot level; do not bury the woody base.

**Spacing:** 45–60cm between plants

**Fertiliser:** Very little required — rich soil produces soft, less aromatic growth. A light balanced feed in spring is sufficient. Container plants: occasional liquid feed through summer.

**Companions:** Classic companion for brassicas (deters cabbage moth), carrots and beans in the vegetable garden; also thyme, lavender and other Mediterranean herbs with the same sun/drainage needs.

**West of Ireland:** One of the herbs most likely to struggle on wet west of Ireland clay in winter — a raised bed, gritty mound, or a large terracotta container that can be given a sheltered spot is strongly recommended over open ground. Trim lightly after flowering to keep compact; avoid cutting into old bare wood.

### Hi5. Scurvy Grass (*Cochlearia officinalis*)

 **Reference photo:** [Scurvy Grass — view source](#)

**Light:** ☀ Full sun to 🌤 partial shade.

**Soil needs:** Moist but well-drained soil, tolerant of salty/coastal conditions; pH 6.5–7.5.

**Soil prep:** Improve clay with compost; naturally grows in fairly poor, gritty or rocky coastal ground, so avoid over-rich soil.

**Planting depth:** At pot level, or sow seed on the surface.

**Spacing:** 15–20cm between plants

**Fertiliser:** Little required.

**Companions:** Sea kale, other coastal/salt-tolerant edible plants if grown in a coastal garden setting.

**West of Ireland:** A native coastal plant of saltmarshes, cliffs and rocky shores right around the Irish coast, historically eaten by sailors for its high vitamin C content (hence the name). Leaves have a strong, peppery, mustard-like flavour, best used sparingly in salads; happiest in a sunny spot that isn't far removed from its natural coastal, slightly salty preference.

### Hi6. Zucchini / Courgette (*Cucurbita pepo*)

 **Reference photo:** [Zucchini / Courgette — view source](#)

**Light:** ☀ Full sun, sheltered from wind.

**Soil needs:** Rich, moisture-retentive but well-drained soil; pH 6.0–7.0.

**Soil prep:** Dig in plenty of well-rotted compost/manure into a planting hole or mound — courgettes are hungry, thirsty plants.

**Planting depth:** At pot level, after all risk of frost has passed.

**Spacing:** 60–90cm between plants

**Fertiliser:** High-potash liquid feed (tomato feed) weekly once flowering/fruiting begins.

**Companions:** Nasturtiums (trap crop), sweetcorn, beans — classic "three sisters"-adjacent vegetable bed companions.

**West of Ireland:** Very productive in a warm, sheltered, sunny spot; keep well watered in dry spells and harvest fruit young and regularly (every 2–3 days once cropping) to keep plants producing through the season.

## GROUP P: ORNAMENTAL PERENNIALS

### P1. Astilbe (*Astilbe* spp.)

 **Reference photo:** [Astilbe — view on Wikipedia](#)

**Light:** 🌤 Partial shade to full sun if soil stays moist. Best in partial shade — avoids leaf scorch. Excellent beside ponds or in moisture-rich borders.

**Soil needs:** Moist, humus-rich, clay-tolerant. pH 5.5–7.0.

**Soil prep:** Add generous compost. No heavy grit needed.

**Planting depth:** At pot level; crown at soil surface.

**Spacing:** 30–45cm between plants

**Fertiliser:** Balanced fertiliser in spring. Generous compost or bark mulch — the most important care task. Do not let the plant dry out.

**Companions:** Hostas (perfect pairing), ferns, hellebores, rodgersias. Primulas in spring, astilbe in summer for successive display in the same moist bed.

### P2. Auricula (*Primula auricula*)

 **Reference photo:** [Auricula — view source](#)

**Light:** 🌤 Partial shade; protect from strong midday sun.

**Soil needs:** Free-draining, humus-rich soil; neutral to slightly alkaline, pH 6.5–7.5.

**Soil prep:** Improve clay generously with grit and compost; best in a raised bed, trough or pot given its need for sharp drainage.

**Planting depth:** Crown at soil level; do not bury.

**Spacing:** 15–20cm between plants

**Fertiliser:** Balanced liquid feed monthly through the growing season, stopping in winter.

**Companions:** Other alpine/trough plants such as saxifrage and sempervivum; traditionally displayed in individual pots on a shelf ("auricula theatre").

**West of Ireland:** Alpine primula relative, best grown in pots or a raised trough rather than open clay, since winter wet is the main threat. Divide congested clumps every 2–3 years after flowering.

### P3. Irises (Iris spp.)

 **Reference photos:** [Bearded Iris](#) · [Siberian Iris](#) · [Yellow Flag Iris](#)

| Species                    | Latin name            | Height    | Flowering               | Planting depth                                            | Notes                                                                        |
|----------------------------|-----------------------|-----------|-------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Bearded Iris (Border Iris) | <i>I. germanica</i>   | 60–90cm   | Early summer (May–June) | Rhizome at/just proud of soil surface, top exposed to sun | Classic sunny-border iris; needs sharp drainage, rots in wet clay            |
| Siberian Iris              | <i>I. sibirica</i>    | 60–100cm  | May–June                | Rhizome at soil level or 2–3cm below                      | Thrives in moist, heavy clay and tolerates boggy ground, unlike Bearded Iris |
| Yellow Flag Iris           | <i>I. pseudacorus</i> | 90cm–1.5m | May–July                | Crown at soil level; 0–20cm water above                   | Native pond-margin iris; tolerates standing water; spreads vigorously        |

**Light:** ☀ Full sun essential for Bearded Iris — at least 6 hours daily for good flowering. Siberian Iris flowers most freely in full sun but tolerates dappled shade. Yellow Flag Iris flowers best in full sun but tolerates light/partial shade.

**Soil needs:** The three species have almost opposite soil preferences, so choose the right one for your site. Bearded Iris: free-draining, neutral to slightly alkaline soil, pH 6.5–7.5 — rhizomes rot in wet, poorly-drained clay, which is the single biggest cause of failure. Siberian Iris: moist, fertile, neutral to slightly acidic soil, pH 5.8–7.0 — the RHS confirms Siberian irises "do well in heavy clay soil" and prefer consistently moist conditions, tolerating slightly boggy ground near ponds or streams. Yellow Flag Iris: moist to wet rich soil; pond margin/bog zone with 0–20cm of water over the soil surface, or reliably damp ground — the only one of the three suited to standing water.

**Soil prep:** Bearded Iris: improve clay generously with 30% horticultural grit; raised beds or mounded planting strongly recommended on heavy soil. Siberian Iris: dig in generous compost (50/50 with clay) — no need for heavy grit, since this species actually prefers moisture-retentive conditions; mulch each autumn with bark or compost to retain moisture and protect the rhizome crowns. Yellow Flag Iris: plant in an aquatic basket with aquatic compost at the pond margin, or directly into boggy clay.

**Planting depth:** Bearded Iris: rhizome at or just proud of the soil surface, top exposed to sun — do not bury, unlike most other rhizomes. Siberian Iris: at soil level or just 2–3cm below, planted in spring or early autumn. Yellow Flag Iris: crown at soil level, with the basket set so water sits 0–20cm above the soil surface (can grow in up to 25–30cm depth); basket size 19–24cm diameter, or plant directly into boggy clay at pond margins.

**Spacing:** Bearded Iris: 30–45cm between rhizomes, divide every 3–4 years. Siberian Iris: 30–45cm between plants; clumps spread slowly outward over years, divide every 3–5 years. Yellow Flag Iris: 30–60cm between plants; very vigorous, divide every 2–3 years.

**Fertiliser:** Bearded Iris: low-nitrogen, high-potash feed (e.g. tomato feed) in spring and again after flowering — avoid manure or high-nitrogen feeds, which encourage rot. Siberian Iris: a single balanced fertiliser (e.g. Growmore) application in early spring is usually sufficient; avoid high-nitrogen feeds, which promote leafy growth at the expense of flowers, and do not feed in late summer or autumn. Yellow Flag Iris: aquatic fertiliser tablets pushed into the basket compost at the start of the growing season.

**Companions:** Bearded Iris: roses, peonies, alliums — classic sunny border companions with similar sun and drainage needs. Siberian Iris: excellent at pond edges alongside Yellow Flag Iris, bogbean and meadowsweet; in borders, works beautifully with astilbe, hostas, daylilies, primulas and ornamental grasses, and pairs well with native royal fern for a classic Atlantic garden look; alliums flower slightly earlier and make a good succession companion. Yellow Flag Iris: white water lily, bogbean, bog pimpernel, meadowsweet, royal fern at pond/boggy margins — dense clumps give refuge for amphibians and emergent support for dragonflies.

**Pot/container:** Siberian Iris:  possible in a 35–40cm diameter / 15–20L container, using multipurpose compost with extra moisture retention (vermiculite rather than grit); keep consistently moist. Bearded and Yellow Flag Iris are not well suited to pots — Bearded needs a wide, shallow container with excellent drainage if attempted; Yellow Flag needs a pond or large water feature.

**Warnings** ⚠: Yellow Flag Iris sap can cause skin irritation — wear gloves when handling. It also spreads vigorously by rhizomes and seed and can overtake native plants in wet sites — keep it in an aquatic basket to control spread in smaller ponds.

**West of Ireland:** Between them, these three cover almost every garden situation. Bearded Iris needs a raised, gritty, south-facing bed to do well on west of Ireland clay, and congested clumps should be divided every 3–4 years, discarding the older woody centre and replanting healthy young rhizomes. Siberian Iris, by contrast, is an outstanding choice for the region — unlike Bearded Iris it actively thrives in the moist, heavy soil typical of the Atlantic coast, is fully hardy to -20°C, and flowers May–June in blue, purple, violet or white



depending on cultivar (good choices: 'Caesar's Brother', 'White Swirl', 'Flight of Butterflies'). Yellow Flag Iris is a native Irish plant found wild in fens, marshes and river margins throughout the country, and is one of the most reliable and beautiful marginal pond plants for Irish conditions.

#### P4. Blue Gentian (*Gentiana* spp., e.g. *G. acaulis*, *G. sino-ornata*)

 Reference photo: [Blue Gentian — view source](#)

**Light:** ☀ Full sun to ☁ partial shade, depending on species.

**Soil needs:** Moist but well-drained, humus-rich soil; most garden gentians prefer slightly acid conditions, pH 5.5–6.5.

**Soil prep:** Mix clay with compost and grit; a raised bed or rockery suits most species well.

**Planting depth:** Crown at soil level.

**Spacing:** 20–30cm between plants

**Fertiliser:** Light balanced or ericaceous feed in spring. Annual mulch with compost or leaf mould.

**Companions:** Heather, dwarf conifers, saxifrage — classic rockery/alpine-bed companions.

**West of Ireland:** Intensely blue, trumpet-shaped autumn or spring flowers (depending on species) make this a rockery highlight. The moist, mild west of Ireland climate suits autumn-flowering Asiatic gentians (*G. sino-ornata* type) particularly well, given reasonably acid soil.

#### P5. Bellflowers (Border) (*Campanula* spp.)

 Reference photos: [Clustered Bellflower](#) · [Spreading Bellflower](#) · [Peach-leaved Bellflower](#)

| Species                 | Latin name             | Height  | Flowering | Planting depth                            | Notes                                                                                                  |
|-------------------------|------------------------|---------|-----------|-------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Clustered Bellflower    | <i>C. glomerata</i>    | 30–60cm | Summer    | Crown at soil level                       | Dense clusters of violet-purple, upward-facing bells; spreads by rhizomes into good-sized clumps       |
| Spreading Bellflower    | <i>C. patula</i>       | 30–60cm | Summer    | Crown at soil level, or surface-sown seed | Open, star-shaped violet-blue bells on branching stems; biennial/short-lived native wildflower         |
| Peach-leaved Bellflower | <i>C. persicifolia</i> | 60cm–1m | June–July | Crown at soil level                       | Tall, elegant spires of large cup-shaped lilac-blue or white bells; a classic cottage-garden perennial |

**Light:** ☀ Full sun to ☁ partial shade for all three.

**Soil needs:** *C. glomerata*: most well-drained soils including clay, preferring neutral to alkaline, pH 6.5–7.5. *C. patula*: well-drained soil, pH 6.0–7.5. *C. persicifolia*: moist but well-drained, fertile soil.

**Soil prep:** *C. glomerata*: mix clay 50/50 with compost. *C. patula*: mix clay with compost and grit. *C. persicifolia*: mix clay 50/50 with compost, ensuring reasonable moisture retention alongside drainage.

**Planting depth:** *C. glomerata* and *C. persicifolia*: crown at soil level. *C. patula*: crown at soil level, or sow seed on the surface in late spring/summer.

**Spacing:** *C. glomerata*: 30–40cm between plants, divide every 3–4 years. *C. patula*: 20–30cm between plants; biennial/short-lived. *C. persicifolia*: 30–45cm between plants; divide every 2–4 years.

**Fertiliser:** Light balanced feed in spring for all three; *C. glomerata* also benefits from an annual compost mulch.

**Companions:** *C. glomerata*: roses, peonies, ornamental grasses — sunny cottage-border companions. *C. patula*: ox-eye daisy, wild grasses, other cottage/meadow-style companions. *C. persicifolia*: delphiniums, roses, lupins — classic tall cottage-border companions; excellent as a cut flower.

**West of Ireland:** *C. glomerata* spreads by rhizomes to form good-sized clumps — divide every 3–4 years to keep vigorous and control spread in smaller borders. *C. patula* is a biennial or short-lived perennial native British/Irish wildflower, distinct from the more vigorously spreading (and often invasive in gardens) *Campanula rapunculoides* — self-seeds gently; deadhead if self-seeding is not wanted. *C. persicifolia* is a widely grown cottage-garden classic that self-seeds readily in the right conditions and performs well in the cool, moist Irish climate; deadhead to prolong flowering.

#### P6. Columbine (*Aquilegia vulgaris* and hybrids)

 Reference photo: [Aquilegia — view source](#)

**Light:** ☀ Full sun to ☁ partial shade.

**Soil needs:** Moist but well-drained soil; pH 6.0–7.5. Tolerant of clay if not waterlogged.

**Soil prep:** Mix clay 50/50 with compost.

**Planting depth:** Crown at soil level.

**Spacing:** 30–45cm between plants; self-seeds freely

**Fertiliser:** Light balanced feed in spring. Annual compost mulch.

**Companions:** Foxgloves, hardy geraniums, roses — classic cottage-garden border companions; self-seeds readily among other perennials.

**West of Ireland:** Easy, reliable, and self-seeds freely — often needs thinning rather than encouraging once established. Distinctive spurred flowers in a wide range of colours through late spring/early summer.

## P7. Coral Bells (*Heuchera* spp.)

 **Reference photo:** [Coral Bells — view source](#)

**Light:** 🌤️ Partial shade preferred; purple/dark-leaved varieties tolerate more sun, green/lime varieties prefer more shade.

**Soil needs:** Moist but well-drained soil, rich in organic matter; pH 6.0–7.0.

**Soil prep:** Mix clay 50/50 with compost and 20% grit for drainage — *Heuchera* dislikes waterlogging, especially in winter.

**Planting depth:** Crown at soil level — do not bury the crown, which can cause rot.

**Spacing:** 30–45cm between plants

**Fertiliser:** Balanced liquid feed monthly through the growing season. Light annual mulch with compost, keeping it away from the crown.

**Companions:** Hostas, astilbe, ferns, hellebores — classic shade/part-shade border and edging companions; excellent foliage contrast plant.

**West of Ireland:** Reliable, low-maintenance evergreen/semi-evergreen foliage perennial. Divide congested clumps every 3 years in spring or autumn to keep vigorous.

## P8. Cutleaf Coneflower 'Goldball' (*Rudbeckia laciniata* 'Goldball')

 **Reference photo:** [Rudbeckia 'Goldball' — view on Wikipedia](#)

**Light:** ☀️ Full sun preferred. Will flower in light shade, but the shadier the location the less they will flower.

**Soil needs:** A good choice for improved clay soils — easy to grow if given full sun or partial shade and a moderately fertile soil that is moist but well-drained. pH 5.5–7.0. Moisture-retentive soil is important — dislikes prolonged dry periods in summer.

**Soil prep:** Add generous compost to clay (50/50). If the soil is very heavy or is not free draining, add lots of well-rotted compost to the area and dig it in well.

**Planting depth:** At pot level. Plant bare-root crowns with buds 2–3cm below soil.

**Spacing:** 60–90cm between; divide every 2–3 yrs

**Fertiliser:** *Rudbeckia* needs little or no regular applications of fertiliser in most garden soils. Mulching plants in borders with well-rotted manure or garden compost each spring should be sufficient. Certainly do not feed with nitrogen-rich fertilisers — this will only encourage leaf growth at the expense of flowers.

**Special note on *R. laciniata*:** *R. laciniata* has vigorous rhizomes (horizontal underground stems) that make it better suited to larger gardens. It might need lifting, dividing and reducing every two to three years to keep it in check. *R. laciniata* can reach 3m (10ft). This tall variety is inclined to flop, so pinch out the shoots in early summer to promote strong and bushy growth, or provide support.

**Companions:** Helenium, echinacea, late-flowering salvias, ornamental grasses, asters for a dramatic late-summer/autumn border. Excellent with purple-flowered plants (*veronicastrum*, *verbena bonariensis*). The tall flowers of 'Goldball' are stunning in naturalistic or prairie-style planting schemes.

**Pot size:** For containers, use a liquid fertiliser such as Phostrogen or seaweed feed. Minimum 40–50cm diameter; deep container needed given eventual 2–3m height. ⚠️ Better in-ground given ultimate vigour.

**West of Ireland:** *Rudbeckia* does very well in the moist, cool-summer Irish climate. Does not suffer from drought issues. Excellent for late summer colour when many plants are declining. Divide regularly to prevent uncontrolled spread.

## P9. Daylilies (*Hemerocallis* spp.)

 **Reference photo:** [Daylilies — view source](#)

**Light:** ☀️ Full sun to 🌤️ partial shade.

**Soil needs:** Most soils including clay, tolerant of a wide pH range 6.0–7.5. One of the easiest, most clay-tolerant border perennials.

**Soil prep:** Mix clay 50/50 with compost; grit optional, since daylilies are notably tolerant of heavy soil.

**Planting depth:** Crown at soil level, roots spread out in the hole.

**Spacing:** 45–60cm between plants; divide every 3–4 yrs

**Fertiliser:** Balanced feed in spring. Annual compost mulch.

**Companions:** Roses, ornamental grasses, achillea (yarrow) — classic sunny border companions.

**West of Ireland:** Extremely tough, reliable, and genuinely clay-tolerant — one of the best "no-fuss" flowering perennials for west of Ireland gardens. Each flower lasts only a day, but a well-established clump produces a long succession of blooms through summer. Divide every 3–4 years to rejuvenate.

## Pro. Delphiniums (*Delphinium* spp.)

 **Reference photo:** [Delphiniums — view on Wikipedia](#)

**Light:** ☀ Full sun — 6+ hours. Wind shelter equally essential.

**Soil needs:** Rich, fertile, well-drained, pH 6.5–7.5.

**Soil prep:** Dig 40–50cm deep; generous compost and 20% grit on heavy clay.

**Planting depth:** At pot level; bare-root buds 2–5cm below soil.

**Spacing:** 60–90cm between plants; stake essential

**Fertiliser:** Balanced granular fertiliser in early spring. High-potash liquid feed (tomato feed) fortnightly from bud formation through flowering. After first flush: cut stems, apply balanced liquid feed to encourage second flush. Annual well-rotted manure mulch.

**Companions:** Roses, lupins, peonies, alliums, irises in cottage-garden combination. Staking mandatory. Slug protection critical in the wet west.

## Pr1. Edelweiss (*Leontopodium alpinum*)

 **Reference photo:** [Edelweiss — view source](#)

**Light:** ☀ Full sun.

**Soil needs:** Free-draining, poor to moderately fertile, alkaline soil; pH 6.5–7.5. Excellent drainage essential.

**Soil prep:** Improve clay heavily with 30–40% grit; best in a raised bed, trough or rockery.

**Planting depth:** Crown at soil level.

**Spacing:** 15–20cm between plants

**Fertiliser:** Very little required — rich soil produces soft, less characterful growth.

**Companions:** Sempervivum, saxifrage, other alpine rockery plants with the same sharp-drainage needs.

**West of Ireland:** A true alpine, and one of the more challenging plants on wet west of Ireland clay — reliable success generally needs a raised, gritty, free-draining bed or trough rather than open ground. Silvery-white star-shaped flower bracts in summer.

## Pr2. Elephant's Ears (*Bergenia* spp.)

 **Reference photo:** [Elephant's Ears — view on Wikipedia](#)

**Light:** 🌑 Full shade to ☀ full sun. Leaves colour best in open, exposed positions.

**Soil needs:** Humus-rich, moist but well-drained. Excellent on clay.

**Soil prep:** Add compost. Unfussy.

**Planting depth:** At pot level; rhizome just at or slightly below surface.

**Spacing:** 30–60cm between plants

**Fertiliser:** Low-maintenance. Balanced slow-release in spring, or just annual bark mulch. Do not overfeed.

**Companions:** Hostas, hellebores, snowdrops, pulmonaria, ferns. Bold evergreen foliage contrasts beautifully with delicate fern texture.

### P13. Fern-leaf Peony (*Paeonia tenuifolia*)

 **Reference photo:** [Paeonia tenuifolia — view source](#)

**Light:** ☀ Full sun.

**Soil needs:** Well-drained, fertile soil, neutral to slightly alkaline; pH 6.5–7.5. Dislikes waterlogging, more so than common garden peonies.

**Soil prep:** Mix clay with compost and 20–30% grit for extra drainage.

**Planting depth:** Crown/eyes no more than 2–3cm below soil level — as with all peonies, planting too deep prevents flowering.

**Spacing:** 45–60cm between plants

**Fertiliser:** Balanced fertiliser in spring; light high-potash feed as buds form.

**Companions:** Alliums, bearded iris, catmint — classic sunny border companions with similar drainage needs.

**West of Ireland:** A smaller, earlier-flowering species peony with finely divided, fern-like foliage and deep red single flowers — distinct from the common garden peonies (*Paeonia* spp.) already in this guide. More particular about drainage than common peonies, so a raised or well-drained spot gives the best results on Irish clay.

### P14. Foxgloves (*Digitalis purpurea* and perennial species)

 **Reference photo:** [Foxgloves — view on Wikipedia](#)

**Light:** 🌤 Partial shade to full sun if soil stays moist.

**Soil needs:** Nutrient-rich, moist, pH 5.5–7.5. Native to Ireland.

**Soil prep:** Add compost. Very adaptable. Self-seeding.

**Planting depth:** At pot level; seeds sown on surface (need light to germinate).

**Spacing:** 30–45cm between plants

**Fertiliser:** Low-maintenance — rarely needs feeding. Light balanced fertiliser in spring for vigorous second-year plants. Bark mulch to retain moisture.

**Companions:** Ferns, astilbe, hostas in shaded beds. With roses, alliums, and delphiniums in sunnier borders. Superb companion as they attract bumblebees very effectively.

### P15. Globeflower (*Trollius europaeus* / *T. x cultorum*)

 **Reference photo:** [Trollius — view source](#)

**Light:** ☀ Full sun to 🌤 partial shade.

**Soil needs:** Moist to wet, humus-rich soil; pH 5.5–7.0. Unusually for a border perennial, thrives in damp ground and tolerates heavy clay very well.

**Soil prep:** Mix clay with compost; no need for extra drainage — this plant prefers consistently moist soil.

**Planting depth:** Crown at soil level.

**Spacing:** 30–40cm between plants

**Fertiliser:** Balanced feed in spring. Annual compost mulch, keeping the crown moist.

**Companions:** Astilbe, hosta, candelabra primulas — classic damp border or pond-margin companions.

**West of Ireland:** One of the few showy border perennials genuinely suited to the wetter parts of a west of Ireland garden — round, globe-like yellow or orange flowers on upright stems in late spring. Excellent for a damp border or the margin of a pond garden.

### P16. Hellebore (*Helleborus* spp.)

 **Reference photo:** [Hellebore — view on Wikipedia](#)

**Light:** 🌤 to 🌑 Partial to full shade. Ideal under deciduous trees or shrubs. Avoid full sun which scorches leaves.

**Soil needs:** Humus-rich, fertile, moisture-retentive, pH 6.0–8.0. Excellent on clay.

**Soil prep:** Add generous compost. Annual compost or leaf mould mulch.

**Planting depth:** At pot level; crown just at or slightly below soil surface.

**Spacing:** 45–60cm between plants

**Fertiliser:** Balanced slow-release in early spring after clearing old foliage. Annual compost mulch after flowering — most effective treatment. Takes 2–3 years to settle after planting; do not disturb once established.

**Companions:** Snowdrops (January–March together — one of the great winter garden combinations). Cyclamen coum, pulmonaria, early daffodils. Hostas and ferns alongside in summer.

#### Pr17. Hosta (Hosta spp.)

 **Reference photo:** [Hosta — view on Wikipedia](#)

**Light:** ☀ to 🌑 Partial to full shade. Golden types tolerate more sun; blue-leaved varieties need more shade. Avoid full sun which scorches leaves.

**Soil needs:** Moist, humus-rich, fertile. Grows well on clay.

**Soil prep:** Add generous compost.

**Planting depth:** At pot level; crown just at soil surface.

**Spacing:** 30–90cm (variety-dependent)

**Fertiliser:** Balanced slow-release granular in spring. Balanced liquid feed monthly April through midsummer. Do not feed after August. Annual compost mulch.

**Companions:** Astilbe, ferns, hellebores, bergenia. Snowdrops and winter aconites bloom in the gaps before hostas emerge in spring. ⚠ Slugs and snails are the main challenge in the moist west — wool pellets, copper tape (on pots), or nematode treatments are essential companions.

#### Pr18. Lady's Bedstraw (Galium verum)

 **Reference photo:** [Lady's Bedstraw — view source](#)

**Light:** ☀ Full sun.

**Soil needs:** Well-drained soil, tolerant of poor/dry conditions; pH 6.0–7.5.

**Soil prep:** Minimal — this native wildflower thrives on lean soil; excess compost/fertility encourages weak, floppy growth.

**Planting depth:** Crown at soil level.

**Spacing:** 20–30cm between plants

**Fertiliser:** None required — over-feeding is counterproductive for this meadow wildflower.

**Companions:** Ox-eye daisy, yarrow, wild grasses — classic dry meadow/wildflower planting.

**West of Ireland:** A native wildflower with masses of tiny, honey-scented yellow flowers in summer, traditionally used to stuff mattresses (hence the name) and once used to curdle milk in cheesemaking. Best suited to a wildflower meadow area or dry, sunny bank rather than a fertile border.

#### Pr19. Lilyleaf Ladybells (Adenophora liliifolia)

 **Reference photo:** [Lilyleaf Ladybells — view source](#)

**Light:** ☀ Full sun to 🌤 partial shade.

**Soil needs:** Moist but well-drained soil; pH 6.0–7.5.

**Soil prep:** Mix clay 50/50 with compost.

**Planting depth:** Crown at soil level; resents root disturbance once established (like many bellflower relatives, it has a fleshy taproot), so choose the final position with care.

**Spacing:** 30–40cm between plants

**Fertiliser:** Light balanced feed in spring. Annual compost mulch.

**Companions:** Other cottage-border perennials such as clustered bellflower, delphiniums, phlox.

**West of Ireland:** A relative of the campanulas, with nodding, pale blue-violet bell flowers on upright stems in summer. Less commonly available than campanulas but similarly easy once settled — best left undisturbed once planted.

## P20. Lungworts (*Pulmonaria* spp.)

 **Reference photo:** [Lungworts — view source](#)

**Light:** ☀️ Partial to full shade.

**Soil needs:** Moist, humus-rich soil; pH 6.0–7.5. Tolerates clay well if not waterlogged.

**Soil prep:** Mix clay 50/50 with compost.

**Planting depth:** Crown at soil level.

**Spacing:** 30–40cm between plants; divide every 3–4 yrs

**Fertiliser:** Light balanced feed in spring. Annual compost mulch.

**Companions:** Hellebores, ferns, hostas — classic early-spring woodland/shade border planting; one of the earliest nectar sources for bees.

**West of Ireland:** Reliable, easy, semi-evergreen shade perennial with attractively spotted leaves and pink-to-blue spring flowers (often both colours on the same plant). Spreads gently to form good groundcover under trees and shrubs; divide every 3–4 years.

## P21. Lupins (*Lupinus polyphyllus* and hybrids)

 **Reference photo:** [Lupins — view source](#)

**Light:** ☀️ Full sun to 🌤️ partial shade.

**Soil needs:** Moist but well-drained, slightly acid soil; pH 5.5–6.5. Dislikes shallow chalk.

**Soil prep:** Mix clay 50/50 with compost; avoid excess lime.

**Planting depth:** Crown at soil level; resents root disturbance, so choose the final position with care.

**Spacing:** 45–60cm between plants

**Fertiliser:** Light balanced feed in spring — like other legumes, lupins fix some of their own nitrogen, so avoid overfeeding.

**Companions:** Delphiniums, roses, foxgloves — classic tall cottage-border companions.

**West of Ireland:** Tall, showy flower spikes in early-mid summer in a wide colour range. Slug damage to young shoots is the main challenge on damp Irish clay — protect emerging growth in spring. Cut back after flowering to encourage a possible second, smaller flush.

## P22. Monkshood (*Aconitum napellus*)

 **Reference photo:** [Aconitum / Monkshood — view source](#)

**Light:** 🌤️ Partial shade to full sun; prefers cooler root conditions.

**Soil needs:** Moist, humus-rich soil; pH 6.0–7.5. Tolerates clay well if not waterlogged.

**Soil prep:** Mix clay 50/50 with compost.

**Planting depth:** Crown at soil level.

**Spacing:** 45–60cm between plants; ⚠️ toxic, wear gloves

**Fertiliser:** Balanced liquid feed in spring. Annual compost mulch.

**Companions:** Delphiniums, hostas, astilbe — classic cottage/damp border companions.

**West of Ireland:** Reliable, long-lived tall spikes of deep blue-purple hooded flowers in late summer.

⚠️ All parts are highly toxic if ingested, and sap can irritate skin on contact — wear gloves when handling, and site away from children's play areas and vegetable beds.

## P23. Pasqueflower (*Pulsatilla vulgaris*)

 **Reference photo:** [Pasqueflower — view on Wikipedia](#)

**Light:** ☀️ Full sun — essential. Hates shade.

**Soil needs:** Excellent drainage, pH 6.5–8.0. Hates wet clay. Raised bed or pot essential.

**Soil prep:** 40–50% grit/compost mix in raised bed or container.

**Planting depth:** At pot level. Do not disturb once established.

**Spacing:** 20–30cm between plants

**Fertiliser:** Virtually no feeding needed. Adapted to lean limestone soils. Nitrogen causes floppy, non-flowering growth. Grit mulch on the surface is more beneficial than any fertiliser.

**Companions:** Eryngium, Dianthus, Scabiosa, Achillea, ornamental grasses in a gravel garden. Thyme and other rock garden plants nearby.

#### P24. Peonies (*Paeonia* spp.)

 **Reference photo:** [Peonies — view on Wikipedia](#)

**Light:** ☀ to 🌤 Full sun to partial shade. At least 4–6 hours for good flowering.

**Spacing:** 90cm between plants

**Soil needs:** Free-draining, fertile, pH 6.5–7.0.

**Planting depth (herbaceous):** ⚠ Eyes MAX 2.5–5cm below soil. Too deep = no flowers. The most commonly made planting mistake.

**Planting depth (tree peony):** Graft union 10–15cm below surface.

**Fertiliser:** Balanced fertiliser in early spring as red shoots emerge. High-potash feed (tomato feed) as buds develop. Annual well-rotted compost mulch, keeping mulch away from crown.

**Companions:** Alliums (flower as peonies fade — elegant combination). Salvia, irises, delphiniums in mixed border. Roses, foxgloves, geraniums. Avoid planting near taller shade-casting plants.

#### P25. Perennial Flax (*Linum perenne*)

 **Reference photo:** [Linum / Perennial Flax — view source](#)

**Light:** ☀ Full sun.

**Soil needs:** Well-drained soil, tolerant of poor/dry conditions; pH 6.0–7.5. Dislikes winter wet.

**Soil prep:** Improve clay with grit for drainage.

**Planting depth:** Crown at soil level.

**Spacing:** 20–30cm between plants

**Fertiliser:** Light balanced feed in spring; avoid rich soil, which shortens the plant's lifespan.

**Companions:** Achillea (yarrow), lavender, other sun-loving, drought-tolerant border perennials.

**West of Ireland:** Delicate, sky-blue flowers open fresh each morning through summer on airy, wiry stems. Can be short-lived, especially where drainage is poor — a raised or gritty spot extends its life considerably on Irish clay.

#### P26. Pheasant's Eye (*Adonis vernalis* / *A. amurensis*)

 **Reference photo:** [Adonis — view source](#)

**Light:** ☀ Full sun to 🌤 partial shade (some afternoon shade in summer, when the plant is dormant, is fine).

**Soil needs:** Well-drained, humus-rich soil; neutral to slightly alkaline, pH 6.5–7.5.

**Soil prep:** Improve clay with compost and grit for good drainage.

**Planting depth:** Crown at soil level.

**Spacing:** 20–30cm between plants; ⚠ toxic

**Fertiliser:** Light balanced feed in spring. Annual compost mulch.

**Companions:** Snowdrops, hellebores and other very early spring flowers; goes dormant by summer, so pair with later perennials to fill the gap.

**West of Ireland:** One of the earliest perennials to flower, with bright yellow, buttercup-like blooms often appearing in late winter. Slow to establish and resents disturbance, so choose its position carefully and leave undisturbed once planted.

⚠ All parts are toxic if ingested.

## P27. Pinks & Sweet Williams (*Dianthus* spp.)

 Reference photos: [Sweet William](#) · [Carnation](#) · [Chinese Pink](#) · [Maiden Pink](#) · [Garden Pink](#)

| Species                      | Latin name             | Height  | Flowering            | Planting depth                          | Notes                                                                                                   |
|------------------------------|------------------------|---------|----------------------|-----------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Sweet William                | <i>D. barbatus</i>     | 30–60cm | Early summer         | At pot level; sow June–July (biennial)  | Classic biennial cottage-garden pink with dense flat flowerheads; self-sows readily                     |
| Carnation (Border Carnation) | <i>D. caryophyllus</i> | 45–60cm | Summer (June–August) | At pot level                            | Clove-scented double flowers on a woody-based perennial; tolerates maritime exposure and salt-laden air |
| Chinese Pink                 | <i>D. chinensis</i>    | 15–30cm | Summer               | At pot level, or sow 3mm deep in spring | Usually grown as an annual or short-lived biennial bedding plant rather than a long-term perennial      |
| Maiden Pink                  | <i>D. deltoides</i>    | 15–20cm | Late spring–summer   | At pot level                            | Low, mat-forming groundcover species; RHS AGM; good for rockeries and path edges                        |
| Garden Pink                  | <i>D. plumarius</i>    | 25–35cm | Early–midsummer      | At pot level                            | The classic perennial cottage-garden pink; many named cultivars (e.g. 'Doris', 'Mrs Sinkins')           |

**Light:** ☀ Full sun for all — at least 6 hours daily. Sweet William tolerates partial shade.

**Soil needs:** All prefer neutral to slightly alkaline, well-drained soil, pH roughly 5.8–7.5 depending on species, and dislike waterlogged clay. Good air circulation helps avoid root rot and fungal disease. Carnation is unusually tolerant of salt-laden coastal air.

**Soil prep:** Improve clay with compost and 20–30% horticultural grit for all species — good drainage matters more than exact pH.

**Planting depth:** All at pot level, planted at the same depth as in the nursery pot. Sweet William: sow June–July as a biennial to flower the following year. Chinese Pink: can also be surface-sown (3mm deep) direct in spring. See table above for spacing guidance per species.

**Spacing:** Sweet William and Carnation: 30–35cm and 45–60cm between plants respectively. Chinese Pink: 15–20cm. Maiden Pink: low groundcover, plant 20–30cm apart. Garden Pink: 25–35cm.

**Fertiliser:** Routine feeding is not required for any of them. A well-balanced feed in early spring promotes new growth and flowering; perennial types (Carnation, Garden Pink, Maiden Pink) can also be fed once in late spring with an organic fertiliser such as comfrey or chicken pellets. Container-grown plants of any species benefit from a fortnightly liquid feed while in flower.

**Companions:** Roses, stocks, alliums, lavender, thyme and campanula in a well-drained sunny border; foxgloves, forget-me-nots, wallflowers and pansies alongside Sweet William in particular. Other annual bedding such as cornflower and love-in-a-mist suit Chinese Pink in a cottage-style summer border. Maiden Pink and Garden Pink both combine well with Phlox subulata, Iberis sempervirens and sempervivum at the front of a rockery.

**West of Ireland:** The perennial and biennial types (Carnation, Garden Pink, Sweet William) find the region's wet winters the main challenge — a raised bed with gritty soil or a sheltered, south-facing spot gives the best results, and Sweet William in particular benefits from the mild winters, though it is still best treated as a biennial with fresh seed sown each year. Chinese Pink is best treated as an annual, replanted fresh each year for reliable colour. Maiden Pink is the easiest of the five, forming a trouble-free low mat once given sharp drainage.

## P28. Siberian Statice (*Goniolimon tataricum*)

 Reference photo: [Siberian Statice — view source](#)

**Light:** ☀ Full sun.

**Soil needs:** Well-drained soil, tolerant of poor/dry ground; pH 6.0–7.5. Dislikes winter wet.

**Soil prep:** Improve clay with grit for good drainage.

**Planting depth:** Crown at soil level; deep taproot, so choose the final position with care.

**Spacing:** 30–40cm between plants

**Fertiliser:** Light balanced feed in spring; avoid rich soil.

**Companions:** Ornamental grasses, achillea, sedum — classic gravel-garden or dried-flower border companions.

**West of Ireland:** Airy sprays of small white/papery flowers held well above a basal rosette, popular for drying. Best given a raised, gritty, well-drained spot given the west of Ireland's high rainfall, as it is more prone to winter losses on flat wet clay than many border perennials.



### P30. Stocks (*Matthiola incana* / *M. longipetala*)

 **Reference photo:** [Stocks — view on Wikipedia](#)

**Light:** ☀ Full sun to partial shade. Best fragrance in the evening in a sheltered spot.

**Soil needs:** Well-drained, pH 6.5–7.5. Slightly alkaline preferred.

**Soil prep:** Compost and 20% grit.

**Planting depth:** At pot level; seeds surface-sown.

**Spacing:** 20–30cm between plants

**Fertiliser:** Balanced fertiliser at planting. Liquid tomato feed fortnightly once buds appear. Moderate feeder — do not overfeed with nitrogen.

**Companions:** Wallflowers, sweet William, pansies. Place near seating areas or windows for exceptional evening fragrance.

### P32. Toadflax (*Linaria vulgaris*)

 **Reference photo:** [Toadflax — view source](#)

**Light:** ☀ Full sun to ☀ partial shade.

**Soil needs:** Well-drained soil, tolerant of poor/dry ground; pH 6.0–7.5.

**Soil prep:** Minimal — this native wildflower is unfussy; avoid over-rich soil, which encourages excess soft growth and spread.

**Planting depth:** Crown at soil level, or sow seed on the surface.

**Spacing:** 20–30cm between plants; spreads readily

**Fertiliser:** None required.

**Companions:** Ox-eye daisy, yarrow, other native wildflower meadow companions.

**West of Ireland:** A native wildflower with snapdragon-like yellow and orange flowers on upright spikes through summer, valuable for bees. Spreads by rhizomes and self-seeds readily, so best suited to a wildflower area or informal bank rather than a tidy border, where it can be to be kept in check.

### P33. Vervain (*Verbena officinalis*)

 **Reference photo:** [Vervain — view source](#)

**Light:** ☀ Full sun to ☀ partial shade.

**Soil needs:** Well-drained soil; pH 6.0–7.5. Tolerant of poor, dry conditions once established.

**Soil prep:** Improve clay with compost and grit.

**Planting depth:** Crown at soil level.

**Spacing:** 20–30cm between plants

**Fertiliser:** Little required; avoid rich soil, which produces floppy growth.

**Companions:** Lavender, catmint, ornamental grasses — classic gravel-garden and pollinator-border companions.

**West of Ireland:** A native wildflower with wiry, airy stems of tiny lilac flowers through summer, valuable for pollinators, and long used in traditional herbal medicine. Self-seeds gently; best in a sunny, well-drained spot rather than heavy wet clay.

### P34. Yarrow (*Achillea millefolium*)

 **Reference photo:** [Yarrow — view on Wikipedia](#)

**Light:** ☀ Full sun — at least 6–8 hours. Tolerates partial shade but flowers less freely and becomes leggy.

**Soil needs:** Loamy soil is ideal, but yarrow tolerates clay soil if it drains well. Loosen soil 12–15 inches deep and mix in 2–4 inches of compost before planting. Avoid overly rich soil; too much fertility can cause floppy stems. pH 5.5–7.0. Very adaptable — will grow in poor soil.

**Soil prep:** Loosen soil to 30–40cm depth and mix in compost before planting. Do not add heavy nitrogen; this causes floppy stems. On clay, add 15–20% grit to improve drainage.

**Planting depth:** At pot level; bare-root crowns with buds 2–3cm below soil surface. Space 30–60cm apart.

**Spacing:** 30–60cm between plants; divide every 2–3 yrs

**Fertiliser:** Apply a thin layer of compost each spring. Additional fertiliser is rarely necessary. Over-feeding produces tall, floppy plants that fall over. Yarrow needs little or no regular applications of fertiliser in most garden soils. Mulching plants in borders with well-rotted manure or garden compost each spring should be sufficient.

**Companions:** Yarrow helps deter unwanted pests, attracts native insects and predators like those that manage aphids and caterpillars, and works quietly to improve soil quality by replenishing nutrients. Yarrow pairs beautifully with weigela and hydrangea. Also excellent with roses, delphiniums, salvias, ornamental grasses, and echinacea. One of the best pollinator plants — flat-topped flowers are perfect landing platforms for hoverflies, butterflies and bees. ⚠️ Can spread aggressively in good garden soil — divide every 2–3 years.

**Pot size:** 30cm diameter, 25cm deep container; multipurpose compost with 20% grit.

**West of Ireland:** Native *A. millefolium* grows wild throughout Ireland and is extremely well adapted to Irish conditions. Tolerates the wet, windy west coast. Excellent for naturalistic planting, wildflower meadow schemes, and cottage gardens.

## GROUP S: SHADE & WOODLAND PLANTS

### S1. Common Dog Violet (*Viola riviniana*)

 **Reference photo:** [Common Dog Violet — view source](#)

**Light:** ☀️ Partial shade; tolerates full sun to full shade.

**Soil needs:** Most moist, well-drained soils including clay; pH 5.5–7.0.

**Soil prep:** Minimal — very adaptable native woodland-floor plant.

**Planting depth:** Crown at soil level.

**Spacing:** 15–20cm between plants

**Fertiliser:** None required.

**Companions:** Primroses, wood sorrel, ferns — classic native woodland-floor groundcover; the larval food plant for several fritillary butterflies.

**West of Ireland:** Easy, unfussy native wildflower with violet-blue flowers in spring, valuable groundcover under trees and shrubs, and important for wildlife. Self-seeds gently to form drifts.

### S2. Irish Native Mosses

 **Reference photo:** [Irish Native Mosses — view source](#)

**Light:** ☀️ Partial to full shade; most native mosses scorch in strong, direct sun.

**Spacing:** Establish as low patches; allow to spread and knit together naturally over 1–2 growing seasons.

**Soil/surface needs:** Consistently moist, humid conditions on soil, rock, tree bases, walls or fallen wood; most prefer slightly acid, humus-rich conditions, though some (like common tamarisk-moss) tolerate neutral ground.

**Establishing mosses:** Unlike flowering plants, mosses are not "planted" in the usual sense — they establish from spores or small transplanted clumps ("moss transplant") pressed onto a clean, consistently damp surface (soil, rock, log, or the shaded base of a wall) and kept moist while they knit in, generally over one growing season.

**Care:** No feeding — added fertiliser harms moss. Keep the area free of fallen leaf litter, which can smother it, and maintain humidity/shade; mosses generally do not need protection from cold.

**Companions:** Ferns, wood sorrel, primroses and other shaded, damp woodland-floor plants; mosses are a natural companion groundcover beneath the native ferns already in this guide.

**West of Ireland:** Ireland's mild, exceptionally damp Atlantic climate is superb for mosses generally, and the west of Ireland (especially Kerry's oceanic woodlands) is internationally important for its bryophyte (moss and liverwort) diversity. A shaded, damp corner, old wall, or fallen log left undisturbed will often colonise naturally with little help. A selection of common native species suited to garden conditions:

| Common name            | Species                           | Typical habitat                                                   |
|------------------------|-----------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Fox-tail Feather-moss  | <i>Thamnobryum alopecurum</i>     | Shaded rocks, streamsides, tree bases in humid woodland           |
| Common Tamarisk-moss   | <i>Thuidium tamariscinum</i>      | Damp ground and rotting logs in woodland; tolerates neutral soils |
| Bank Haircap Moss      | <i>Polytrichastrum formosum</i>   | Shaded banks, ditches, woodland and tree stumps on acidic soils   |
| Common Haircap         | <i>Polytrichum commune</i>        | Damp, acidic ground, bog margins and woodland                     |
| Swan's-neck Thyme-moss | <i>Mnium hornum</i>               | Very common on tree bases, rotting wood and acidic woodland floor |
| Springy Turf-moss      | <i>Rhytidiadelphus squarrosus</i> | Damp lawns, banks and open woodland; tolerant of some sun         |

### S3. Lily of the Valley (*Convallaria majalis*)

 Reference photo: [Convallaria — view source](#)

**Light:** 🌤️ Partial to full shade.

**Soil needs:** Moist, humus-rich soil; pH 6.0–7.5. Tolerates clay well if not waterlogged.

**Soil prep:** Mix clay with compost/leaf mould.

**Planting depth:** Rhizome ("pip") 2–3cm deep, growing point up, in autumn.

**Spacing:** 15–20cm between plants; ⚠️ toxic, spreads

**Fertiliser:** Light balanced feed in spring. Annual leaf mould mulch.

**Companions:** Ferns, hostas, hellebores — classic shaded woodland-floor groundcover.

**West of Ireland:** Fragrant white bell flowers in late spring, spreading by rhizomes to form good groundcover under trees and shrubs over time — can be vigorous once established, so give it room or a contained bed if a tidy border is wanted.

⚠️ All parts are toxic if ingested.

### S4. Ferns (Native Irish + Garden Cultivars)

Reference photos: [Male Fern](#) · [Lady Fern](#) · [Broad Buckler Fern](#) · [Hard Shield Fern](#) · [Polypody](#) · [Royal Fern](#) · [Deer Fern](#) · [Fortune's Holly Fern](#) · [Maidenhair Fern](#)

| Fern                                          | Latin Name                                         | Light     | Height       | Notes                                                                                                          |
|-----------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------|-----------|--------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Male Fern                                     | <i>Dryopteris filix-mas</i>                        | 🌤️–<br>●  | 60–<br>100cm | Most robust native; tolerates exposed positions                                                                |
| Lady Fern                                     | <i>Athyrium filix-femina</i>                       | 🌤️        | 60–<br>120cm | Prefers sheltered, moist shade                                                                                 |
| Broad Buckler Fern                            | <i>Dryopteris dilatata</i>                         | 🌤️–<br>●  | 60–<br>100cm | Glossy dark fronds; excellent in deep shade                                                                    |
| Hard Shield Fern                              | <i>Polystichum aculeatum</i>                       | 🌤️        | 45–<br>60cm  | Evergreen; tolerates dry shade & coastal exposure                                                              |
| Polypody                                      | <i>Polypodium vulgare</i>                          | 🌤️        | 15–<br>40cm  | Grows on walls and banks; evergreen                                                                            |
| Royal Fern                                    | <i>Osmunda regalis</i>                             | ☀️–<br>🌤️ | 1–2m         | Loves wet clay and boggy spots; spectacular                                                                    |
| Deer Fern                                     | <i>Blechnum spicant</i>                            | 🌤️–<br>●  | 30–<br>60cm  | Evergreen; needs acidic soil (pH 4.5–6.0)                                                                      |
| Fortune's Holly Fern (var. <i>clivicola</i> ) | <i>Cyrtomium fortunei</i><br>var. <i>clivicola</i> | 🌤️–<br>●  | 30–<br>60cm  | Evergreen; very cold-hardy; bold, glossy fronds; tolerates dry shade                                           |
| Koidzumi's Wood Fern                          | <i>Dryopteris koidzumiana</i>                      | 🌤️–<br>●  | 60–<br>90cm  | Deciduous/semi-evergreen; warm copper new growth; shade and clay tolerant                                      |
| Maidenhair Fern (Himalayan)                   | <i>Adiantum venustum</i>                           | 🌤️–<br>●  | 15–<br>25cm  | Not native, but genuinely hardy (RHS AGM); delicate black-stemmed fan-shaped fronds; spreads slowly into a mat |

**Soil needs:** Most: moist, humus-rich, acidic to neutral (pH 5.0–7.0). Deer fern: acidic conditions. *C. fortunei* var. *clivicola*: neutral to slightly alkaline tolerated (pH 6.0–8.0). *D. koidzumiana*: pH 5.5–7.0. *Adiantum venustum*: moist but well-drained, humus-rich soil, pH 5.5–7.0 — reliably moist conditions matter more than exact pH.

**Soil prep:** Add generous compost. Extra moisture retention for Royal Fern and Lady Fern.

**Planting depth:** At pot level. Crowns of *Dryopteris* and *Osmunda* should sit 7–12cm above soil. *Adiantum venustum* has a thin, creeping rhizome planted at pot level.

**Spacing:** 30cm–1.5m between plants depending on species — see table above.

**Fertiliser:** Very low feeding requirements. Light balanced fertiliser in spring or annual compost top-dressing is sufficient. Do not overfeed. Bark mulch around base to retain moisture.

**Companions:** Hostas, astilbe, hellebores, snowdrops, bluebells. Native ferns under deciduous trees is the ideal naturalistic Irish planting. Japanese maple and bamboo make beautiful structural companions. Foxgloves self-seed among ferns magnificently.

**West of Ireland:** You are in prime fern territory. Royal Fern (*Osmunda regalis*) is spectacular in boggy west of Ireland conditions.

#### Notes on the two new additions:

**Fortune's Holly Fern var. *clivicola*** (*Cyrtomium fortunei* var. *clivicola*): A particularly cold-hardy variety of Fortune's holly fern (hardy to -15°C or below), originating in Japan and Korea. Produces bold, glossy, deep green fronds with holly-leaf-shaped pinnae. Fully evergreen. One of the few ferns that genuinely tolerates dry shade — invaluable under trees where moisture competition is fierce, a challenge common in west of Ireland woodland gardens. Grows well in neutral to slightly alkaline soils as well as acidic conditions, giving it wider site flexibility than many ferns. The RHS lists *Cyrtomium fortunei* as suitable for shade in humus-rich, well-drained to moist soil. Plant at pot level; the crown should sit at or just below the soil surface. Slug-resistant (tough, glossy fronds). Height 30–60cm; spread to 60cm. Pot size: 🟩 30–40cm / 15L+.

**Koidzumi's Wood Fern** (*Dryopteris koidzumiana*): A Japanese species related to the common Male Fern, increasingly grown as a garden fern in the UK and Ireland. Produces upright, broadly lance-shaped fronds with attractive coppery-bronze new growth in spring (resembling *D. erythrosora* in this regard), maturing to dark green. Semi-evergreen to deciduous depending on exposure; in the mild west of Ireland, usually semi-evergreen. Tolerates clay, moist soils, and shade well. Plant at pot level; crown at soil surface or just below; do not bury deeply. pH 5.5–7.0. Height 60–90cm; spread 60cm. Pot size: 🟩 40–50cm / 25–30L.

## S5. Primroses (*Primula vulgaris*)

📷 Reference photo: [Primroses — view source](#)

**Light:** 🌤️ Partial shade; tolerates more sun in the cooler, moister west of Ireland climate than in drier regions.

**Soil needs:** Moist, humus-rich soil; pH 5.5–7.0. Tolerates clay well if not waterlogged.

**Soil prep:** Mix clay with compost/leaf mould.

**Planting depth:** Crown at soil level.

**Spacing:** 20–25cm between plants

**Fertiliser:** Light balanced feed in spring. Annual leaf mould/compost mulch.

**Companions:** Bluebells, wood anemones, violets, ferns — classic native woodland-floor and hedge-bank planting.

**West of Ireland:** One of Ireland's most familiar native spring wildflowers, found throughout hedge banks and woodland; pale yellow flowers from late winter into spring. Easy, long-lived, and self-seeds gently to form drifts under trees, shrubs and hedges.

## S6. Round-Lobed Hepatica (*Hepatica nobilis*)

📷 Reference photo: [Round-Lobed Hepatica — view source](#)

**Light:** 🌤️ Partial to full shade; ideal under deciduous trees.

**Soil needs:** Moist but well-drained, humus-rich soil, tolerant of neutral to slightly alkaline; pH 6.0–7.5.

**Soil prep:** Improve clay with leaf mould/compost and a little grit.

**Planting depth:** Crown at soil level; resents disturbance once established.

**Spacing:** 15–20cm between plants

**Fertiliser:** Light balanced feed in spring. Annual leaf mould mulch.

**Companions:** Snowdrops, hellebores, wood anemones — classic very-early-spring woodland-floor planting.

**West of Ireland:** One of the earliest woodland perennials to flower, with delicate blue, pink or white blooms often appearing before the leaves in late winter/early spring, followed by attractive lobed evergreen foliage. Slow-growing but long-lived once settled — best left undisturbed.

### S7. St Patrick's Cabbage (*Saxifraga spathularis*)

 **Reference photo:** [St Patrick's Cabbage — view source](#)

**Light:** 🌤️ Partial shade to full shade; also tolerates exposed, unshaded mountain sites in its native range.

**Soil needs:** Moist, humus-rich, acid soil among rocks; pH 5.0–6.0.

**Soil prep:** Mix clay with 30–40% ericaceous compost/leaf mould and some grit — best replicating a humid, rocky woodland or streamside setting.

**Planting depth:** Crown at soil level; shallow, stoloniferous rooting.

**Spacing:** 15–20cm between plants

**Fertiliser:** Very little required. Light ericaceous feed in spring if growth is poor.

**Companions:** Ferns, mosses, other Irish native rock/woodland plants for an authentic west of Ireland native rockery or shaded bank.

**West of Ireland:** A true west of Ireland native and local treasure — part of the "Lusitanian flora" found naturally only in Ireland and parts of Portugal/Spain, most abundant in Kerry and west Cork on shaded, humid rocks and hedge banks. An excellent, genuinely native choice for a shaded rockery or damp stone wall in this guide's own region. Evergreen rosettes of fleshy leaves with delicate white, pink-speckled flowers in early summer.

### S8. Tasmanian Tree Fern (*Dicksonia antarctica*)

 **Reference photo:** [Dicksonia antarctica \(Tasmanian Tree Fern\) — view source](#)

**Light:** 🌤️ Partial to full shade; shelter from direct hot sun and, importantly, from cold drying winds.

**Soil needs:** Moist, humus-rich, free-draining, slightly acid soil; pH 5.5–6.5. Needs consistent moisture at the crown and root zone but good drainage — dislikes both drought and waterlogging.

**Soil prep:** Mix clay with generous compost/leaf mould (40%+) and grit. In a container, use a peat-free ericaceous or woodland-type compost mix.

**Planting depth:** Trunk (caudex) at same depth as previously grown; the fibrous "trunk" is actually a mass of roots and needs to stay moist.

**Spacing:** 1.5–3m between plants; wrap crown in hard frost

**Fertiliser:** Balanced liquid feed watered into the crown monthly through the growing season. Regular watering — including watering directly into the crown in dry spells — is more important than feeding.

**Companions:** Hostas, ferns, hellebores, snowdrops — classic damp, shaded woodland-garden planting.

**West of Ireland:** RHS hardiness H4–H5 (borderline, roughly to –5°C, less with protection); the mild, humid west of Ireland climate suits it well in a sheltered spot, but in harder winters wrap the crown with fleece or straw. Water the crown regularly in the growing season — this is the single most common cause of failure when it is allowed to dry out.

### S9. Wood Sorrel (*Oxalis acetosella*)

 **Reference photo:** [Wood Sorrel — view source](#)

**Light:** 🌑 Full shade to 🌤️ partial shade.

**Soil needs:** Moist, humus-rich, acid to neutral soil; pH 5.0–6.5.

**Soil prep:** Improve clay with leaf mould/compost.

**Planting depth:** Crown/rhizome at soil level.

**Spacing:** 10–15cm between plants

**Fertiliser:** None required.

**Companions:** Ferns, mosses, primroses — classic deep-woodland-floor groundcover, often found growing directly among tree roots and on old stumps.

**West of Ireland:** A dainty native woodland groundcover with clover-like leaves that fold down at night and delicate white, purple-veined flowers in spring. Spreads gently by rhizomes to form soft carpets in deep shade where little else will grow — ideal under mature trees or in a native woodland-style corner.

## GROUP T: ORNAMENTAL TREES & SHRUBS

### T1. Bamboo (clump-forming: *Fargesia* spp., *Chusquea* spp.)

 Reference photo: [Bamboo — view on Wikipedia](#)

**Light:** ☀ Full sun to partial shade. *Fargesia* prefers some afternoon shade.

**Soil needs:** Most soils including clay; prefers moist, fertile, free-draining. Choose clump-forming species — running bamboo (*Phyllostachys*) requires a 60cm deep root barrier.

**Soil prep:** Dig hole twice the rootball width. Mix clay 50/50 with compost. Mulch well.

**Planting depth:** At pot level.

**Spacing:** 1.5–3m from structures; root barrier for running types

**Fertiliser:** High-nitrogen fertiliser (lawn feed or balanced granular) each spring. Top-dress with compost each autumn. Container plants: balanced liquid fertiliser monthly during the growing season.

**Companions:** Ferns, hostas, astilbe, hellebores. Bamboo provides shelter for smaller plants. Root barrier required near structures.

### T2. Border Forsythia (*Forsythia* × *intermedia*)

 Reference photo: [Border Forsythia — view on Wikipedia](#)

**Light:** ☀ Full sun to partial shade. Flowers better in full sun.

**Soil needs:** pH 6.0–8.0. Tolerates clay very well.

**Soil prep:** Standard clay improvement with compost and grit.

**Planting depth:** At pot level.

**Spacing:** 1.5m between; 2m from walls

**Fertiliser:** Balanced general fertiliser (Growmore) in early spring. Annual compost mulch after pruning. Avoid high-nitrogen feeds. ⚠ Prune immediately after flowering — never in autumn/winter (flower buds form on old wood).

**Companions:** Spring tulips underplanted, Vinca or Pulmonaria as underplanting, holly or yew as evergreen backdrop.

### T3. Cherry Blossom 'Kanzan' (*Prunus* 'Kanzan')

 Reference photo: [Cherry Blossom 'Kanzan' — view on Wikipedia](#)

**Light:** ☀ Full sun. Avoid frost pockets — late frosts damage April blossom.

**Soil needs:** Well-drained, fertile, pH 6.0–7.5.

**Soil prep:** 60cm wide, 45cm deep. Mix clay 50/50 with compost and 20% grit. Stake well.

**Planting depth:** Graft union at or just above soil level.

**Spacing:** 4–5m from trees/structures

**Fertiliser:** Balanced fertiliser in early spring. Compost mulch around base each spring. Do not feed in late summer.

**Companions:** Daffodils and tulips beneath (spectacularly timed with April blossom). Forget-me-nots as blue-and-pink carpet. Hostas and hardy geraniums as underplanting.

### T4. Common Hawthorn (*Crataegus monogyna*)

 Reference photo: [Common Hawthorn — view source](#)

**Light:** ☀ Full sun to ☀ partial shade.

**Soil needs:** Very adaptable — most soils including heavy clay, chalk, and poor ground; pH 5.5–7.5.

**Soil prep:** Minimal — one of the most tolerant trees of clay and exposure. Improve drainage with grit only on the wettest sites.

**Planting depth:** At nursery soil mark.

**Spacing:** As hedge: 30–45cm; as tree: 4–6m from structures

**Fertiliser:** None needed once established. Light mulch of compost in early years.

**Companions:** Classic native hedgerow tree — combines with blackthorn, holly and hazel for a mixed native hedge; underplant with primroses, bluebells and violets.

**West of Ireland:** Ireland's most familiar native hedgerow and windbreak tree ("whitethorn"), exceptionally tolerant of wind, salt spray and exposure — an excellent, low-cost choice for shelterbelts on Atlantic-facing boundaries. Masses of white May blossom followed by red autumn haws valuable for birds.

#### T5. Dwarf Lily Magnolia (*Magnolia liliiflora*, e.g. 'Nigra')

 **Reference photo:** [Dwarf Lily Magnolia — view source](#)

**Light:** ☀ Full sun to 🌤 part shade, sheltered from cold wind.

**Soil needs:** Moist but well-drained, humus-rich soil; slightly acid to neutral, pH 5.5–6.5. Dislikes shallow chalk and waterlogging.

**Soil prep:** Mix clay with 30% compost/ericaceous compost and grit for drainage. Avoid deep planting.

**Planting depth:** At nursery soil mark; shallow, fleshy roots — do not disturb once planted.

**Spacing:** 2–3m between plants/structures

**Fertiliser:** Balanced or ericaceous slow-release feed in spring. Annual mulch with compost or bark, kept away from the trunk.

**Companions:** Underplant with hellebores, ferns, snowdrops; pairs well with Japanese maple and star magnolia for a spring border.

**West of Ireland:** More compact and later-flowering than star magnolia, so its blooms often escape the worst late frosts. Reliably hardy in sheltered west of Ireland gardens; avoid frost pockets and exposed coastal wind.

#### T6. Dwarf Mountain Pine (*Pinus mugo* var. *mugo*)

 **Reference photo:** [Pinus mugo — view on Wikipedia](#)

**Light:** ☀ Full sun — needed to keep the habit compact and dense; tolerates part shade but grows looser.

**Soil needs:** Any reasonably drained soil, pH 5.0–7.5; naturally found on poor, rocky mountain soils, so tolerates poor and thin ground well. Dislikes permanently waterlogged clay.

**Soil prep:** Dig a hole twice the width of the rootball. Mix the excavated clay 50/50 with multipurpose compost, adding 20–30% horticultural grit to guarantee sharp drainage — this matters more than fertility for a plant adapted to mountain scree. On the wettest clay, plant on a slightly raised mound.

**Planting depth:** At the same level as in the pot; do not bury the base of the stems.

**Spacing:** 1.5–2m between plants; ultimate size around 1.5–2m tall and wide, reached slowly.

**Fertiliser:** None needed at planting — wait 6–8 weeks before feeding to avoid burning new roots. From the following spring, a light dressing of Kieserite (magnesium sulphate) or an organic conifer feed each February–March keeps the needles a good green. Otherwise very low-maintenance.

**Companions:** Heather, dwarf junipers, sempervivum and other rockery or gravel-garden plants that share its need for sharp drainage.

**West of Ireland:** A genuinely tough, slow-growing dwarf conifer from the mountains of central and southern Europe — very cold-hardy and, once established, tolerant of salt-laden wind, which makes it a good choice for an exposed coastal west of Ireland garden. Needs almost no pruning beyond removing dead wood.

#### T7. False Spirea (*Sorbaria sorbifolia*)

 **Reference photo:** [Sorbaria sorbifolia — view source](#)

**Light:** ☀ Full sun to 🌤 partial shade.

**Soil needs:** Most moist soils including clay; pH 5.5–7.5. Very adaptable and tolerant of poor drainage better than many shrubs.

**Soil prep:** Minimal — dig hole twice rootball width, mix clay 50/50 with compost.

**Planting depth:** At nursery soil mark.

**Spacing:** 1–1.5m between plants; spreads by suckers

**Fertiliser:** Balanced general fertiliser in spring. Annual compost mulch.

**Companions:** Good at the back of a mixed border with hydrangea and deutzia; also useful for stabilising damp banks.

**West of Ireland:** Vigorous, suckering shrub with creamy plume-like flowers in summer — spreads readily by suckers, so best given room to naturalise (e.g. a bank or informal border) rather than a tight border, where it can be kept in check by removing suckers.

### T8. Fuzzy Pride-of-Rochester (*Deutzia scabra*)

 **Reference photo:** [Fuzzy Pride-of-Rochester — view source](#)

**Light:** ☀ Full sun to 🌤 partial shade. Flowers best and stays more compact in full sun; needs a sheltered spot out of the coldest wind.

**Soil needs:** Most moist, well-drained soils including clay; pH 6.0–7.5. Not fussy once drainage is adequate.

**Soil prep:** Dig hole twice the rootball width. Mix excavated clay 50/50 with compost and 20% grit.

**Planting depth:** At nursery soil mark.

**Spacing:** 1.5–2m between plants; grows 1.8–3m tall

**Fertiliser:** Balanced general fertiliser in early spring. Annual compost mulch.

**Companions:** Lewis mock orange, lilac, weigela — classic spring/early-summer flowering shrub border. Underplant with spring bulbs.

**West of Ireland:** A larger, more vigorous *Deutzia* than the dwarf *D. gracilis* type, with distinctive peeling cinnamon-coloured bark and fuzzy, sandpaper-textured leaves (hence "scabra," Latin for rough) that give this cultivar its common name. Double white flowers, sometimes tinged pink, in early summer on arching branches. Prune immediately after flowering, removing a proportion of the oldest stems at the base each year to keep it renewing well — it flowers on the previous year's wood, so late pruning sacrifices next year's display. Note: in parts of North America this species can self-seed and naturalise; in an Irish garden setting this is not generally a concern, but deadheading after flowering avoids any risk of unwanted seedlings.

### T9. Holly (*Ilex aquifolium*)

 **Reference photo:** [Holly — view on Wikipedia](#)

**Light:** 🌑 Full shade to ☀ full sun. Extraordinary adaptability. More berries in sunnier positions. ⚠ Plant at least one male + one female for berries.

**Soil needs:** pH 4.5–8.0. Tolerates heavy clay, poor soil, coastal exposure.

**Soil prep:** Dig hole twice rootball size, backfill with clay/compost mix. Grit helpful but not essential.

**Planting depth:** At pot level; fibrous shallow root mat, do not bury deeply.

**Spacing:** 1.5–3m between; slow-growing hedge

**Fertiliser:** Balanced slow-release fertiliser in early spring only if plant looks weak or pale. Annual bark mulch more useful than heavy feeding. Container: slow-release granular fertiliser each spring, liquid feed monthly in summer.

**Companions:** Yew (classic Irish churchyard combination), forsythia (glows against dark foliage), winter-flowering hellebores, snowdrops beneath. Critical: plant at least one male (e.g. 'Silver Queen' — confusingly a male) and one or more berry-bearing females nearby (within 50–100m).

⚠ All parts except berry flesh toxic to humans and livestock.

### T10. Irish Yew (*Taxus baccata* 'Fastigiata')

 **Reference photo:** [Irish Yew — view on Wikipedia](#)

**Light:** 🌑 Full shade to ☀ full sun. Narrow column; produces more compact form in full sun. Discovered as natural mutation in Co. Fermanagh in the 18th century — all Irish yews worldwide descend from that one tree.

**Soil needs:** Most well-drained soils, pH 5.0–8.0. Tolerates heavy clay if drainage adequate. Deeply dislikes waterlogged roots.

**Soil prep:** Mix clay 50/50 with compost and 20% grit. On very wet clay, plant on a raised mound.

**Planting depth:** At pot level. Extensive but not deep root system.

**Spacing:** Column 1m wide eventually; 1m from structures

**Fertiliser:** Very little required. Light balanced slow-release fertiliser in spring if plant looks pale. Annual bark mulch more beneficial than chemical feeding. Avoid high-nitrogen feeds.

**Companions:** Holly, peonies, roses (as a dark backdrop), hellebores, snowdrops. Evergreen column provides structure year-round.

⚠ All parts except red berry flesh are highly toxic to humans, horses and livestock. Do not plant near paddocks.

### T11. Japanese Camellia (*Camellia japonica*)

 **Reference photo:** [Japanese Camellia — view source](#)

**Light:** 🌤 Partial shade preferred, sheltered from early morning sun (which can damage frosted buds) and cold wind.



**Soil needs:** Moist but well-drained, humus-rich, acid soil; pH 5.0–6.5. Will yellow (chlorosis) on alkaline soil.

**Soil prep:** Mix clay generously with ericaceous compost (40%+) and grit. In a container, use peat-free ericaceous compost.

**Planting depth:** At nursery soil mark; shallow-rooted, do not bury the stem base.

**Spacing:** 1–1.5m between plants

**Fertiliser:** Ericaceous slow-release feed after flowering in spring. Avoid feeding after midsummer, to let wood ripen before winter.

**Companions:** Japanese skimmia, hydrangea macrophylla, Japanese maple — classic acid-soil shrub border.

**West of Ireland:** The mild, humid west of Ireland climate suits camellias well, though a sheltered spot out of early morning sun and harsh wind protects the flowers. Excellent in a large container of ericaceous compost if clay soil is not acid enough.

## T20. Japanese Cedar (*Cryptomeria japonica*)

 **Reference photo:** [Japanese Cedar — view on Wikipedia](#)

**Light:** ☀ Full sun to 🌤 partial shade.

**Soil needs:** Moist but well-drained, fertile, acid to neutral soil; pH 5.5–6.5. Tolerates a wide range of soils including clay, but dislikes drying out and dislikes strong maritime exposure (unlike many other conifers in this guide).

**Soil prep:** Mix clay 50/50 with multipurpose or ericaceous compost and 20% grit for drainage. Choose a site sheltered from strong winds — this is essential, not optional, for this species.

**Planting depth:** At nursery soil mark.

**Spacing:** 4–6m between plants for a full-sized tree; dwarf cultivars (e.g. 'Globosa Nana', 'Vilmoriniana') can go as close as 1–1.5m.

**Fertiliser:** Balanced slow-release feed in early spring. Keep soil evenly moist, especially while young; established trees tolerate short dry spells but perform best without prolonged drought.

**Companions:** Japanese maple, camellia, rhododendron and other acid-loving woodland-edge shrubs; underplant with ferns and hostas.

**Pot/container:** ☒ Dwarf cultivars such as 'Globosa Nana' are well suited to a large container of ericaceous or multipurpose compost; full-sized forms need open ground.

**West of Ireland:** A large, elegant evergreen conifer with soft, awl-shaped needles that take on a bronze tint in winter and attractive, peeling red-brown bark. Full-sized forms need a big, sheltered garden — this is not a tree for an exposed coastal site, since RHS and other growers note it dislikes strong winds and salt-laden maritime exposure, unlike many conifers already in this guide. Dwarf cultivars are a much better fit for a smaller or more exposed west of Ireland garden.

## T12. Japanese Maple (*Acer palmatum*)

 **Reference photo:** [Japanese Maple — view on Wikipedia](#)

**Light:** 🌤 Partial shade preferred. Morning sun with afternoon shade is ideal. Variegated and dissectum types especially wind-sensitive. Avoid open exposed positions.

**Soil needs:** Moist but well-drained, slightly acidic, pH 5.5–6.5.

**Soil prep:** Dig 2–3× diameter of rootball. Mix clay with compost, 25% ericaceous compost and 25% grit in backfill. Shallow-rooted — do not dig deeply.

**Planting depth:** At pot level. Shallow-rooted; do not bury.

**Spacing:** 2–4m from structures; wind shelter essential

**Fertiliser:** Slow-release balanced fertiliser (e.g. Osmocote) in spring. Container: liquid feed monthly April–July at balanced rate — do not feed after July. Annual composted bark mulch.

**Companions:** Hostas (classic combination), ferns, hellebores, snowdrops beneath. Excellent specimen plant. Avoid planting with other thirsty trees nearby.

**West of Ireland:** Wind shelter is essential. Sheltered courtyard or walled garden position is ideal.

## T13. Japanese Skimmia (*Skimmia japonica*)

 **Reference photo:** [Japanese Skimmia — view source](#)

**Light:** 🌑 Shade to 🌤 partial shade preferred; tolerates full sun in cooler, moister climates like the west of Ireland.

**Soil needs:** Moist but well-drained, humus-rich soil; prefers slightly acid to neutral, pH 5.5–6.5. Dislikes dry or chalky soils.

**Soil prep:** Mix clay with 30–40% ericaceous compost and grit for drainage. Add well-rotted organic matter.

**Planting depth:** At nursery soil mark; shallow-rooted, do not bury the stem base.

**Spacing:** 60–90cm between plants; ♂+♀ within a few metres for berries

**Fertiliser:** Ericaceous slow-release feed in spring. Mulch annually with ericaceous compost or bark.

**Companions:** Hellebores, ferns, hostas and other shade/woodland plants; Japanese maple and hydrangea for a shaded border.

**West of Ireland:** Dioecious — plant at least one male (e.g. 'Rubella') near females (e.g. 'Nymans') for the females' red berries. Compact, reliable evergreen for shaded, sheltered spots; good in containers on the north side of a house.

⚠ Berries are mildly toxic if ingested in quantity.

#### T14. Lewis Mock Orange (*Philadelphus lewisii*)

📷 **Reference photo:** [Lewis Mock Orange — view source](#)

**Light:** ☀ Full sun to 🌞 part shade. Best flowering and fragrance in full sun.

**Soil needs:** Most well-drained soils including clay; pH 6.0–7.5. Tolerant of a wide range once established.

**Soil prep:** Dig hole twice the rootball width. Mix excavated clay 50/50 with compost and 20% grit for drainage.

**Planting depth:** At nursery soil mark.

**Spacing:** 1.5–2m between plants

**Fertiliser:** Balanced general fertiliser in early spring. Annual compost mulch. Avoid high-nitrogen feeds, which favour leaves over flowers.

**Companions:** Deutzia and Lilac (classic mixed shrub border companions), roses, spring bulbs beneath.

**West of Ireland:** State flower of Idaho, very hardy and wind-tolerant once established — a good choice for exposed Atlantic gardens. Prune immediately after flowering (flowers on previous year's wood).

#### T15. Lilac (*Syringa vulgaris*)

📷 **Reference photo:** [Lilac — view on Wikipedia](#)

**Light:** ☀ Full sun — needs at least 6 hours to flower well.

**Soil needs:** Neutral to slightly alkaline, pH 6.5–8.0.

**Soil prep:** Mix clay 50/50 with compost and 20–25% grit. Add garden lime if soil is acidic. Slight mound if waterlogging is a risk.

**Planting depth:** At nursery soil mark.

**Spacing:** 1.5m between; 2m from walls

**Fertiliser:** Superphosphate or balanced fertiliser in early spring. Avoid high-nitrogen feeds (produces leaves, not flowers). Annual compost mulch around base.

**Companions:** Roses (May–June combination), alliums, irises, peonies, delphiniums, aquilegia, geraniums. Foxgloves self-seed naturally nearby.

#### T16. Mophead / Lacecap Hydrangea (*Hydrangea macrophylla*)

📷 **Reference photo:** [Hydrangea macrophylla — view on Wikipedia](#)

**Light:** 🌤 Partial shade preferred. Morning sun with afternoon shade is ideal. Bigleaf hydrangea performs best in areas with dappled sunlight, partial shade, or deep shade. Protect it from afternoon sun. The macrophylla cultivars famously tolerate coastal exposure.

**Soil needs:** They love a fertile, humus-rich, clay soil. pH 5.0–6.0 for blue flowers; 6.0–7.0 for pink flowers. Moist but well-drained. Good salt tolerance. Flower colour changes depending on soil pH — blue in acid soils (high aluminium availability), mauve in lightly acid to neutral soil, pink in alkaline conditions.

**Soil prep:** Before planting, dig in well-rotted compost or manure to the whole area (not just the planting hole), using a bucketful per square yard/metre. Make the planting hole as deep as the root ball and three times wider. For blue flowers: use ericaceous compost in the planting hole and grow in ericaceous compost in containers.

**Planting depth:** At pot level; place the top of the rootball at or slightly above surrounding soil level. Shallow-rooted — avoid hoeing around it as roots can be easily damaged.

**Spacing:** 90cm–2.4m between (check label for variety size)

**Fertiliser:** Fertilise once in spring with a fertiliser designed to encourage blooms such as one high in phosphorus (e.g. 15-30-15). For blue flowers: feed with a fertiliser low in phosphorus and high in potassium and use ericaceous compost. If you're gardening on alkaline soils and want to retain blue flowers, grow in containers using ericaceous compost. Stop feeding after August.

**⚠ Pruning note:** Hydrangeas that flower on old wood should not be pruned hard as you will lose this summer's flowers. Prune in mid-spring; only remove the withered flowerheads and dead parts. Traditionally leave old flowers on through winter to protect new growth from cold.

**Companions:** Astilbe, hostas, ferns (all love similar moist, semi-shaded conditions). Yarrow pairs beautifully with hydrangea. Heucheras, hardy geraniums, and hellebores as underplanting. Behind low-growing perennials such as bergenia at the border front.

**Pot size:** Standard mophead varieties reach 1–1.5m in containers and need 50–60cm pots at maturity. Compact cultivars like Cityline Paris manage in 30–35cm pots. Use ericaceous compost for blue flowers; standard John Innes No.3 (2 parts) + multipurpose compost (1 part) for pink flowers.

**West of Ireland:** Hydrangeas are one of the quintessential plants of Irish gardens. Macrophylla hydrangeas tolerate coastal exposure too. The mild, moist Atlantic climate suits them perfectly. The west of Ireland's naturally slightly acidic soils tend to produce beautiful blue-mauve flowers. Choose a sheltered spot away from frost pockets — late frosts can damage new growth.

#### T17. Mountain Ash / Rowan (*Sorbus aucuparia*)

 **Reference photo:** [Mountain Ash / Rowan — view source](#)

**Light:** ☀ Full sun to 🌞 partial shade.

**Soil needs:** Very adaptable — most soils including clay, acid or neutral; pH 5.0–7.0. Dislikes shallow chalk.

**Soil prep:** Dig hole twice the rootball width. Mix excavated clay 50/50 with compost; grit if drainage is poor.

**Planting depth:** At nursery soil mark.

**Spacing:** 3–5m from structures

**Fertiliser:** Little required once established. Balanced feed in the first two seasons; annual compost mulch.

**Companions:** A traditional companion to holly and hawthorn in native hedgerows and gardens; underplant with ferns, foxgloves, hellebores.

**West of Ireland:** One of the hardiest, most wind- and exposure-tolerant native trees, traditionally planted near Irish homes for protection ("the traveller's tree" / rowan folklore). Bright orange-red berries from late summer are an important food source for birds; excellent for exposed sites.

#### T18. St John's Wort 'Rowallane' (*Hypericum 'Rowallane'*)

 **Reference photo:** [Hypericum 'Rowallane' — view source](#)

**Light:** ☀ Full sun to 🌞 part shade. Flowers best in full sun.

**Soil needs:** Most well-drained soils including clay; pH 5.5–7.5. Prefers shelter from hard frost and cold winds — borderline hardy (RHS H4), so a sheltered spot is important in the west of Ireland.

**Soil prep:** Dig hole twice the rootball width. Mix excavated clay 50/50 with compost and 20% grit.

**Planting depth:** At nursery soil mark.

**Spacing:** 1–1.5m between plants

**Fertiliser:** Balanced general fertiliser in spring. Annual compost mulch; avoid feeding late in the season, which can soften growth ahead of winter.

**Companions:** Heathers, skimmia and other evergreen structure shrubs; also pairs well with roses and late perennials for a long season of interest.

**West of Ireland:** Large, showy golden-yellow flowers from midsummer into autumn. Semi-evergreen to evergreen in mild areas. Site against a warm wall or in a sheltered border, away from the coldest exposure.

#### T19. Star Magnolia (*Magnolia stellata*)

 **Reference photo:** [Star Magnolia — view on Wikipedia](#)

**Light:** ☀ Full sun to partial shade. Morning sun, sheltered position. Blooms in March–April — susceptible to late frost damage.

**Soil needs:** Moist but well-drained, pH 5.0–6.5. Tolerates alkaline better than most magnolias (RHS). Shallow, fleshy roots — handle gently.

**Soil prep:** Wide, shallow hole. Mix clay with compost and 20% grit. Generous bark or leaf mould mulch each spring.

**Planting depth:** At pot level. Do not plant deeper. Fleshy roots are fragile — do not damage.

**Spacing:** 2.5m spread; shelter from N/E winds

**Fertiliser:** Slow-release balanced fertiliser in spring. Annual bark mulch more beneficial than heavy feeding. Ericaceous liquid feed sparingly on acidic soils.

**Companions:** Snowdrops, species crocus, Iris reticulata (bloom before magnolia leaves up). Hellebores in partial shade beneath. Hardy geraniums as ground cover. White flowers shown off beautifully against evergreen backdrop.

## GROUP W: POND & WATER PLANTS

### W1. Bog Asphodel (*Narthecium ossifragum*)

 **Reference photo:** [Bog Asphodel — view source](#)

**Light:** ☀ Full sun.

**Soil needs:** Permanently wet, humus-rich, nutrient-poor, acid soil/peat; pH 4.5–6.0.

**Soil prep:** No amendment with compost or fertiliser — this plant is adapted to nutrient-poor bog conditions and rich soil is counterproductive. Best in a boggy, permanently wet corner or the very shallow, saturated margin of a pond.

**Planting depth:** Crown/rhizome at soil surface, kept permanently wet.

**Spacing:** 20–30cm between plants; needs permanently wet acid soil

**Fertiliser:** None — bog asphodel is adapted to nutrient-poor conditions.

**Companions:** Bogbean, bog pimpernel, sphagnum-type damp margin planting.

**West of Ireland:** Widespread in Irish bogs, heaths and moorland, with spikes of bright yellow, star-shaped flowers in summer turning deep orange in autumn. A specialist for a genuinely boggy, acid, permanently wet spot rather than an ordinary border or standard pond margin.

⚠ Foliage is toxic to livestock if grazed in quantity; not a concern for typical garden use, but worth knowing if animals have access.

### W2. Bog Pimpernel (*Anagallis tenella*)

 **Reference photo:** [Bog Pimpernel — view on Wikipedia](#)

**Light:** ☀ Full sun.

**Spacing:** 30–40cm apart; spreads as carpet

**Soil needs:** Grow in the damp margin to level with the water surface. Moderately fertile, moist but not deeply submerged. Damp margins, bog gardens, very shallow water.

**Water depth:** Surface moisture to very shallow water (0–5cm at most). Primarily a bog and wet-margin plant.

**Planting:** Remove from aquatic basket/pot and plant directly into damp boggy soil at the water's edge, or at the very margin of a pond.

**Fertiliser:** Minimal — adapted to low-nutrient bog conditions. No feeding required if in naturally boggy soil. A light liquid balanced feed monthly if in a container situation will maintain good growth.

**Companions:** Bogbean, yellow flag iris, water mint, native mosses, royal fern at pond margins. This spreading, native plant forms a dense carpet of tiny evergreen leaves, mixed with numerous rosy pink flowers from late spring to early summer.

**West of Ireland:** A native Irish plant of damp, slightly acidic marshes, flush grasslands, and lake margins. Particularly common in the west of Ireland, where it grows in abundance in the Burren and Connaught margins. Its natural conditions are replicated in any consistently damp, open, sunny spot near water.

### W3. Bogbean (*Menyanthes trifoliata*)

 **Reference photo:** [Bogbean — view on Wikipedia](#)

**Light:** ☀ Full sun to 🌤 partial shade. Full sun preferred to encourage flowering.

**Spacing:** 60cm between plants; spreads indefinitely without basket

**Soil needs:** Shallow water or boggy mud. Grow in baskets in a large pond in water up to 25cm deep, or grow in muddy pool margins.

**Water depth:** Planting depth: up to 20cm (8 inches) deep in water. Alternatively, in boggy soil at the water's edge with consistent moisture.

**Basket size:** Recommend a planting basket of at least 19cm across for one plant, or for more impact, plant several of the same variety in a larger basket.

**Planting:** Place the Menyanthes in a container or directly in the soil, making sure that the roots plus about 2 inches of the plant's stem is in the soil and at least an inch of water.

**Fertiliser:** Very low-maintenance; requires little feeding. Aquatic fertiliser tablet in the basket compost at the start of each growing season is sufficient. The plant is adapted to naturally nutrient-poor bog conditions.

**Companions:** White water lily, yellow flag iris, bog pimpernel. Bogbean will spread indefinitely by its thick pink rhizomes if not planted in an aquatic basket. Keep in a basket in smaller ponds. Bogbean provides excellent habitat for dragonfly adults and larvae as well as a host of other semi-aquatic invertebrates. Flowers attract bumblebees.

**West of Ireland:** A native Irish plant of bogs, fens, and lake margins. In nature, bogbean only occurs in bogs and fens, making it a diagnostic species of these important habitats. Completely at home in the west of Ireland — may self-establish naturally in or beside garden ponds.

#### W4. Marsh Marigold (*Caltha palustris*)

 **Reference photo:** [Marsh Marigold — view source](#)

**Light:** ☀ Full sun to ☁ partial shade.

**Soil needs:** Permanently moist to wet soil, or shallow water; pH 6.0–7.5. Tolerates heavy clay very well.

**Soil prep:** Little needed — thrives in the wet margins many other plants struggle with.

**Planting depth:** Crown at soil level, in boggy ground or shallow water 0–10cm deep (in an aquatic basket if planted directly in a pond).

**Spacing:** 30–40cm between plants

**Fertiliser:** Little required in a natural pond margin; balanced aquatic fertiliser tablet if grown in a basket.

**Companions:** Yellow flag iris, bogbean, ferns — classic pond-margin planting.

**West of Ireland:** Cheerful, bright yellow, buttercup-like flowers in spring at the water's edge; one of the easiest and most reliable native pond-margin perennials for the consistently damp west of Ireland climate.

#### W5. Marsh Orchids (*Dactylorhiza* spp.)

 **Reference photo:** [Marsh Orchids — view source](#)

**Light:** ☀ Full sun to ☁ partial shade, provided the soil stays consistently moist.

**Soil needs:** Consistently moist, humus-rich soil; slightly acid to neutral (some species tolerate alkaline), pH 6.0–7.0.

**Soil prep:** Improve clay with leafy compost; avoid manure or very rich feeds, which encourage weeds and disrupt the orchid's root/fungal relationship. Never allow the site to dry out, especially in the growing season.

**Planting depth:** Tubers 5–8cm deep, or plant nursery-grown pot plants at pot level.

**Spacing:** 15–20cm between plants; buy nursery stock only

**Fertiliser:** Little to none required — rich feeding is unhelpful and can encourage competing weeds.

**Companions:** Damp meadow and pond-margin planting with yellow flag iris, meadowsweet, ragged robin.

**West of Ireland:** Several marsh orchid species are native to Ireland, found in damp meadows, fens and dune slacks. Always buy nursery-propagated plants (never collected from the wild) and give them a permanently moist, undisturbed spot — a damp meadow area or pond margin suits them far better than a conventional border.

#### W6. Meadowsweet (*Filipendula ulmaria*)

 **Reference photo:** [Meadowsweet — view on Wikipedia](#)

**Light:** ☀ Full sun to ☁ partial shade. Does best in a humus-rich moist well-drained soil in semi-shade or in full sun if the soil is kept moist throughout the growing season. It does not tolerate dry or acid soils; however, it does grow well in heavy clay soils.

**Soil needs:** Moist, fertile soil. Meadowsweet prefers a pH level between 5.0 and 6.5. If your soil is heavy or clay-based, amend it with organic matter to improve drainage. Ideal for boggy areas, pond edges, and consistently damp borders.

**Soil prep:** For in-ground planting, dig in generous compost. No grit needed — meadowsweet actually prefers moisture-retentive conditions. For very wet areas, plant directly without amendment.

**Planting depth:** Simply bury the roots up to the crown of the stem in rich soil. Crown at soil level.

**Spacing:** 60cm between plants; can self-seed

**Fertiliser:** Feed in spring with a balanced fertiliser to encourage vigorous growth. Deadhead spent flowers to prolong bloom, and cut back the stems to ground level after flowering to keep the plant tidy and encourage fresh foliage. Annual compost mulch. Low-maintenance overall.

**Companions:** Yellow flag iris, bogbean, royal fern, astilbe, primulas at pond margins or in damp borders. Borders (rear), naturalized areas, wet meadows or moist areas along streams or ponds. Attracts butterflies, bees and beneficial insects very effectively.

**West of Ireland:** Meadowsweet is native throughout Ireland and wildly abundant in wet western meadows, roadside ditches, and riverside habitats. It is perfectly adapted to the Irish climate and particularly thrives in the wet conditions of the west. One of the most rewarding native plants for a damp or boggy garden.

## W7. Native Irish White Water Lily (*Nymphaea alba*)

 **Reference photo:** [Native Irish White Water Lily — view on Wikipedia](#)

**Light:** ☀ Full sun essential — needs maximum sunshine for flowers to open. Plant in the sunniest spot in the pond.

**Spacing:** 1.5–2m between plants; large ponds only

**Soil needs:** Aquatic compost in mesh baskets. Loamy, clay-based aquatic soil is ideal. Do not use multipurpose/garden compost (too rich — promotes algae). Cover with lime-free pea gravel.

**Water depth:** Best grown about 1 metre deep, but it can grow in up to 3 metres of water if allowed to adjust very gradually. Start shallower (20–30cm) and lower the basket gradually as the plant grows.

**Basket size:** Recommend a planting basket of at least 22cm across initially; pot up to 30–40cm+ basket as the plant grows. *N. alba* is vigorous — suitable for large ponds and lakes only. Not suitable for small garden ponds.

**Planting:** Plant the rhizome level with the top of the aquatic compost. Top with lime-free pea gravel. Place basket in pond at shallow depth first; gradually lower to final depth as leaves grow.

**Fertiliser:** Feed during the growing season with a proprietary aquatic fertiliser at the manufacturer's recommended rate. Use only aquatic fertiliser tablets pushed into the compost — never loose fertiliser into pond water (causes algae bloom). Feed at the start of each growing season.

**Companions:** *Nymphaea alba* is Ireland's only true native water lily. Ideal with Irish natives: Yellow Flag Iris, Bogbean, Bog Pimpernel and meadowsweet at the margins. Water lily pads provide vital shade for fish and wildlife, and reduce algae. Plant oxygenating plants (hornwort, water crowfoot) in the same pond to maintain water quality.

**West of Ireland:** The moist, mild Atlantic climate is ideal for water lilies. Do not plant near a pump or fountain — water lilies require still water and must not have water splashed onto their floating leaves. Keep leaves dry.

## W9. Yellow Loosestrife (*Lysimachia vulgaris*)

 **Reference photo:** [Yellow Loosestrife — view source](#)

**Light:** ☀ Full sun to 🌤 partial shade.

**Soil needs:** Moist to wet soil; pH 6.0–7.5. Tolerates heavy clay very well.

**Soil prep:** Little needed — thrives in damp ground.

**Planting depth:** Crown at soil level.

**Spacing:** 40–50cm between plants; spreads by rhizome

**Fertiliser:** Little required in reasonably fertile damp ground.

**Companions:** Meadowsweet, yellow flag iris, marsh marigold — classic pond-margin/damp border companions.

**West of Ireland:** Tall, upright spikes of bright yellow flowers in summer at the water's edge; spreads by rhizomes to form good-sized clumps in consistently damp ground, so give it room or a contained spot in a smaller pond margin.

# COMPLETE REFERENCE TABLE

(Sorted alphabetically by English name across all groups; ID prefix shows which group each plant belongs to.)

Light: ☀ = full sun | 🌤 = sun/partial shade | ☁ = partial shade preferred | 🌑 = shade tolerant/full shade In Pot?: ✅ = excellent/recommended | ⚠ = possible with care | ❌ = not suitable Pot size given where relevant

| #   | English Name                       | Latin Name                                | pH      | Planting Depth                         | In Pot?                              | Light  | Key Companions                                        | Spacing                                                 |
|-----|------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------|---------|----------------------------------------|--------------------------------------|--------|-------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------|
| B1  | Acidanthera / Abyssinian Gladiolus | Gladiolus murielae                        | 6.0–7.0 | 10–16cm on bed of sharp sand; spring   | ✅ 30cm / 15L+                        | ☀      | Salvias, gladioli, dahlias, ornamental grasses        | 15–20cm between corms                                   |
| P22 | Aconitum (Monkshood)               | Aconitum napellus                         | 6.0–7.5 | Crown at soil level                    | ⚠ 20–30L container                   | 🌤 to ☀ | Delphiniums, hostas, astilbe                          | 45–60cm between plants; ⚠ toxic, wear gloves            |
| P26 | Adonis                             | Adonis vernalis                           | 6.5–7.5 | Crown at soil level                    | ✅ 10–15L container                   | ☀ to ☁ | Snowdrops, hellebores                                 | 20–30cm between plants; ⚠ toxic                         |
| B16 | Allium                             | Allium spp.                               | 6.0–7.5 | 10–15cm deep (2–3× bulb depth); autumn | ✅ 5L+ per bulb cluster               | ☀      | Roses, peonies, irises, ornamental grasses            | 10–20cm between bulbs depending on variety              |
| B30 | Allium 'Nigrum'                    | Allium multibulbosum 'Nigrum' (A. nigrum) | 6.0–7.5 | 15cm deep (2–3× bulb depth); autumn    | ✅ Large 5L+ container                | ☀      | Roses, peonies, ornamental grasses                    | 20–25cm between bulbs                                   |
| F1  | Apple 'Baya Marisa' (P22)          | Malus domestica                           | 6.0–7.0 | Graft union at/above soil              | ⚠ Half-barrel (50L+)                 | ☀      | Chives, garlic, nasturtiums                           | 1–1.5m between trees; permanent stake                   |
| P6  | Aquilegia (Columbine)              | Aquilegia vulgaris                        | 6.0–7.5 | Crown at soil level                    | ✅ 15–20L container                   | ☀ to ☁ | Foxgloves, hardy geraniums, roses                     | 30–45cm between plants; self-seeds freely               |
| P1  | Astilbe                            | Astilbe spp.                              | 5.5–7.0 | At pot level; crown at surface         | ✅ 40–50cm / 30L+                     | 🌤      | Hostas, ferns, hellebores, primulas                   | 30–45cm between plants                                  |
| P2  | Auricula                           | Primula auricula                          | 6.5–7.5 | Crown at soil level                    | ✅ 3–5L pot/trough                    | ☁      | Saxifrage, sempervivum, other alpines                 | 15–20cm between plants                                  |
| T1  | Bamboo (clump-forming)             | Fargesia / Chusquea spp.                  | 5.5–7.0 | At pot level                           | ⚠ Very large tub (100L+)             | 🌤      | Ferns, hostas, astilbe                                | 1.5–3m from structures; root barrier for running types  |
| P3  | Bearded Iris (Border Iris)         | Iris germanica                            | 6.5–7.5 | Rhizome at/just above soil surface     | ⚠ Wide shallow container, 30L+       | ☀      | Roses, peonies, alliums                               | 30–45cm between rhizomes; divide every 3–4 yrs          |
| G16 | Bell Heather                       | Erica cinerea                             | 4.5–6.5 | At pot level                           | ✅ 20–25cm / 5–10L ericaceous compost | ☀      | Blueberry, lingonberry, deer fern, ornamental grasses | 30–45cm between plants                                  |
| F2  | Blackberries                       | Rubus fruticosus agg.                     | 5.5–7.0 | At nursery soil mark                   | ⚠ 40–50L container against support   | ☀ to 🌤 | Raspberries, other cane fruit                         | 2–3m between plants against wires                       |
| F3  | Blackcurrant                       | Ribes nigrum                              | 6.0–7.0 | 5–7cm deeper than nursery mark         | ⚠ 30L+ large pot                     | 🌤      | Alliums, garlic, nasturtiums, redcurrant              | 1.2–1.5m between plants                                 |
| P4  | Blue Gentian                       | Gentiana spp.                             | 5.5–6.5 | Crown at soil level                    | ✅ 10–15L container                   | ☀ to ☁ | Heather, dwarf conifers, saxifrage                    | 20–30cm between plants                                  |
| F4  | Blueberry                          | Vaccinium corymbosum                      | 4.0–5.5 | At pot level                           | ✅ Essential: 40–60cm / 30–50L+       | 🌤      | Heather, lingonberry (same ericaceous trough)         | 1 plant per pot; 60cm between pots                      |
| W1  | Bog Asphodel                       | Nartheicum ossifragum                     | 4.5–6.0 | Crown at soil surface, permanently wet | ⚠ Bog garden/boggy pot only          | ☀      | Bogbean, bog pimpernel                                | 20–30cm between plants; needs permanently wet acid soil |

| #   | English Name                     | Latin Name                                            | pH                    | Planting Depth                                 | In Pot?                              | Light            | Key Companions                                         | Spacing                                                  |
|-----|----------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------|------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------|------------------|--------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------|
| W2  | Bog Pimpernel                    | <i>Anagallis tenella</i>                              | 5.0–6.5               | Crown at soil surface; bog margin to waterline | ✔ Small shallow container at margin  | ☀                | Bogbean, yellow flag iris, water mint                  | 30–40cm apart; spreads as carpet                         |
| W3  | Bogbean / Buckbean               | <i>Menyanthes trifoliata</i>                          | 5.0–7.5               | Roots + 5cm stem in soil; 5–25cm water above   | ✔ 19–24cm+ aquatic basket            | ☀                | White water lily, yellow flag iris, bog pimpernel      | 60cm between plants; spreads indefinitely without basket |
| T2  | Border Forsythia                 | <i>Forsythia × intermedia</i>                         | 6.0–8.0               | At pot level                                   | ✗ Too large                          | ☀                | Spring tulips, Vinca, holly backdrop                   | 1.5m between; 2m from walls                              |
| A3  | Briza Maxima (Quaking Grass)     | <i>Briza maxima</i>                                   | 6.0–7.5               | 5mm deep (seed)                                | ✔ 5L+ container                      | ☀                | Cornflower, poppies, love-in-a-mist                    | 15–20cm between plants; annual, self-seeds               |
| G10 | Campanula saxifraga              | <i>Campanula saxifraga</i>                            | 6.5–7.5               | At pot level                                   | ✔ Trough/rockery, 3–5L               | ☀                | Sempervivum, saxifrage, wall pennywort                 | 15–20cm between plants                                   |
| P38 | Carnation (Border Carnation)     | <i>Dianthus caryophyllus</i>                          | 6.0–7.5               | At pot level                                   | ✔ 20–25cm / 10L+                     | ☀                | Roses, stocks, alliums, lavender                       | 45–60cm between plants                                   |
| G12 | Carpathian Bellflower            | <i>Campanula carpatica</i>                            | 6.0–7.0               | At pot level                                   | ✔ 15–20L container                   | ☀ to 🌤           | Sempervivum, saxifrage, dianthus pinks                 | 25–35cm between plants                                   |
| H1  | Catnip                           | <i>Nepeta cataria</i>                                 | 6.0–7.5               | At pot level                                   | ✔ 15–20L container                   | ☀ to ☀           | Brassicas, roses                                       | 30–45cm between plants                                   |
| F5  | Cherry 'Athos'                   | <i>Prunus avium</i> 'Athos'                           | 5.5–7.5               | At pot level; spring/autumn                    | ✔ 30–40cm+ container                 | ☀                | Chives, garlic                                         | 1–1.5m between plants; self-fertile                      |
| T3  | Cherry Blossom 'Kanzan'          | <i>Prunus</i> 'Kanzan'                                | 6.0–7.5               | Graft union at/above soil                      | ⚠ 100L+ container                    | ☀                | Daffodils, forget-me-nots, hostas                      | 4–5m from trees/structures                               |
| P39 | Chinese Pink                     | <i>Dianthus chinensis</i>                             | 6.5–7.5               | 3mm deep (seed) / at pot level                 | ✔ 5L+ container                      | ☀                | Cornflower, love-in-a-mist                             | 15–20cm between plants; grow as annual/biennial          |
| C2  | Clematis (most)                  | <i>Clematis</i> spp.                                  | 6.5–7.5               | 10–15cm DEEPER than pot                        | ✔ 45cm/40L+ container                | ☀ (roots shaded) | Climbing roses, other clematis                         | 60–90cm between; cool roots essential                    |
| C3  | Climbing Honeysuckle             | <i>Lonicera periclymenum</i>                          | 5.5–8.0               | At pot level                                   | ⚠ 30L+ (not ideal, deep roots)       | ☀                | Climbing roses, clematis; near windows                 | 1.5m between plants                                      |
| C4  | Climbing Hydrangea               | <i>Hydrangea anomala</i> subsp. <i>petiolaris</i>     | 6.0–7.0               | At pot level                                   | ⚠ 50L+ (not ideal)                   | 🌑 to ☀           | Ivy, ferns, hostas, shade-tolerant plants              | 45cm from wall; 60cm+ between plants                     |
| C5  | Climbing Roses                   | <i>Rosa</i> (climbing cvs.)                           | 6.0–7.0               | Graft union just below soil                    | ⚠ 50L+ large container               | ☀                | Clematis (same wall), lavender, geraniums              | 45cm from wall; 2–3m between plants                      |
| P5  | Clustered Bellflower             | <i>Campanula glomerata</i>                            | 6.5–7.5               | Crown at soil level                            | ✔ 15–20L container                   | ☀ to 🌤           | Roses, peonies, ornamental grasses                     | 30–40cm between plants; divide every 3–4 yrs             |
| S1  | Common Dog Violet                | <i>Viola riviniana</i>                                | 5.5–7.0               | Crown at soil level                            | ✔ 5L+ container                      | 🌤                | Primroses, wood sorrel, ferns                          | 15–20cm between plants                                   |
| T4  | Common Hawthorn                  | <i>Crataegus monogyna</i>                             | 5.5–7.5               | At nursery soil mark                           | ✗ Too large for pots                 | ☀ to ☀           | Blackthorn, holly, hazel; primroses, bluebells beneath | As hedge: 30–45cm; as tree: 4–6m from structures         |
| G3  | Common Heather / Ling            | <i>Calluna vulgaris</i> (syn. <i>Erica vulgaris</i> ) | 4.5–6.5 (ideally 5.5) | At pot level                                   | ✔ 20–25cm / 5–10L ericaceous compost | ☀                | Blueberry, lingonberry, deer fern, ornamental grasses  | 30–45cm between plants                                   |
| S3  | Convallaria (Lily of the Valley) | <i>Convallaria majalis</i>                            | 6.0–7.5               | 2–3cm deep (rhizome)                           | ✔ 15–20L container                   | 🌤                | Ferns, hostas, hellebores                              | 15–20cm between plants; ⚠ toxic, spreads                 |
| P7  | Coral Bells                      | <i>Heuchera</i> spp.                                  | 6.0–7.0               | Crown at soil level                            | ✔ 20–30L container                   | 🌤                | Hostas, astilbe, ferns, hellebores                     | 30–45cm between plants                                   |



| #   | English Name                     | Latin Name                         | pH      | Planting Depth                    | In Pot?                               | Light          | Key Companions                                         | Spacing                                         |
|-----|----------------------------------|------------------------------------|---------|-----------------------------------|---------------------------------------|----------------|--------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------|
| H2  | Coriander                        | <i>Coriandrum sativum</i>          | 6.0–7.0 | Sow 5mm deep; do not transplant   | ✅ 20cm+ deep / 5L+                    | ☀️             | Parsley, brassicas; away from dill & fennel            | 15–20cm between plants                          |
| A2  | Cornflower                       | <i>Centaurea cyanus</i>            | 6.0–7.5 | 1–2cm deep (seed)                 | ✅ 5L+ container                       | ☀️             | Poppies, love-in-a-mist, briza maxima                  | 20–30cm between plants; annual, self-seeds      |
| F6  | Cranberry                        | <i>Vaccinium macrocarpon</i>       | 4.0–5.0 | At pot level                      | ✅ Essential: 30–45cm / 10–20L         | ☀️             | Heather, lingonberry, blueberry (ericaceous)           | 30–45cm in acidic bed                           |
| G2  | Creeping / Moss Phlox            | <i>Phlox subulata</i>              | 5.5–7.7 | At pot level; shoots above soil   | ✅ 20–30cm / 5–10L + grit              | ☀️             | Tulips, daffodils underplanted; thyme, sedum, dianthus | 30–45cm for ground cover                        |
| G1  | Creeping Juniper                 | <i>Juniperus horizontalis</i>      | 4.5–8.5 | At pot level or slightly raised   | ✅ 30–40cm/20L+                        | ☀️ (essential) | Heather, sedum, ornamental grasses, thyme              | 1–1.5m for ground cover                         |
| B5  | Crocus                           | <i>Crocus</i> spp.                 | 6.0–7.5 | 7–12cm deep; autumn               | ✅ Excellent: 15–20cm / 3L+            | ☀️ (most) / 🌞  | Snowdrops, daffodils, muscari, aconites                | 8–9cm between corms                             |
| B6  | Crown Imperial                   | <i>Fritillaria imperialis</i>      | 6.5–8.0 | 20–30cm deep, on its side; autumn | ⚠️ 40cm / 30L+ deep pot               | ☀️             | Tulips, alliums, wallflowers, euphorbia                | 25cm between bulbs                              |
| H3  | Cucumbers                        | <i>Cucumis sativus</i>             | 6.0–7.0 | At pot level (after frost)        | ✅ Large 30–40L container with support | ☀️             | Nasturtiums, dill, sweetcorn                           | 45–60cm between plants                          |
| B7  | Daffodil                         | <i>Narcissus</i> spp.              | 6.0–7.0 | 15cm (3× bulb height); autumn     | ✅ 20–30cm / 5L+                       | ☀️             | Snowdrops, tulips, forget-me-nots, Muscari             | 10–15cm between bulbs                           |
| G15 | Dalmatian Bellflower             | <i>Campanula portenschlagiana</i>  | 6.0–7.5 | At pot level                      | ✅ 15–20L container                    | ☀️ to 🌞        | Sempervivum, saxifrage, dianthus pinks                 | 30–40cm between plants                          |
| P9  | Daylilies                        | <i>Heemerocallis</i> spp.          | 6.0–7.5 | Crown at soil level               | ✅ 20–30L container                    | ☀️ to 🌞        | Roses, ornamental grasses, yarrow                      | 45–60cm between plants; divide every 3–4 yrs    |
| S4c | Deer Fern                        | <i>Blechnum spicant</i>            | 4.5–6.0 | At pot level                      | ✅ 30cm / 10L+                         | 🌧️ to 🌑        | Lingonberry, heather, foxgloves                        | 30–45cm between plants                          |
| P10 | Delphinium                       | <i>Delphinium</i> spp.             | 6.5–7.5 | At pot level; buds 2–5cm below    | ⚠️ 40–50cm / 40L+                     | ☀️             | Roses, lupins, peonies, alliums                        | 60–90cm between plants; stake essential         |
| S8  | Dicksonia antarctica (Tree Fern) | <i>Dicksonia antarctica</i>        | 5.5–6.5 | Trunk at same depth as grown      | ✅ Large 50L+ container                | 🌧️ to 🌑        | Hostas, ferns, hellebores, snowdrops                   | 1.5–3m between plants; wrap crown in hard frost |
| H4  | Dill                             | <i>Anethum graveolens</i>          | 5.5–7.0 | Sow 3–5mm deep; do not transplant | ✅ 30cm+ deep / 8L+                    | ☀️             | Brassicas, lettuce; away from coriander & fennel       | 20–30cm between plants                          |
| B8  | Dwarf Iris                       | <i>Iris reticulata</i>             | 6.0–7.5 | 8–10cm deep; autumn               | ✅ 3–5L pot/trough                     | ☀️             | Snowdrops, crocus, dwarf daffodils                     | 5–8cm between bulbs                             |
| T5  | Dwarf Lily Magnolia              | <i>Magnolia liliiflora</i>         | 5.5–6.5 | At nursery soil mark              | ⚠️ 50–80L container                   | ☀️ to 🌞        | Hellebores, ferns, snowdrops, Japanese maple           | 2–3m between plants/structures                  |
| T6  | Dwarf Mountain Pine              | <i>Pinus mugo</i> var. <i>mugo</i> | 5.0–7.5 | At pot level                      | ⚠️ Large gritty container             | ☀️             | Heather, dwarf junipers, sempervivum                   | 1.5–2m between plants                           |
| P11 | Edelweiss                        | <i>Leontopodium alpinum</i>        | 6.5–7.5 | Crown at soil level               | ✅ Trough/rockery, 5L                  | ☀️             | Sempervivum, saxifrage, other alpins                   | 15–20cm between plants                          |
| P12 | Elephant's Ears                  | <i>Bergenia</i> spp.               | 5.5–8.0 | Rhizome at/just below surface     | ✅ 25–35cm / 10L+                      | 🌑 to ☀️        | Hostas, hellebores, snowdrops, ferns                   | 30–60cm between plants                          |

| #   | English Name                                  | Latin Name                                        | pH      | Planting Depth                            | In Pot?                                              | Light          | Key Companions                                         | Spacing                                                    |
|-----|-----------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------|---------|-------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------|----------------|--------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------|
| P14 | Foxglove                                      | <i>Digitalis purpurea</i>                         | 5.5–7.5 | At pot level; seeds on surface            | ✅ 30cm / 10L+ deep                                   | ☁️             | Ferns, hostas, roses, alliums; self-seeds              | 30–45cm between plants                                     |
| S4d | Fortune's Holly Fern (var. <i>clivicola</i> ) | <i>Cyrtomium fortunei</i> var. <i>clivicola</i>   | 6.0–8.0 | At pot level; crown at/just below surface | ✅ 30–40cm / 15L+                                     | ☀️ to 🌑        | Hostas, hellebores, snowdrops; tolerates dry shade     | 45–60cm between plants                                     |
| B9  | Fox's Grape Fritillary                        | <i>Fritillaria uva-vulpis</i>                     | 6.0–7.5 | 10cm deep; autumn                         | ✅ Raised bed/trough/pot                              | ☀️ to ☀️       | Other species fritillarias, dwarf iris, crocus         | 8–10cm between bulbs                                       |
| B10 | Freesia                                       | <i>Freesia</i> spp.                               | 6.0–7.0 | 5–8cm deep; spring, lift & store          | ✅ Best in containers (tender)                        | ☀️             | Ixia and other tender corms                            | 5–8cm between corms                                        |
| B3  | Fritillaria meleagris (Checkered Lily)        | <i>Fritillaria meleagris</i>                      | 6.0–7.0 | 10cm deep; autumn                         | ✅ 5L+ container                                      | ☀️             | Snowdrops, daffodils, damp border/pond-margin planting | 8–10cm between bulbs                                       |
| B11 | Fritillaria michailovskyi                     | <i>Fritillaria michailovskyi</i>                  | 6.0–7.5 | 8–10cm deep; autumn                       | ✅ Trough/raised bed/pot                              | ☀️             | Dwarf iris, crocus, other alpine bulbs                 | 8–10cm between bulbs                                       |
| T8  | Fuzzy Pride-of-Rochester                      | <i>Deutzia scabra</i>                             | 6.0–7.5 | At nursery soil mark                      | ⚠️ Large 80–100L container                           | ☀️ to ☀️       | Mock orange, lilac, weigela, spring bulbs              | 1.5–2m between plants; grows 1.8–3m tall                   |
| B26 | Gagea (Yellow Star-of-Bethlehem)              | <i>Gagea lutea</i>                                | 6.5–7.5 | 5–8cm deep; autumn                        | ✅ 5L+ container                                      | ☁️             | Snowdrops, wood anemones                               | 5–8cm between bulbs                                        |
| F7  | Garden Plum                                   | <i>Prunus domestica</i>                           | 6.0–7.0 | Graft union at/above soil                 | ⚠️ Half-barrel (50L+)                                | ☀️             | Chives, garlic, comfrey, nasturtiums                   | 3–5m between trees depending on rootstock; permanent stake |
| B27 | Giant Onion                                   | <i>Allium giganteum</i>                           | 6.0–7.5 | 20cm deep (2–3× bulb depth); autumn       | ✅ Large 5L+ container                                | ☀️             | Roses, peonies, ornamental grasses                     | 25–30cm between bulbs                                      |
| B28 | Golden Garlic                                 | <i>Allium moly</i>                                | 6.0–7.5 | 8–10cm deep; autumn                       | ✅ 3–5L container                                     | ☀️             | Dwarf iris, crocus, other rockery bulbs                | 10–15cm between bulbs                                      |
| F8  | Gooseberry                                    | <i>Ribes uva-crispa</i>                           | 6.0–7.5 | At nursery mark; roots 5cm                | ⚠️ 30L+ large pot                                    | ☀️             | Redcurrant, whitecurrant, tansy                        | 1.5m between plants                                        |
| H5  | Green Onions (Scallions)                      | <i>Allium fistulosum</i>                          | 6.0–7.0 | 1cm deep (seed) / at pot level            | ✅ 5L+ container                                      | ☀️ to ☀️       | Carrots, rocket, radish                                | 5–8cm between plants; sow successionally                   |
| C6  | Hardy Grapes                                  | <i>Vitis vinifera</i>                             | 6.0–6.5 | At pot depth; graft above soil            | ⚠️ 40L+ container                                    | ☀️ (essential) | Lavender, rosemary, garlic, hyssop                     | 1.2–1.5m between vines; 20cm from wall                     |
| P16 | Hellebore / Lenten Rose                       | <i>Helleborus</i> spp.                            | 6.0–8.0 | At pot level; crown at/just below         | ✅ 25–35cm / 10L+                                     | ☁️ to 🌑        | Snowdrops, cyclamen, pulmonaria, hostas                | 45–60cm between plants                                     |
| T9  | Holly                                         | <i>Ilex aquifolium</i>                            | 4.5–8.0 | At pot level (shallow roots)              | ⚠️ 50L+ container                                    | 🌑 to ☀️        | Yew, forsythia, hellebores; plant ♂ + ♀ for berries    | 1.5–3m between; slow-growing hedge                         |
| F9  | Honeyberry (Kamchatka)                        | <i>Lonicera caerulea</i> var. <i>kamtschatica</i> | 4.5–7.5 | At pot level                              | ⚠️ 50–75L (15–20 gal.)                               | ☀️             | Blueberry, lingonberry; needs 2+ varieties             | 1–1.5m between plants                                      |
| C7  | Hops                                          | <i>Humulus lupulus</i>                            | 6.0–8.0 | Rhizome 5–8cm / pot level                 | ✅ 50L+ large container                               | ☀️             | Climbing roses, clematis, ornamental grasses           | 1–1.5m between plants                                      |
| P17 | Hosta / Plantain Lily                         | <i>Hosta</i> spp.                                 | 6.0–8.0 | At pot level; crown at surface            | ✅ 30–60cm / 20–50L+                                  | ☁️ to 🌑        | Astilbe, ferns, hellebores, bergenia                   | 30–90cm (variety-dependent)                                |
| T18 | Hypericum 'Rowallane'                         | <i>Hypericum</i> 'Rowallane'                      | 5.5–7.5 | At nursery soil mark                      | ⚠️ 40–50L container                                  | ☀️ to ☀️       | Heather, skimmia, roses, late perennials               | 1–1.5m between plants                                      |
| G18 | Irish Heath                                   | <i>Erica erigena</i>                              | 5.5–7.5 | At pot level                              | ✅ 20–25cm / 5–10L ericaceous or multipurpose compost | ☀️             | Blueberry, lingonberry, deer fern, ornamental grasses  | 45–60cm between plants                                     |

| #   | English Name              | Latin Name                                | pH             | Planting Depth                               | In Pot?                                  | Light    | Key Companions                                 | Spacing                                                     |
|-----|---------------------------|-------------------------------------------|----------------|----------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------|----------|------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------|
| S2  | Irish Native Mosses       | <i>various spp.</i>                       | 5.0–6.5 (most) | Surface transplant, not buried               | ✅ Shallow tray/log/pot                   | ☀️ to 🌑  | Ferns, wood sorrel, primroses                  | Establish as patches; keep consistently moist               |
| T10 | Irish Yew                 | <i>Taxus baccata</i> 'Fastigiata'         | 5.0–8.0        | At pot level                                 | ⚠️ 50L+ container                        | 🌑 to ☀️  | Holly, peonies, roses (backdrop), hellebores   | Column 1m wide eventually; 1m from structures               |
| B12 | Iron Cross (Oxalis)       | <i>Oxalis tetraphylla</i> 'Iron Cross'    | 6.0–7.0        | 5cm deep; spring, lift & store               | ✅ 3–5L container                         | ☀️ to ☀️ | Ixia, dwarf dahlias, other summer bulbs        | 10–15cm between tubers; lift over winter                    |
| C8  | Ivy                       | <i>Hedera helix</i> / <i>H. hibernica</i> | 5.0–8.0        | At pot level                                 | ✅ 20L+ (25–35cm pot)                     | 🌑 to ☀️  | Virginia creeper, ferns, snowdrops, bluebells  | 30–50cm between plants                                      |
| B4  | Ixia                      | <i>Ixia</i> spp.                          | 6.0–7.0        | 8–10cm deep; spring, lift & store            | ✅ Best in containers (borderline hardy)  | ☀️       | Freesia and other tender corms                 | 5–8cm between corms                                         |
| B2b | Japanese / Autumn Anemone | <i>Anemone × hybrida</i>                  | 6.0–7.5        | At pot level; spring                         | ✅ 40–50cm / 30L+                         | ☁️       | Hostas, astilbe, hellebores                    | 45–60cm between plants; can spread                          |
| T11 | Japanese Camellia         | <i>Camellia japonica</i>                  | 5.0–6.5        | At nursery soil mark                         | ✅ 40–50L ericaceous compost              | ☀️       | Skimmia, hydrangea macrophylla, Japanese maple | 1–1.5m between plants                                       |
| T20 | Japanese Cedar            | <i>Cryptomeria japonica</i>               | 5.5–6.5        | At nursery soil mark                         | ✅ Large container for dwarf cultivars    | ☀️ to ☁️ | Japanese maple, camellia, rhododendron, ferns  | 4–6m between plants; dwarf cultivars 1–1.5m                 |
| T12 | Japanese Maple            | <i>Acer palmatum</i>                      | 5.5–6.5        | At pot level (shallow)                       | ✅ 50–80L terracotta/stone                | ☀️       | Hostas, ferns, hellebores, snowdrops           | 2–4m from structures; wind shelter essential                |
| T13 | Japanese Skimmia          | <i>Skimmia japonica</i>                   | 5.5–6.5        | At nursery soil mark                         | ✅ 30–40L container                       | 🌑 to ☀️  | Hellebores, ferns, hostas, Japanese maple      | 60–90cm between plants; ♂+♀ within a few metres for berries |
| G5  | Juniper 'Repanda'         | <i>Juniperus communis</i> 'Repanda'       | 4.5–7.5        | At pot level, ~15cm deep                     | ⚠️ Large shallow container               | ☀️       | Heather, sempervivum, saxifrage                | 1–1.5m for ground cover                                     |
| C9  | Kiwi 'Jenny'              | <i>Actinidia deliciosa</i> 'Jenny'        | 6.0–7.0        | At pot level; do not bury crown              | ⚠️ Min. 60–80L (better in ground)        | ☀️       | Climbing roses, wisteria, lavender, garlic     | 3–5m between plants; needs permanent support                |
| S4e | Koidzumi's Wood Fern      | <i>Dryopteris koidzumiana</i>             | 5.5–7.0        | At pot level; crown at/just below surface    | ✅ 40–50cm / 25–30L                       | ☀️ to 🌑  | Hostas, astilbe, hellebores, bamboo            | 60cm between plants                                         |
| P18 | Lady's Bedstraw           | <i>Galium verum</i>                       | 6.0–7.5        | Crown at soil level                          | ✅ 5L+ container                          | ☀️       | Ox-eye daisy, yarrow, wild grasses             | 20–30cm between plants                                      |
| H6  | Lavender                  | <i>Lavandula angustifolia</i>             | 6.5–8.0        | At pot level                                 | ✅ Terracotta 20–30L, with grit           | ☀️       | Roses, rosemary, thyme                         | 30–45cm between plants                                      |
| T14 | Lewis Mock Orange         | <i>Philadelphus lewisii</i>               | 6.0–7.5        | At nursery soil mark                         | ⚠️ 50L+ container                        | ☀️ to ☀️ | Deutzia, lilac, roses, spring bulbs            | 1.5–2m between plants                                       |
| T15 | Lilac                     | <i>Syringa vulgaris</i>                   | 6.5–8.0        | At nursery soil mark                         | ❌ Too large                              | ☀️       | Roses, alliums, peonies, irises                | 1.5m between; 2m from walls                                 |
| B13 | Lily                      | <i>Lilium</i> spp.                        | 6.0–7.0        | 15cm (3× bulb height) on grit; autumn/spring | ✅ 30–40cm / 15–25L                       | ☀️       | Hostas, geraniums, roses, alliums              | 15–30cm between bulbs                                       |
| P19 | Lilyleaf Ladybells        | <i>Adenophora liliifolia</i>              | 6.0–7.5        | Crown at soil level                          | ⚠️ 20L+ container (dislikes disturbance) | ☀️ to ☁️ | Bellflowers, delphiniums, phlox                | 30–40cm between plants                                      |
| F10 | Lingonberry               | <i>Vaccinium vitis-idaea</i>              | 4.2–5.5        | At pot level                                 | ✅ 25–30cm / 10–15L                       | ☁️       | Blueberry, heather, cranberry, deer fern       | 30cm between plants                                         |
| P25 | Linum (Perennial Flax)    | <i>Linum perenne</i>                      | 6.0–7.5        | Crown at soil level                          | ✅ 10–15L container                       | ☀️       | Yarrow, lavender, drought-tolerant perennials  | 20–30cm between plants                                      |

| #   | English Name                | Latin Name                                           | pH                                   | Planting Depth                                                                        | In Pot?                                      | Light    | Key Companions                                      | Spacing                                          |
|-----|-----------------------------|------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------|----------|-----------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------|
| A5  | Love-in-a-Mist              | <i>Nigella damascena</i>                             | 6.0–7.5                              | 1cm deep (seed)                                                                       | ✅ 5L+ container                              | ☀️ to 🌤️ | Cornflower, poppies, briza maxima                   | 20cm between plants; annual, self-seeds freely   |
| P20 | Lungworts                   | <i>Pulmonaria</i> spp.                               | 6.0–7.5                              | Crown at soil level                                                                   | ✅ 15–20L container                           | 🌤️       | Hellebores, ferns, hostas                           | 30–40cm between plants; divide every 3–4 yrs     |
| P21 | Lupins                      | <i>Lupinus polyphyllus</i>                           | 5.5–6.5                              | Crown at soil level                                                                   | ⚠️ 20L+ container (dislikes disturbance)     | ☀️ to 🌤️ | Delphiniums, roses, foxgloves                       | 45–60cm between plants                           |
| P40 | Maiden Pink                 | <i>Dianthus deltoides</i>                            | 6.0–7.5                              | At pot level                                                                          | ✅ 15–20cm / 5L+                              | ☀️       | Phlox subulata, sempervivum, saxifrage              | 20–30cm between plants                           |
| S4a | Male Fern                   | <i>Dryopteris filix-mas</i>                          | 5.0–7.0                              | Crown 7–12cm above soil                                                               | ✅ 40–50cm / 30L+                             | 🌤️ to 🌑  | Hostas, astilbe, bamboo, snowdrops                  | 60–90cm between plants                           |
| S4f | Maidenhair Fern (Himalayan) | <i>Adiantum venustum</i>                             | 5.5–7.0                              | At pot level                                                                          | ✅ 25–30cm / 10–15L                           | 🌤️ to 🌑  | Hostas, hellebores, primroses, other woodland ferns | 20–30cm between plants                           |
| W4  | Marsh Marigold              | <i>Caltha palustris</i>                              | 6.0–7.5                              | Crown at soil level / shallow water                                                   | ✅ Aquatic basket, 3–5L                       | ☀️ to 🌤️ | Yellow flag iris, bogbean, ferns                    | 30–40cm between plants                           |
| W5  | Marsh Orchids               | <i>Dactylorhiza</i> spp.                             | 6.0–7.0                              | 5–8cm deep (tuber) / at pot level                                                     | ⚠️ Large container, kept constantly moist    | ☀️ to 🌤️ | Yellow flag iris, meadowsweet, ragged robin         | 15–20cm between plants; buy nursery stock only   |
| B14 | Martagon Lily               | <i>Lilium martagon</i>                               | 6.0–7.5                              | 15cm deep (3× bulb height); autumn/spring                                             | ✅ Large 20L+ container                       | 🌤️       | Hostas, ferns, hellebores; light woodland edge      | 20–30cm between bulbs                            |
| W6  | Meadowsweet                 | <i>Filipendula ulmaria</i>                           | 5.0–6.5                              | Crown at soil level                                                                   | ⚠️ Large 40–50cm / 30L+                      | ☀️ to 🌤️ | Yellow flag iris, bogbean, royal fern, astilbe      | 60cm between plants; can self-seed               |
| H7  | Melissa (Lemon Balm)        | <i>Melissa officinalis</i>                           | 6.0–7.5                              | At pot level                                                                          | ✅ 15–20L container (to contain spread)       | ☀️ to 🌤️ | Brassicas, tomatoes                                 | 30–45cm between plants; spreads readily          |
| H8  | Mint                        | <i>Mentha</i> spp.                                   | 6.0–7.0                              | At pot level                                                                          | ✅ Essential (contains spread): 30cm / 10L+   | ☀️       | Near brassicas/tomatoes as repellent (in pots)      | 60cm if in ground with root barrier              |
| T16 | Mophead / Lacecap Hydrangea | <i>Hydrangea macrophylla</i>                         | 5.0–7.0 (blue 5.0–6.0; pink 6.0–7.0) | At pot level; rootball top slightly raised                                            | ✅ Excellent: 40cm compact / 50–60cm standard | 🌤️       | Astilbe, hostas, ferns, yarrow, heucheras           | 90cm–2.4m between (check label for variety size) |
| G13 | Mother of Thyme             | <i>Thymus serpyllum</i>                              | 6.0–8.0                              | At pot level                                                                          | ✅ Terracotta 20cm / 5L+ with grit            | ☀️       | Rosemary, oregano, lavender, creeping juniper       | 20–30cm between plants                           |
| T17 | Mountain Ash (Rowan)        | <i>Sorbus aucuparia</i>                              | 5.0–7.0                              | At nursery soil mark                                                                  | ⚠️ 80–100L container                         | ☀️ to 🌤️ | Holly, hawthorn, ferns, foxgloves, hellebores       | 3–5m from structures                             |
| B29 | Naples Garlic               | <i>Allium cowanii</i> (syn. <i>A. neapolitanum</i> ) | 6.0–7.5                              | 8–10cm deep; autumn                                                                   | ✅ 3–5L container                             | ☀️       | Crocus, dwarf iris, other small spring bulbs        | 10–15cm between bulbs                            |
| H10 | Nasturtiums                 | <i>Tropaeolum majus</i>                              | 6.0–7.5                              | 1–2cm deep (seed)                                                                     | ✅ 5L+ container                              | ☀️ to 🌤️ | Apples, brassicas, cucumbers (trap crop)            | 20–30cm between plants; annual, self-seeds       |
| B15 | Native Bluebells            | <i>Hyacinthoides non-scripta</i>                     | 6.0–6.8                              | 8cm deep; autumn                                                                      | ✅ 5L+ container                              | 🌤️       | Ferns, hostas, primroses, wood anemones             | 8–10cm between bulbs                             |
| W7  | Native White Water Lily     | <i>Nymphaea alba</i>                                 | 6.5–7.5 (water)                      | Crown at soil surface in basket; start 20–30cm below water surface, lower to 90–150cm | ✅ (pond basket essential): 30–40cm+ basket   | ☀️       | Yellow flag iris, bogbean, oxygenating plants       | 1.5–2m between plants; large ponds only          |
| H11 | Oregano / Wild Marjoram     | <i>Origanum vulgare</i>                              | 6.5–8.0                              | At pot level                                                                          | ✅ 25cm / 8L+                                 | ☀️       | Thyme, rosemary; pollinator attractor for fruit     | 30–45cm between plants                           |

| #   | English Name                         | Latin Name                               | pH      | Planting Depth                               | In Pot?                             | Light               | Key Companions                                   | Spacing                                                  |
|-----|--------------------------------------|------------------------------------------|---------|----------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------|---------------------|--------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------|
| B32 | Ostrowsky's Onion                    | <i>Allium oreophilum</i>                 | 6.0–7.5 | 8–10cm deep; autumn                          | ✅ 3–5L container                    | ☀️                  | Dwarf iris, crocus, other rockery bulbs          | 8–10cm between bulbs                                     |
| P13 | Paeonia tenuifolia (Fern-leaf Peony) | <i>Paeonia tenuifolia</i>                | 6.5–7.5 | Eyes 2–3cm below soil                        | ⚠️ 30–40L container                 | ☀️                  | Alliums, bearded iris, catmint                   | 45–60cm between plants                                   |
| P23 | Pasqueflower                         | <i>Pulsatilla vulgaris</i>               | 6.5–8.0 | At pot level; do not disturb                 | ✅ Essential on clay: 25–30cm / 10L+ | ☀️                  | Dianthus, Eryngium, Achillea, ornamental grasses | 20–30cm between plants                                   |
| C1  | Passiflora (Blue Passion Flower)     | <i>Passiflora caerulea</i>               | 6.0–7.5 | At nursery soil mark                         | ⚠️ 40–50L container against support | ☀️                  | Climbing roses, clematis, honeysuckle            | 2–3m between plants against wall/fence                   |
| P37 | Peach-leaved Bellflower              | <i>Campanula persicifolia</i>            | 6.0–7.5 | Crown at soil level                          | ✅ 15–20L container                  | ☀️ to 🌧️            | Delphiniums, roses, lupins                       | 30–45cm between plants; divide every 2–4 yrs             |
| P24 | Peony (herbaceous) ⚠️                | <i>Paeonia</i> spp.                      | 6.5–7.0 | Eyes MAX 2.5–5cm below soil                  | ⚠️ 50L+ large tub                   | ☀️ to 🌧️            | Alliums, irises, salvia, roses, foxgloves        | 90cm between plants                                      |
| G6  | Periwinkle                           | <i>Vinca minor</i> / <i>V. major</i>     | 5.5–8.0 | At pot level                                 | ✅ 25–35cm / 10L+                    | 🌑 to ☀️             | Hellebores, snowdrops, ivy; under trees/shrubs   | 30–45cm between plants; can spread                       |
| B17 | Persian Fritillary                   | <i>Fritillaria persica</i>               | 6.5–8.0 | 15–20cm deep, on its side; autumn            | ⚠️ Large gritty container           | ☀️                  | Tulips, alliums, euphorbia                       | 20–25cm between bulbs                                    |
| B18 | Persian Ranunculus                   | <i>Ranunculus asiaticus</i>              | 6.0–7.0 | 5–8cm deep; claws down; spring, lift & store | ✅ Better in pots: 25–30cm / 10L+    | ☀️                  | Pansies, muscari, spring anemones                | 15–20cm between tubers                                   |
| A4  | Phacelia                             | <i>Phacelia tanacetifolia</i>            | 6.0–7.5 | 1cm deep (seed)                              | ✅ 5L+ container                     | ☀️                  | Vegetable beds, fruit trees (pollinator support) | 20–30cm between plants; annual, sow successionaly        |
| P27 | Garden Pink                          | <i>Dianthus plumarius</i> (garden pinks) | 5.8–6.5 | At pot level                                 | ✅ 25–35cm / 10L+                    | ☀️                  | Roses, stocks, alliums, lavender, Phlox subulata | 25–35cm between plants                                   |
| F11 | Plum Tree 'Aprimira'                 | <i>Prunus domestica</i> 'Aprimira'       | 6.0–7.0 | Top of rootball just below surface           | ✅ 25cm+ pot, standard form          | ☀️                  | Chives, garlic                                   | 1–1.5m from structures; self-fertile                     |
| F12 | Pomegranate                          | <i>Punica granatum</i>                   | 5.5–7.0 | At nursery soil mark                         | ✅ Large 50L+ container, movable     | ☀️                  | Passiflora, grapevine on same warm wall          | 2–3m against wall; borderline hardy, best in a container |
| A6  | Poppies                              | <i>Papaver rhoeas</i>                    | 6.0–7.5 | Surface-sown (seed)                          | ✅ 5L+ container                     | ☀️                  | Cornflower, love-in-a-mist, briza maxima         | 15–20cm between plants; annual, self-seeds freely        |
| G7  | Prickly Heath                        | <i>Gaultheria mucronata</i>              | 4.5–6.0 | At nursery soil mark                         | ✅ 20–30L ericaceous compost         | ☀️ to 🌧️            | Heather, blueberry, lingonberry, dwarf conifers  | 45–60cm between plants; ♂+♀ for berries                  |
| S5  | Primroses                            | <i>Primula vulgaris</i>                  | 5.5–7.0 | Crown at soil level                          | ✅ 10–15L container                  | 🌧️                  | Bluebells, wood anemones, violets, ferns         | 20–25cm between plants                                   |
| B31 | Purple-flowered Onion                | <i>Allium atropurpureum</i>              | 6.0–7.5 | 20cm deep (2–3× bulb depth); autumn          | ✅ Large 5L+ container               | ☀️                  | Roses, peonies, ornamental grasses               | 25–30cm between bulbs                                    |
| H12 | Radish                               | <i>Raphanus sativus</i>                  | 6.0–7.0 | 1cm deep (seed)                              | ✅ 5L+ container                     | ☀️ to 🌧️            | Carrots, lettuce, green onions                   | 2–3cm between plants; sow successionaly                  |
| F13 | Raspberry                            | <i>Rubus idaeus</i>                      | 5.8–6.5 | Crown 5–7cm below soil                       | ❌                                   | 🌧️                  | Garlic, marigolds, tansy; away from potatoes     | 45–60cm between canes; 1.8m between rows                 |
| F14 | Redcurrant                           | <i>Ribes rubrum</i>                      | 6.0–7.5 | At nursery mark; roots 5cm                   | ⚠️ 30L+ large pot                   | 🌧️ (north fence ok) | Gooseberry, whitecurrant                         | 1.5m between plants                                      |
| G8  | Reindeer Lichen                      | <i>Cladonia rangiferina</i>              | 4.0–5.5 | Surface only, not buried                     | ⚠️ Shallow tray/rockery             | ☀️ to 🌧️            | Heather, sempervivum, open heath planting        | Establishes slowly; avoid disturbance                    |

| #   | English Name               | Latin Name                                      | pH      | Planting Depth                                             | In Pot?                                          | Light    | Key Companions                                           | Spacing                                       |
|-----|----------------------------|-------------------------------------------------|---------|------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------|----------|----------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------|
| F15 | Rhubarb                    | <i>Rheum × hybridum</i>                         | 6.0–7.0 | Buds 1–2cm below soil                                      | ⚠️ 50cm / 50L+ deep pot                          | ☀️       | Beans, peas nearby; away from fennel                     | 90cm between crowns                           |
| H13 | Rocket                     | <i>Eruca sativa</i>                             | 6.0–7.0 | 1cm deep (seed)                                            | ✅ 5L+ container                                  | ☀️ to 🌤️ | Radish, green onions, lettuce                            | 15–20cm between plants; sow successionally    |
| H14 | Rosemary                   | <i>Salvia rosmarinus</i>                        | 6.0–7.5 | At pot level                                               | ✅ Terracotta 20–30L, with grit                   | ☀️       | Brassicas, carrots, beans, thyme, lavender               | 45–60cm between plants                        |
| S6  | Round-Lobed Hepatica       | <i>Hepatica nobilis</i>                         | 6.0–7.5 | Crown at soil level                                        | ✅ 10–15L container                               | 🌤️       | Snowdrops, hellebores, wood anemones                     | 15–20cm between plants                        |
| S4b | Royal Fern                 | <i>Osmunda regalis</i>                          | 4.5–6.5 | Crown slightly above soil                                  | ❌ Too large                                      | ☀️ to 🌤️ | Hostas, iris, marginal aquatics, bamboo                  | 1–1.5m between plants                         |
| P8  | Rudbeckia 'Goldball'       | <i>Rudbeckia laciniata</i> 'Goldball'           | 5.5–7.0 | At pot level                                               | ⚠️ 40–50cm / 40L+ (very tall — better in ground) | ☀️       | Helenium, echinacea, salvias, ornamental grasses, asters | 60–90cm between; divide every 2–3 yrs         |
| G9  | Saxifrage                  | <i>Saxifraga</i> spp.                           | 6.0–7.5 | At pot level                                               | ✅ Trough/rockery, 3–5L                           | ☀️ to 🌤️ | Sempervivum, campanula saxifraga, dwarf bulbs            | 15–20cm between plants                        |
| H15 | Scurvy Grass               | <i>Cochlearia officinalis</i>                   | 6.5–7.5 | At pot level / surface-sown seed                           | ✅ 5L+ container                                  | ☀️ to 🌤️ | Sea kale, coastal edible plants                          | 15–20cm between plants                        |
| G4  | Sempervivum                | <i>Sempervivum</i> spp.                         | 6.0–7.5 | At pot level                                               | ✅ Shallow pot/trough, 3–5L                       | ☀️       | Saxifrage, wall pennywort, thyme, sedum                  | 10–15cm between rosettes                      |
| F16 | Serviceberry               | <i>Amelanchier lamarckii</i>                    | 5.5–7.0 | At nursery soil mark                                       | ⚠️ 50–80L container                              | ☀️ to ☀️ | Hellebores, snowdrops, ferns, Japanese maple             | 2–4m between plants/structures                |
| P28 | Siberian Statice           | <i>Goniolimon tataricum</i>                     | 6.0–7.5 | Crown at soil level                                        | ✅ 15–20L container                               | ☀️       | Ornamental grasses, achillea, sedum                      | 30–40cm between plants                        |
| B19 | Snowdrop                   | <i>Galanthus nivalis</i>                        | 5.5–7.0 | 10cm dry (autumn) / at growing depth in the green (spring) | ✅ 20–25cm / 5L+                                  | 🌤️ to 🌑  | Hellebores, aconites, early narcissus, cyclamen coum     | 8–10cm between bulbs                          |
| B20 | Snowflake (Summer)         | <i>Leucojum aestivum</i>                        | 5.5–7.0 | 8–10cm deep; autumn                                        | ✅ 30–40cm / 15L+                                 | ☀️       | Daffodils, snowdrops, hellebores; pond edges             | 8–10cm between bulbs                          |
| T7  | Sorbaria sorbifolia        | <i>Sorbaria sorbifolia</i>                      | 5.5–7.5 | At nursery soil mark                                       | ⚠️ 40–50L container                              | ☀️ to 🌤️ | Hydrangea, deutzia; good bank stabiliser                 | 1–1.5m between plants; spreads by suckers     |
| P29 | Spreading Bellflower       | <i>Campanula patula</i>                         | 6.0–7.5 | Crown at soil level / surface-sown seed                    | ✅ 10–15L container                               | ☀️ to 🌤️ | Ox-eye daisy, wild grasses                               | 20–30cm between plants; biennial/ short-lived |
| B2a | Spring Anemone             | <i>Anemone blanda</i> / <i>A. nemorosa</i>      | 5.5–7.0 | 5–8cm deep; autumn                                         | ✅ 20–25cm / 5L+                                  | 🌤️       | Snowdrops, bluebells, foxgloves                          | 10cm between corms                            |
| B21 | Spring Sowbread (Cyclamen) | <i>Cyclamen coum</i>                            | 6.0–7.5 | 2–3cm deep, flat side down; late summer/ autumn            | ✅ 3–5L container                                 | 🌤️       | Snowdrops, winter aconite, hellebores                    | 10–15cm between tubers                        |
| S7  | St Patrick's Cabbage       | <i>Saxifraga spathularis</i>                    | 5.0–6.0 | Crown at soil level                                        | ✅ 10–15L container/rockery                       | 🌤️ to 🌑  | Ferns, native mosses, shaded rockery plants              | 15–20cm between plants                        |
| T19 | Star Magnolia              | <i>Magnolia stellata</i>                        | 5.0–6.5 | At pot level; no deeper                                    | ✅ 80–100L stone/terracotta                       | ☀️       | Snowdrops, daffodils, hellebores, hardy geraniums        | 2.5m spread; shelter from N/E winds           |
| P30 | Stocks                     | <i>Matthiola incana</i> / <i>M. longipetala</i> | 6.5–7.5 | At pot level; seeds on surface                             | ✅ 25–30cm / 10L+                                 | ☀️       | Wallflowers, sweet William, pansies                      | 20–30cm between plants                        |
| F17 | Strawberry                 | <i>Fragaria × ananassa</i>                      | 5.5–6.8 | Crown exactly at soil level                                | ✅ 30–35cm / 15–20L per plant                     | ☀️       | Borage, garlic, chives, marigolds                        | 30–45cm between plants                        |

| #   | English Name           | Latin Name                                   | pH                     | Planting Depth                            | In Pot?                                              | Light  | Key Companions                                           | Spacing                                        |
|-----|------------------------|----------------------------------------------|------------------------|-------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------|--------|----------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------|
| F18 | Sweet Cherry 'Sylvia'  | <i>Prunus avium</i> 'Sylvia'                 | 6.0–7.0 (well-drained) | ~12cm / graft union at soil level         | ✔ Large patio pot                                    | ☀ to ☀ | Chives, garlic                                           | 1m spacing; self-fertile                       |
| A7  | Sweet Peas             | <i>Lathyrus odoratus</i>                     | 6.0–7.5                | 2cm deep (seed)                           | ✔ Large 20L+ container with support                  | ☀      | Climbing roses, clematis; vegetable garden               | 15–20cm between plants against support         |
| P31 | Sweet William          | <i>Dianthus barbatus</i>                     | 5.8–6.5                | At pot level                              | ✔ 25–30cm / 10L+                                     | ☀      | Pinks, stocks, foxgloves, wallflowers, roses             | 30cm between plants                            |
| P32 | Toadflax               | <i>Linaria vulgaris</i>                      | 6.0–7.5                | Crown at soil level / surface-sown seed   | ✔ 5L+ container                                      | ☀ to ☀ | Ox-eye daisy, yarrow, wildflower meadow                  | 20–30cm between plants; spreads readily        |
| G19 | Tree Heath             | <i>Erica arborea</i>                         | 5.0–6.5                | At pot level                              | ⚠ Large 40–50L container                             | ☀      | Blueberry, lingonberry, ornamental grasses               | 1–1.5m between plants                          |
| P15 | Trollius (Globeflower) | <i>Trollius europaeus</i>                    | 5.5–7.0                | Crown at soil level                       | ✔ 20–30L container, keep moist                       | ☀ to 🌧 | Astilbe, hosta, candelabra primulas                      | 30–40cm between plants                         |
| B22 | Tulip                  | <i>Tulipa</i> spp.                           | 6.0–7.0                | 20cm (3× bulb height); autumn             | ✔ Excellent: 25–30cm / 10L+                          | ☀      | Forget-me-nots, daffodils, alliums, wallflowers          | 10–15cm between bulbs                          |
| B23 | Turkestan Tulip        | <i>Tulipa turkestanica</i>                   | 6.0–7.5                | 10cm deep; autumn                         | ✔ Raised bed/pot                                     | ☀      | Crocus, dwarf iris, other early species bulbs            | 8–10cm between bulbs                           |
| P33 | Vervain                | <i>Verbena officinalis</i>                   | 6.0–7.5                | Crown at soil level                       | ✔ 10–15L container                                   | ☀ to ☀ | Lavender, catmint, ornamental grasses                    | 20–30cm between plants                         |
| C10 | Vicia (Tufted Vetch)   | <i>Vicia cracca</i>                          | 6.0–7.5                | 1–2cm (seed) / at pot level               | ✔ 5L+ container                                      | ☀ to ☀ | Grasses, wildflower meadow species, hedgerow shrubs      | 20–30cm between plants; scrambles via tendrils |
| C11 | Virginia Creeper       | <i>Parthenocissus quinquefolia</i>           | 5.5–7.5                | At pot level                              | ✔ 30–40L container                                   | ☀      | Ivy (same wall), late clematis                           | 1.5–3m between plants                          |
| G11 | Wall Pennywort         | <i>Umbilicus rupestris</i>                   | 6.0–7.5                | At pot level / wall crevice               | ✔ Small pot or wall crevice                          | 🌧      | Ivy, ferns, sempervivum, saxifrage                       | 15–20cm between plants                         |
| B24 | Whittall's Tulip       | <i>Tulipa orphanidea</i>                     | 6.0–7.5                | 10–15cm deep; autumn                      | ✔ Raised bed/pot                                     | ☀      | Crocus, grape hyacinth, other species tulips             | 8–10cm between bulbs                           |
| G14 | Wild Thyme             | <i>Thymus polytrichus</i>                    | 6.5–7.5                | At pot level                              | ✔ Trough/rockery, 3–5L                               | ☀      | Sempervivum, saxifrage, wall pennywort                   | 20–30cm between plants; spreads by runners     |
| B25 | Wild Tulip             | <i>Tulipa sylvestris</i>                     | 6.0–7.5                | 10–15cm deep; autumn                      | ✔ 5L+ container                                      | ☀ to ☀ | Daffodils, other naturalising bulbs                      | 10–15cm between bulbs                          |
| G17 | Winter Heath           | <i>Erica carnea</i>                          | 5.5–7.5                | At pot level                              | ✔ 20–25cm / 5–10L ericaceous or multipurpose compost | ☀      | Blueberry, lingonberry, deer fern, ornamental grasses    | 30–45cm between plants                         |
| C12 | Wisteria               | <i>Wisteria sinensis</i> / <i>floribunda</i> | 6.0–7.0                | At pot level; graft above soil            | ⚠ 45cm/60L+ container                                | ☀      | Climbing roses (same wall), alliums, irises              | 45cm from wall; 3m between plants              |
| S9  | Wood Sorrel            | <i>Oxalis acetosella</i>                     | 5.0–6.5                | Crown at soil level                       | ✔ 5L+ container                                      | 🌑 to 🌧 | Ferns, native mosses, primroses                          | 10–15cm between plants                         |
| F19 | Woodland Strawberry    | <i>Fragaria vesca</i>                        | 5.5–7.0                | Crown at soil level                       | ✔ 20–30L container                                   | ☀ to 🌧 | Ferns, hostas, primroses                                 | 25–30cm between plants; spreads by runners     |
| P34 | Yarrow                 | <i>Achillea millefolium</i>                  | 5.5–7.0                | At pot level; bare-root buds 2–3cm below  | ✔ 30cm / 10L+                                        | ☀      | Roses, salvia, echinacea, hydrangea, ornamental grasses  | 30–60cm between plants; divide every 2–3 yrs   |
| P35 | Siberian Iris          | <i>Iris sibirica</i>                         | 5.8–7.0                | Rhizome at/just below surface (2–3cm max) | ✔ 35–40cm / 15–20L                                   | ☀ to ☀ | Astilbe, hostas, yellow flag iris, daylilies, royal fern | 30–45cm between plants; divide every 3–5 yrs   |

| #   | English Name         | Latin Name                 | pH      | Planting Depth                          | In Pot?                      | Light  | Key Companions                                | Spacing                                      |
|-----|----------------------|----------------------------|---------|-----------------------------------------|------------------------------|--------|-----------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------|
| P36 | Yellow Flag Iris     | <i>Iris pseudacorus</i>    | 5.5–8.0 | Crown at soil level; 0–20cm water above | ✔ 19–24cm aquatic basket     | ☀      | White water lily, bogbean, bog pimpernel      | 30–60cm between plants; divide every 2–3 yrs |
| W9  | Yellow Loosestrife   | <i>Lysimachia vulgaris</i> | 6.0–7.5 | Crown at soil level                     | ✔ 20L+ container, keep moist | ☀ to 🌧 | Meadowsweet, yellow flag iris, marsh marigold | 40–50cm between plants; spreads by rhizome   |
| H16 | Zucchini (Courgette) | <i>Cucurbita pepo</i>      | 6.0–7.0 | At pot level (after frost)              | ✔ Large 30–40L container     | ☀      | Nasturtiums, sweetcorn, beans                 | 60–90cm between plants                       |

## KEY GROUPS

### Ericaceous plants (acid-lovers — never add lime near these):

Blueberry · Heather (*Calluna vulgaris*) · Heather (*Erica* spp.) · Lingonberry · Cranberry · Japanese Maple (partial) · Deer Fern · Royal Fern · Japanese Skimmia · Dicksonia antarctica (partial) · Japanese Camellia · Prickly Heath · St Patrick's Cabbage

### Best clay-tolerant plants on your list:

Virginia Creeper · Ivy · Hops · Bamboo (clump-forming) · Astilbe · Japanese Anemone · Bergenia · Hellebore · Male Fern · Royal Fern · Forsythia · Blackcurrant · Blackberries · Honeyberry · Hostas · Holly · Irish Yew · Climbing Hydrangea · Hydrangea macrophylla · Meadowsweet · Yellow Flag Iris · Snowflake (Leucojum) · Periwinkle · Native Bluebells · Daylilies · Common Hawthorn · Mountain Ash (Rowan) · Sorbaria sorbifolia · Marsh Marigold · Trollius · Yellow Loosestrife

### Needs raised bed or exceptional drainage on Irish clay:

Rosemary · Lavender · Pasqueflower · Fritillaria imperialis · Acidanthera · Thyme · Creeping Juniper · Ranunculus · Tulips (or annual pots) · Dianthus pinks · Sweet William · Phlox subulata · Bearded Iris · Dwarf Iris · Allium · Sempervivum · Saxifrage · Campanula saxifraga · Edelweiss · Auricula · Siberian Statice · Linum

### Must be in containers on wet Irish clay:

Blueberry · Cranberry · Lingonberry (unless naturally acidic area) · Mint (to contain spread) · Melissa/Lemon Balm (to contain spread) · Pasqueflower (strongly recommended) · Ranunculus (best practice) · Rosemary (or raised bed) · Lavender (or raised bed) · Heather (if clay is not acidic enough) · Freesia (tender) · Ixia (borderline hardy) · Iron Cross Oxalis (lift over winter)

### Pond/water plants — water depth guide:

- **Deep water (90–150cm):** Native White Water Lily (*Nymphaea alba*)
- **Shallow water (0–25cm) / pond margin:** Yellow Flag Iris, Bogbean, Bog Pimpernel, Marsh Marigold
- **Bog/damp margin (not submerged but consistently moist):** Meadowsweet, Bog Pimpernel, Royal Fern, Astilbe, Trollius, Yellow Loosestrife, Marsh Orchids
- **Permanently wet, acid bog only:** Bog Asphodel

### Toxic plants — site away from children, pets and livestock:

Holly (berries) · Irish Yew (all parts except berry flesh) · Snowdrops · Daffodils · Bluebells (native and Spanish) · Fritillaria · Aconitum/Monkshood (all parts, sap irritates skin) · Convallaria/Lily of the Valley (all parts) · Adonis (all parts) · Bog Asphodel (foliage, to livestock) · Japanese Skimmia (berries, mildly)



Sources: RHS Growing Guides ([rhs.org.uk](https://rhs.org.uk)), [gardens4you.ie](https://gardens4you.ie) product listings (P22 rootstock; Sweet Cherry 'Sylvia'), Future Forests Ireland ([futureforests.ie](https://futureforests.ie)), Irish Seed Savers Association ([irishseedsavers.ie](https://irishseedsavers.ie)), NC State Extension Plant Toolbox ([plants.ces.ncsu.edu](https://plants.ces.ncsu.edu)), Plants For A Future ([pfaf.org](https://pfaf.org)), Missouri Botanical Garden Plant Finder, BBC Gardeners' World Magazine ([gardenersworld.com](https://gardenersworld.com)), Garden UK ([gardenuk.co.uk](https://gardenuk.co.uk)), Thompson & Morgan, Farmer Gracy, Wild Your Garden, Wetland Plants UK, Plants for Ponds, Pond Informer ([pondinformer.com](https://pondinformer.com)), White Flower Farm, Hydrangea.com, Plantura ([plantura.garden](https://plantura.garden)), Gardenia.net, Old Farmer's Almanac, Hardy Plant Society, Sarah Raven, Wilson Bros Gardens, Garden Design ([gardendesign.com](https://gardendesign.com)), Wayside Gardens, GrowItBuildIt.com, Trehane Nursery, Primrose Hall Peonies, Pomona Fruits, Ashridge Trees, Wildflowers of Ireland ([wildflowersofireland.net](https://wildflowersofireland.net)), Flora of Northern Ireland ([habitas.org.uk](https://habitas.org.uk)), BSBI ([bsbi.org](https://bsbi.org)), First Nature ([first-nature.com](https://first-nature.com)), British Bryological Society ([britishbryologicalsociety.org.uk](https://britishbryologicalsociety.org.uk)), Woodland Trust ([woodlandtrust.org.uk](https://woodlandtrust.org.uk)), Irish Peatland Conservation Council ([ipcc.ie](https://ipcc.ie)).